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04 Content Marketing Strategy

What's inside: This chapter look at **brands** as publishers who need to understand those for whom they are producing content. **Content marketing strategy** is explained and situated within the greater marketing mix. **Organisational** and **conceptual requirements** are considered in line with your overall marketing strategy.

4.1 Introduction

While the phrase 'content is king' has been referenced for some time, it is only in the recent few years that Content Marketing Strategy has been solidified into a discipline of its own. Defining content marketing strategy can be tricky, however, with some practitioners focusing more on the role it plays in information architecture and others believing that it should be considered on a campaign by campaign basis. This chapter looks at content marketing strategy from a holistic perspective, as a process that includes an understanding of all the content your brand is creating, those for whom it is intended, and to what purpose. There is a need to understand the brand and consumer context and match these to the best route to customer (in terms of tactics). Ultimately this supports the design of communication that impacts people enough to make them want to share the content on.

In this chapter, you will learn:

- To understand the role of content marketing strategy within your marketing plan
- To be familiar with the steps involved in developing your content marketing strategy
- To recognise some models for understanding how types of content are absorbed or experienced by your target audience.

4.2 Key terms and concepts

Term	Definition
Algorithm	An algorithm is a mathematical, computational or statistical method pre-determined to take a number of variables into account and output a single, quantifiable result that is a function of all the variables. A good example of a commonly used algorithm is the one used by Google to determine which pages rank more highly on SERPs.
Content audit	An examination and evaluation of the existing content which a brand publishes.
Editor	A person who determines the ultimate content of a text, traditionally understood in the newspaper, magazine or publishing industry context.
Information architecture	The way data and content are organised, structured and labelled to support usability.
Persona	In this context, a character created to define a group of readers in order to speak to them as though they were a unique reader. Usually a hypothetical character created to represent and personify a set of traits.
Usability	A measure of how easy a system is to use. Sites with excellent usability fare far better than those that are difficult to use.

4.3 Defining Content marketing

Content marketing is an umbrella term, one which focuses on matching content (information or entertainment) to your customer needs at whichever stage they are in the buying cycle or customer journey. Unlike TV, where the advertiser pushes messages to a captive audience, the focus is on engaging content, which means that marketers must think like publishers (attracting an audience) rather than seeing themselves as advertisers (buying an audience) of a product. The Internet has, in many respects, cut out the middle man. Consumers and brands can now connect directly through a number of easily accessible online platforms.

The Content Marketing Institute offers the following definition:

> *Content marketing is a marketing technique of creating and distributing relevant and valuable content to attract, acquire, and engage a clearly defined and understood target audience – with the objective of driving profitable customer action* (Content Marketing Institute, 2013).

This definition applies to all the spaces in which you share content – your website, campaigns and competitions, a company blog or the social media space – as well as the way in which that information is shared.

Kristina Halvorson suggests the model illustrated below for approaching the different areas of content marketing strategy.

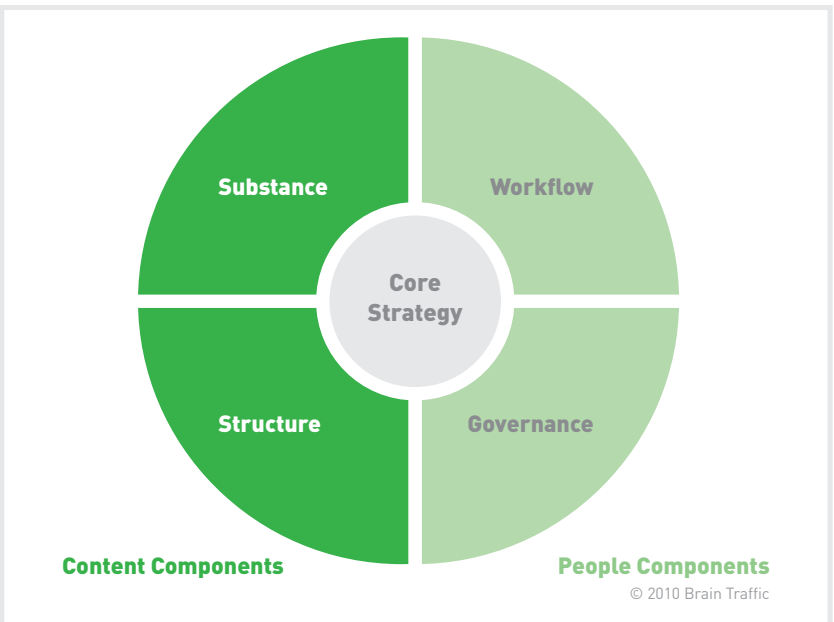

Figure 1. ***A model explaining Content Strategy. (Source: With permission, Kristina Halvorson, 2010)***

Content components

- **Substance**: Who are you trying to reach, and why?
- **Structure:** Where is your content? How is it organised? How do people find your content?

People components

- **Workflow:** How does your content happen?
- **Governance:** Politics, guidelines and standards (Halvorson, 2010).

As you can see in the above discussion, Halvorson suggests that one consider the bigger picture of content creation rather than just the product which is the end result. Content marketing looks at staff, tools, processes and outcomes. The end goal for these processes is, as outlined in the Content Marketing Institute definition, the delivery of a "profitable customer action". All content should be created with a strategic outcome in mind.

4.4 Strategic building blocks

4.4.1 Translating your brand essence

The brand essence is a sentence which sums up the unique attributes of a brand and the basis for its emotional connection with customers. Your brand essence should assist in defining a tone of voice for your brand and the style in which it engages with its customers. The brand essence can be a useful guide for ensuring that the content you create (and your marketing activity) represents the brand appropriately. Some relate this to your brand story. What is your reason for being, and how do you connect that with the interests of your customers?

Will it Blend? is a video series by Blendtec which builds on this principle. Blendtec produce industrial blenders. Their value proposition is that they can blend anything, and their very popular videos demonstrate this.

Figure 2. ***Blendtec produce a series of entertaining videos focused on blending objects discussed in popular culture, such as iPhones.***
(Source: Blendtec, n.d.)

4.4.2 Market research and consumer personas

The sweet spot for content marketing lies in an intercept between the marketing goals of a brand, the brand personality as it guides and differentiates that brand in the marketplace, and the consumer motivation for paying any attention to a brand at all. One device that is used in addressing consumer needs is the development of a consumer persona.

A persona is a profile that a writer creates to embody the characteristics of the target audience for whom he or she is writing.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Writing for Digital* chapter.

Personas are based on the profile of users of your content. Creating a profile is all about considering the characteristics of your readers and their needs and desires.

It's important to focus on the motivations of the persona that you may create, rather than exterior signifiers that lead to the creation of a stereotype. The persona assists you in segmenting and understanding your target market and is a framework through which you can guide any content that you create.

4.4.3 Creating content pillars

Linked to the brand identity are certain themes, which could also be called content pillars. These are areas of focus that support the creation of content that match to a consumer's interest. These themes must be true to the brand essence, not focused directly on sales, and should also speak to the interests of the audience.

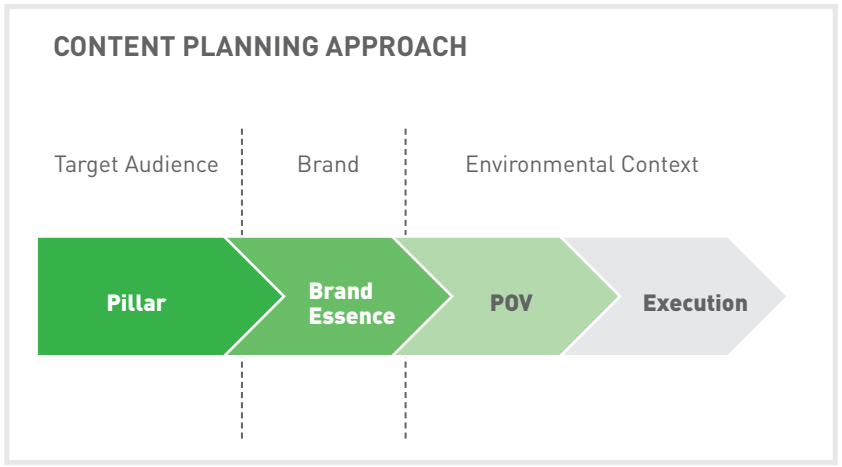

Figure 3. ***Content pillars can be considered in line with the brand's essence, and then situated within the context of the reader.***

For Coca-Cola, for example, consumer interests filtered through the brand essence of 'Coke brings joy' could result in the following pillars:

- Friendship
- Sharing is caring
- Spreading smiles.

These pillars are then used as the basis on which to develop content ideas.

Figure 4. ***Coca-Cola express their brand essence in all of their communications, as demonstrated in the Tweet above.***

In the above tweet, we can see how a particular content pillar was translated into a question that is focused on relationships and family. It also encourages engagement from the audience by asking for their input.

Another example which demonstrates this is how Corona brought their brand essence to life through an interactive documentary. The documentary depicted the first encounter that people from Bulin in China, 7 500km from the coast, had with the beach. You can view it here: http://www.coronaextra.eu.

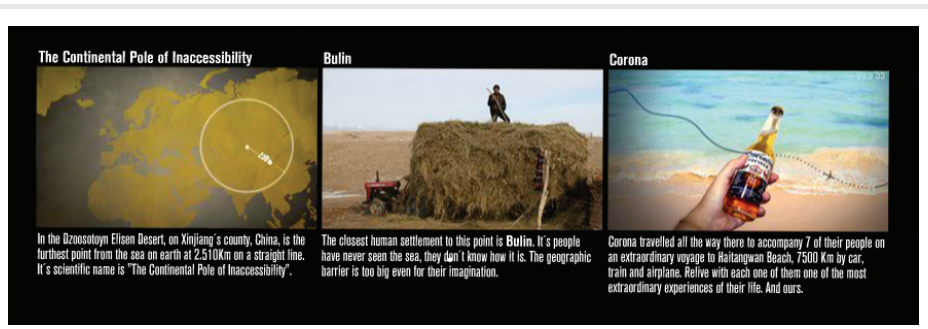

Figure 5. ***Corona created an interactive documentary that tied their brand essence to a powerful human story (http://www.coronaextra.eu/china/).***

4.4.4 Matching content formats to objectives

Information can be presented through any number of mediums, which is both an opportunity and a challenge faced by content marketers. Digital distribution allows for videos, images, interactive infographics and any number of other formats. To gain and keep the attention of consumers/users, it's sometimes not enough to rely simply on text-based forms of content. The role of the content marketer is to select the right medium based on overall objectives, production capabilities, and the needs of the audience. Consider the illustration below.

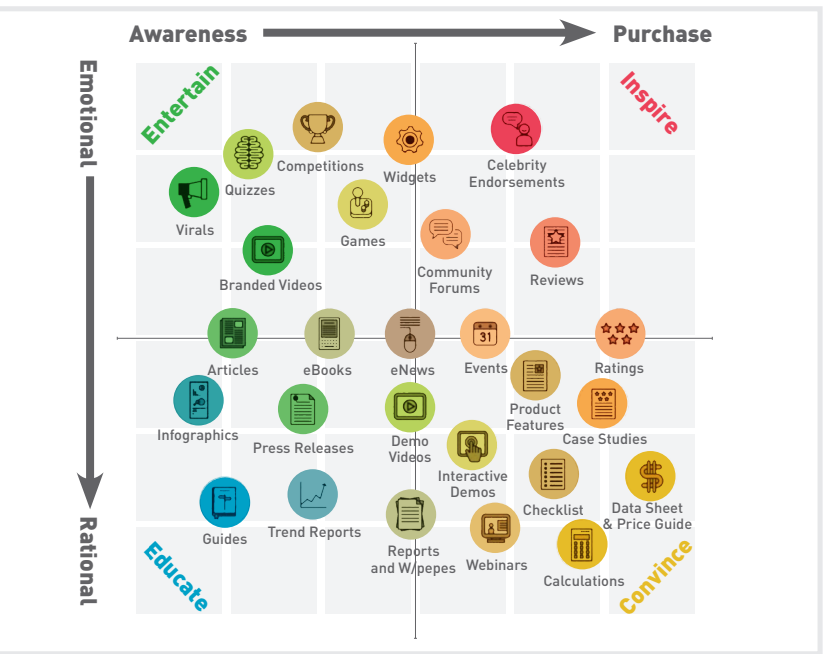

Figure 6. ***Different forms of content will support different objectives. (Adapted from Bosomworth, 2012)***

As discussed in the *Digital Marketing Strategy* chapter, determining your objectives is an essential part of your marketing planning, and should feed into your content marketing strategy. Understanding the journey your consumers go through as they approach your ultimate sales goal will enable you to match content formats to their needs. A humorous video may be successful in initially making potential customers aware of your brand. Once you have their attention, however, a research paper or useful case study could be more effective in convincing them that you are the best choice in the market.

There are many examples of online journalism using multimedia to convey information most effectively to their readers. *The New York Times* has presented a number of different methods for conveying complex information in an engaging manner. 'Snow Fall' by John Branch is one example (http://www.nytimes.com/projects/2012/snow-fall/#/?part=tunnel-creek).

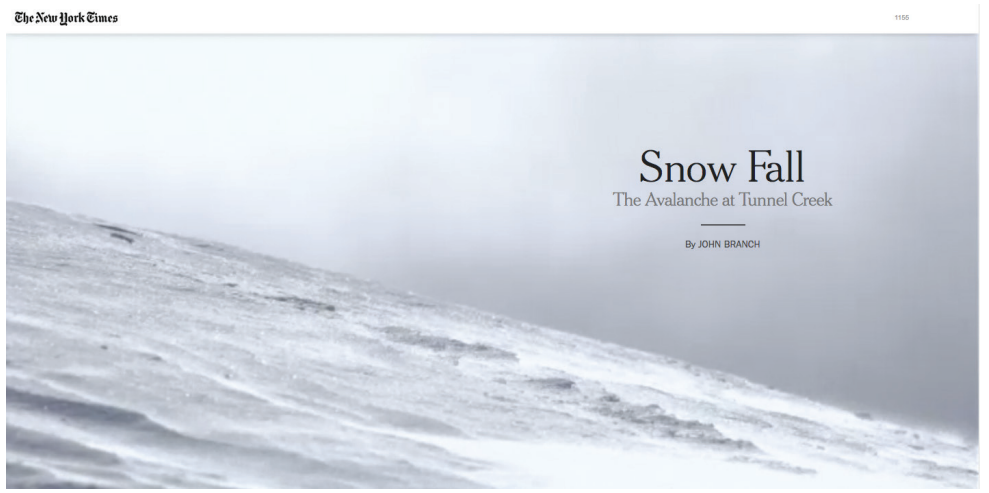

Figure 7. ***'The New York Times' is a media brand that has embraced interactive media features for presenting complex news stories. (Source: The New York Times)***

The New York Times also often publishes infographics that demonstrate this principle powerfully.

	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	Section	Page	URL	Description	Keep/Edit/Delete	Notes
2	About Us					
3		Vision	about-us/vision	Company vision statement, drawn from main brochure (now outdated)	Edit, add info from Mission page, add annual reports.	
4		Mission	about-us/mission	Company value statements. Seems to replicate Vision page. Includes links to annual reports (PDFs)	Delete	
5		The team	about-us/team	Lists bios of key staff members. Missing some staff, other bios 3-5 years out of date, some bios very brief, some very long.	Edit: update bios, edit to make more consistent. Add email addresses.	Second most-visited page in section.
6		Contact details	about-us/contact	Contact details: physical, phone, email. Includes operational hour info.	Update with Google map. Operational hours needs more prominence.	Most visited page in section
7		News	about-us/news	News items, currently divided into press releases; news; announcements; 'from the boss'. 32 items over 3 years.	Keep, but suggest deleting most old articles & removing categories.	
8		Events	about-us/event	Mixture of business and external events. No events loaded this year. 13 events over past 3 years.	Delete. Suggest publishing event info as news items & promoting on homepage.	

Figure 8. ***A content audit conducted for a website. (Source: Liubarets)***

In order to take advantage of these various forms of content delivery, it is necessary to build the correct capabilities. But how do you determine what forms of content you need?

4.4.5 The content audit

Once you have established your marketing goals, your brand personality and a guiding understanding of who you are trying to reach, the content audit is a sometimes laborious but necessary next step. The content audit involves an audit of all the existing content supplied by the brand – the website, white papers, articles, videos and content shared on social media sites can all be considered. An assessment can then be made of how well these pieces of content match the strategic needs of the brand and its audience.

While you can either thoroughly immerse yourself in this process or attempt to get a more time-efficient overview, the goal is to map what is currently on offer with what is necessary in mind. It is important not just to understand what you have, but also how it is currently organised and accessed by your audience.

Many practitioners suggest the use of a spreadsheet to achieve this. Content can be found to be either mismatched to the goals of the organisation, or spot on. Most importantly, you can establish what is missing. Are your customer needs being addressed? Where do the opportunities lie?

4.5 Content creation

4.5.1 Learning from publishers

The term **brand as publisher** refers to repositioning the function of the marketer or brand manager. Rather than focusing on the immediate sale or conversion, a publisher focuses on value and interest for the reader, and building a relationship based on supplying information or entertainment that suits the customer's needs. Makeup.com by L'Oreal is an oft-cited example of a brand publishing useful tips and content that does not link to a product or sales directly, but demonstrates how the brand can give consumers the lifestyle they desire.

4.5.2 Resource planning – thinking like a publisher

Content marketing touches on a number of departments in an organisation. Marketing, sales, customer service, corporate communications, human resources and website management teams should all be aware of the content marketing strategy for a business. Co-ordinating content between these teams can be challenging if not impossible if turnaround times are tight. This is why it is important not only to look at where content production should live in your organisation, but also to map the workflow of content creation, an essential function. Are designers involved? Where does quality control take place? Where can a piece of content be adapted and reused on a different distribution channel?

Some organisations opt to have a central role for someone who oversees content; others build in-house departments. Whether you are outsourcing to a publishing house, or training a team in house, the decision must be made and planned for so that workflow can be mapped in order to facilitate your strategic needs.

4.5.3 Always on content planning

Given that a large part of the global population is constantly engaging with content via various digital devices and platforms, it is necessary to consider content creation in terms of not only short campaign bursts, but ongoing delivery and engagement. Consider the illustration below.

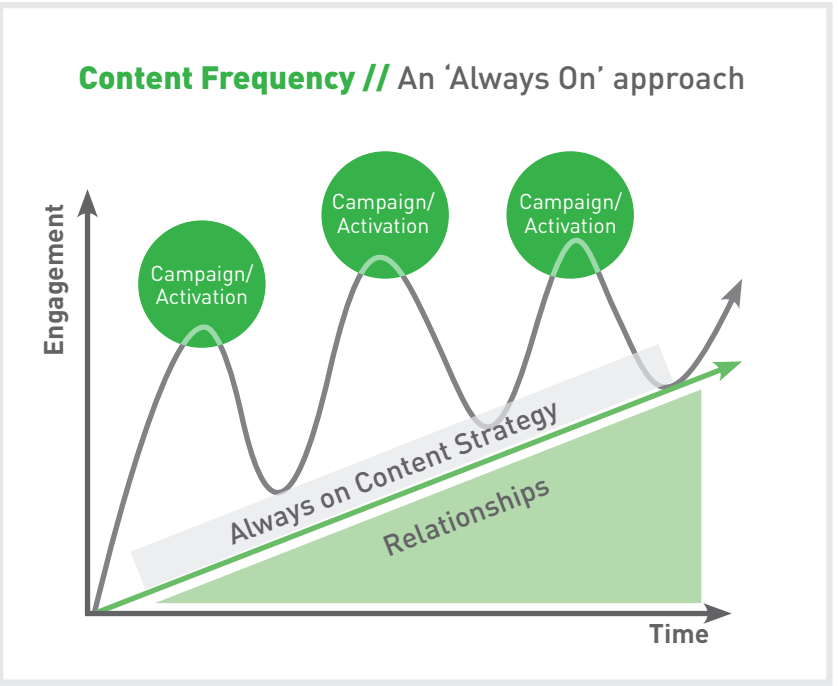

Figure 9. ***An always-on-content strategy approach builds relationships and engagement.***

By constantly engaging with audiences, something which is well suited to social media, for example, it is possible to build and maintain a relationship with customers/readers. Consider the image above, where constant engagement builds on the peaks of engagement that shorter term campaigns can offer.

4.5.4 Content models

Your organisation's content requirements and objectives should determine the structure of your content teams. Do you have a need for ongoing content creation, or are there less frequent high-input forms of content that will benefit your organisation? There are many models which are constantly evolving, so do invest in some research around what will suit your organisation. We have outlined two approaches below.

Stock and flow

Stock content refers to bigger, beautiful assets that require more investment and age well, meaning that they will be interesting in six months as well as today. 'The Dewarists', by Dewars, is an example of this. A high-production value TV show was created and sponsored by the brand in order to achieve awareness across its target market.

Figure 10. *'The Dewarists' was a TV show sponsored by alcohol brand, Dewars.*

Flow content has a lower production value and a quicker production and publishing time frame. Images depicting what is going on at a business on any given day, for example, freshly baked goods at a bakery, can be placed in this category.

Figure 11. *Cake Boss posts images depicting their preparations on their Facebook page.*

Both types of content should be considered for balancing out a content strategy.

Destination and distributed thinking

It can also be useful to consider destination and distributed content. Content which you are either sending out to the world through various platforms and networks, or which pulls your reader towards a page on your website or an article on your blog. Rather than focusing solely on driving readers to your owned media spaces, such as your website, consider how to create content that engages with your target audience in the spaces where they are active.

4.6 Content channel distribution

4.6.1 Algorithmic curation

Algorithmic curation is a term that refers to the algorithms platforms have created for dealing with information overload. Various platforms, like Facebook and the search engine Google, use algorithms to filter out the amount of information that is delivered to users. Each algorithm will use a number of factors to determine what is actually relevant and interesting to the person doing a search, or looking at their news feed. One of the factors that influences whether a piece of content is considered relevant is how much an individual engages with the brand's presence on that platform over time. Posts shared by a Facebook page, for example, may reach only users who have previously engaged with posts from that page through commenting or liking. It is therefore important to create content that encourages engagement and sharing.

4.6.2 Understanding your channels

Understanding the channels through which you share content is as important as the crafting of that content itself. Reaching people effectively will only be achieved if the medium supports the message and vice versa. Social media, email marketing, mobile marketing and video marketing are just some disciplines that will form part of your content creation arsenal. The rest of this book is dedicated to best practice in communicating effectively through the various digital disciplines available to you.

4.7 Tools of the trade

In order to support the ongoing production of interesting content, it is necessary to have some planning documents in place. Consider those outlined below.

- **Brand style guides**

  This document guides anyone creating content for a brand at any time. What is the tone of voice and brand personality? How is it best represented visually, and what are the brand colours and fonts? This can be a challenging document to put together, and it usually isn't the content marketer who is tasked with doing so, but is essential to aligning brand communications. It is also a document that tends to be 'live' – it is constantly updated as the brand and content landscapes evolve and new conventions need to come into play.

- ### Content calendars

  Content calendars assist the content marketer in planning the content they will be sharing, across which platforms, and when. The more advance planning is undertaken, the easier it is to react quickly to tactical opportunities.

- ### Workflow map

  A workflow map documents the path a piece of content takes when it is created. What are the steps in approval, how is it optimised for digital publishing, who has final sign off? Is it a duplicate of existing content, and where else can it be used? A workflow map assists you in streamlining this process.

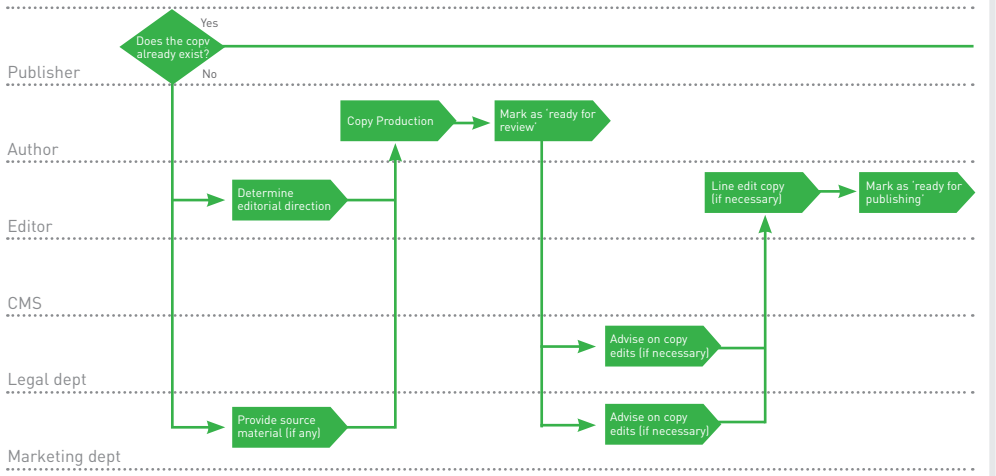

Figure 12. *An example of a workflow map for an article. (Adapted from: Ingserv)*

NOTE

See an example of a content calendar in the *Social Media Strategy* chapter, and an example of a persona in the *Writing for Digital* chapter.

- ### Persona map

  As discussed, the persona map assists content creators in focusing on those for whom they are in fact creating content, and what the motivations of consumers would be.

4.8 Advantages and challenges

Content marketing can position your brand as an expert through the sharing of useful content in your specific field. It also enables you to reach the customer who has a fragmented attention span spread across many devices and content touchpoints.

One of the more powerful benefits, however, is that you can learn a lot about your target consumer through the content with which they do or do not engage. The more targeted and ongoing your content, the more data you can gather about how effectively you are reaching those you need to.

One of the great challenges in content marketing is providing content that is truly interesting and engaging to the right people – the right mix of subject matter and brand. Matching content to the required outcome for your strategic purposes takes dedication and focus. In the context of ongoing content production, it can also be a challenge to maintain levels of quality over time, which is why process and quality assurance steps must be put in place. Consider that the goal is not to create as much content as possible, rather it is to focus on relevance and content that matches strategic outcomes.

4.9 Case study – Coca-Cola Company

4.9.1 One-line summary

Coca-Cola develops a content strategy in order to double sales by 2020 and redefine their business.

4.9.2 The problem

The Coca-Cola Company is a global beverage producer. Even though the brand is globally known and extremely successful, it has set its sights on doubling its business by 2020. It also noted two key changes in the market: consumers were creating an ever-increasing amount of brand content, and technology had empowered them as never before to shape the brand.

Coca-Cola decided that it needed to harness the power of content marketing in order to engage consumers.

4.9.3 The solution

In order to meet their goal of doubling the size of their business by 2020, Coca-Cola created a multifaceted content strategy based on two key content pillars: liquid and linked.

'Liquid' embodies the notion that our networked and connected world enables ideas to spread rapidly – liquid ideas are those that capture the imagination and cannot be controlled once they are put out in the world.

While liquid ideas are creative, they are grounded in a linked strategy. 'Linked' makes sure that ideas are always centred on the core brand story and experience – in other words, liquid ideas must reflect positively on the Coca-Cola brand. It also means that all the brand channels should be coherent and unified.

4.9.4 The outcome

Rather than focusing on traditional advertising, Coca-Cola has thrown its weight behind a global content strategy to meet its rather ambitious goals. It identified that audiences are now largely in control of the brand, and that it is more important to have an open conversation with them than to broadcast advertising at them.

Coca-Cola's content marketing plan is based on three core elements:

1. **Storytelling**: As part of the liquid principle, Coca-Cola has recognised the power of storytelling. Stories create an emotional connection, connect people and spread ideas, which leads to conversations. In dynamic storytelling, a brand idea is released to the audience and picked up in various conversations and channels. One of Coca-Cola's key brand stories is 'living positively' and showing how the brand makes the world a better place. This content idea also forms part of the company values, showing the importance of aligning business and content objectives. Each sub-brand has a big-picture content plan that outlines key elements of the story and how they will be disseminated.

2. **Consumer-generated content**: Consumer-generated content forms a cornerstone of the content strategy. Brand stories encourage consumer reactions and engagement (and are often created by the consumers themselves). The worldwide distribution of creativity and technology means that consumers have greater power than ever before to create and drive brand stories, which leads to emotional connections. Coca-Cola actively encourages fans to 'act and react' to the stories.

3. **Unified brand experience**: Finally, Coca-Cola puts a lot of emphasis on creating a unified, coherent and accessible brand experience. While there are many stories to be told about the brand, it is still necessary to filter and edit these to ensure that they speak to the brand's key values. By focusing on content excellence, Coca-Cola is creating value and engagement, not merely noise. Maintaining this means that the brand must communicate effectively with staff around the world.

In keeping with the 'linked' principle, these ideas will always be linked to business data and business objectives to solve problems (TheCognitiveMedia, n.d.).

Content on the web will spread regardless of whether a brand is involved or not – but Coca-Cola has picked up that they can steer the story themselves. By engaging proactively, building powerful, viral brand stories and giving consumers some control over how the brand is expressed, they are able to steer the conversation to their benefit – this is the true power of content marketing.

4.10 The bigger picture

Content is a significant component of many digital marketing disciplines. When creating content, you should always keep the principles of writing for the web in mind.

- **Email marketing** relies on great content – since most people suffer from email fatigue, they will only stop to read emails that they know are of high quality and that provide excellent content.
- **Social media marketing** also depends on sharing relevant and valuable content with social fans. While your brand promise may get them to your social page, your ongoing stream of quality content will encourage them to interact and share, spreading the word about your company.
- **Search engine optimisation** is strongly influenced by the quality, frequency and value of content. Not only will search engines favour your site, but others will choose to link in to your content, creating a valuable referrer for your brand.
- **Video marketing** is a whole new approach to content, in which you create dynamic and shareable videos specifically tailored to the interests and needs of your audience.
- **Mobile marketing** also requires that you consider the unique requirements of your audiences across a series of devices. If you understand the role that each device plays in a user's life and buying cycle, you can tailor content to optimally address their needs.

4.11 Summary

Content marketing presents a pull mechanism for the marketer rather than a push one. Brands must consider their brand identity and the market they are trying to reach in order to create targeted and valuable brand content that delivers on strategic objectives.

It's about more than creating a piece of content – content marketing strategy looks at how you structure your organisation to create that content, and how you match specific types of content and methods of delivery for achieving strategic outcomes.

These ideas need to resonate with people rather than simply existing across an array of media with which they are presented.

4.12 Case study questions

1. What is Coca Cola's overarching goal? Why is this significant?
2. What is brand storytelling?
3. What do you think about the content audit? Is it a process you would undertake?

4.13 Chapter questions

1. What is content marketing strategy?
2. Why is the customer journey or buying cycle relevant to content marketing strategy?
3. How do you decide what new forms of content your brand needs?

4.14 Further reading

http://contentstrategy.com/ – Content strategy for the web.

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11

Online Advertising

What's inside: An **introduction** to online advertising, a brief **history** following the development of the Internet and an exploration of **how it works**. We look at **types of display advertising, payment models, advertising networks** and **exchanges**. We also explore **ad servers** and what they do and learn more about how **tracking** works. We **put it all together** and take a **brief look at the future of online advertising** followed by an exploration into its **advantages** and **disadvantages**. Finally we include a **summary**, a look at the **bigger picture** and end off with a **case study**.

11.1 Introduction

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Search Advertising* chapter.

Online advertising, simply put, is advertising on the Internet. Online advertising encompasses display adverts found on websites, adverts on search engine results pages (covered in the chapter on *Search Advertising*), adverts placed in emails and on social networks, and other ways in which advertisers use the Internet. Of course, this is not just limited to computers – digital advertising can be found anywhere you access the web, for example, through mobile devices.

The main objectives of online advertising are to increase sales, improve brand awareness and raise share of voice in the marketplace. It is based on the simple economics of demand and supply. Advertisers aim to stimulate a consumer need (demand) and then satisfy that need (supply).

Online advertising, naturally, follows web user behaviour. Advertisers want to place their adverts where potential customers will see them. Digital advertising is not limited to one specific medium or location – it can be placed almost anywhere on the web and can consist of images, text, videos, interactive elements, and even games.

Although the Internet provides new scope for creative approaches to advertising, we see its true advantages when we realise how trackable (and therefore measurable) Internet advertising is. It is possible to track all interactions with the advert itself: the number of impressions served, how many clicks it received, post-click-and-view data, and how many unique users were reached. This leads to valuable data that can be used to make sensible, effective business decisions.

In this chapter, you will learn:

- The various business objectives you can meet with online advertising
- All about the various ad formats, payment models and ad types available
- How and where to publish your adverts
- How to run an online advertising campaign step by step

11.2 Key terms and concepts

Term	Definition
Ad server	The technology that places ads on websites.
Animated GIF	A GIF (type of image file) which supports animations and allows a separate palette of 256 colours for each frame.

Banner	An online advertisement in the form of a graphic image that appears on a web page.
Clickthrough rate (CTR)	Click Through Rate = Clicks / Impressions %
Conversion	A visitor completing a target action.
Cost per acquisition (CPA)	Refers to the cost of acquiring a new customer. The advertiser pays only when a desired action is achieved (sometimes called cost per acquisition).
Cost per click (CPC)	Refers to when an advertiser pays only when their ad is clicked on, giving them a visitor to their site – typically from a search engine in pay per click search marketing.
Cost per mille (CPM)	Amount paid for every 1 000 impressions served of an advertisement.
Display network	Content websites that serve pay per click adverts from the same provider, such as AdWords.
Google AdWords	Google's PPC program, which allows advertisers to display their adverts on relevant search results and across Google's content network.
HyperText Markup Language (HTML)	A language read by web browsers. Certain HTML 'tags' are used to structure the information and features within a web page. As an example, HTML emails usually contain graphics and can be interactive.
Internet protocol (IP) address	The Internet Protocol (IP) address is an exclusive number which is used to represent every single computer in a network.
Internet service provider (ISP)	Internet Service Provider – this is the company that provides you with access to the Internet, for example, MWEB or AOL.
Key performance indicator (KPI)	A metric that shows whether an objective is being achieved.
Marketplace Ads	Facebook ad space units, a type of advertising available on Facebook.
Paid search advertising	Usually refers to advertising on search engines, sometimes called PPC advertising. The advertiser pays only for each click of the advert.
Popup	Unrequested window that opens on top of the currently viewed window.
Tracking	Measuring the effectiveness of a campaign by collecting and evaluating statistics.
Tracking code	A piece of code that tracks a user's interaction and movement through a website.
Traditional media	Newspapers, magazines, television and publishing houses are the realm of traditional media.

Unique selling point (USP)	Unique selling point (or proposition) – what makes your offering different to your competitors'.
Viral video	This is a video that becomes immensely popular, leading to its spread through word-of-mouth on the Internet via email, social networks and other hosting websites.
Web analytics	A software tool that collects data on website users, based on metrics to measure its performance.
Web browser	This is what allows you to browse the World Wide Web. Examples of browsers include Internet Explorer, Chrome, Safari and Firefox.

11.3 Online advertising objectives

Advertising, whether online or offline, has a number of objectives.

11.3.1 Building brand awareness

NOTE

Brand awareness is essential for launching a new brand or product, or approaching a new audience.

Making people aware of a brand or product is an important long-term goal for any marketer. Once customers know about it, they are more likely to trust the brand. The better known a brand is, the more business it can do. And the ultimate goal is to sell more of the product or service.

Online advertising is largely visual, making it an ideal channel for promoting brand imagery and making people familiar with its colours, logo and overall feel.

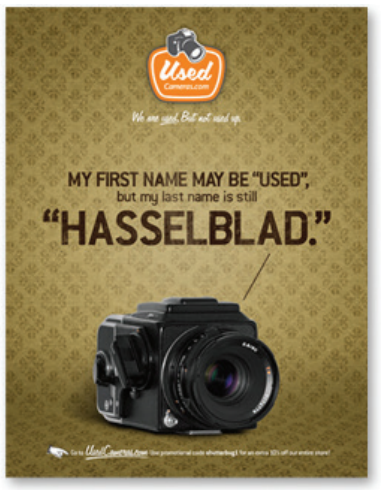

Figure 1. *A banner ad that raises awareness.*

11.3.2 Creating demand

Creating customer demand is a three-step process: inform, persuade and remind. Customers can't want what they don't know about. Advertising needs to convince them about what they should want and why they should want it. Online advertising provides a great way to communicate the unique selling points (USPs) of a product, helping to stimulate demand and reminding customers about the product and why they want it.

Figure 2. *A banner ad that creates demand for a new product.*

11.3.3 Satisfying demand

Once somebody wants a product, they need to find out how to satisfy that desire. At this point it is important for the marketer to show the customer how their particular brand or product will best meet that need.

Figure 3. *A banner ad that meets the customer's need to save money.*

11.3.4 Driving direct response and sales

All forms of digital marketing need to drive traffic and sales in the long term. However, the immediacy of online advertising also drives traffic and sales in the short and medium terms. Unlike traditional media advertising, online advertising can turn the potential customer into an actual customer right there and then. What's more, it is possible to measure accurately how effective the online advertising campaign has been in this regard.

11.4 The key differentiator

Online advertising is able to drive instant sales and conversions. Unlike other advertising mediums, the consumer can go from advert to merchant in one easy click. Because of the connected nature of the Internet, online activities are highly trackable and measurable, which makes it possible to target adverts and to track and gauge the efficacy of the advertising accurately. Each display advert can be tracked for success.

11.5 Types of display adverts

There are many different ways to display adverts online. Here are some of the most common options.

11.5.1 Banner adverts

A banner advert is a graphic image or animation displayed on a website for advertising purposes. Static banners are in GIF or JPEG format, but banners can also employ rich media such as Flash, video, JavaScript, HTML5 and other interactive technologies; these allow the viewer to interact and transact within the banner. Banners are not limited to the space that they occupy; some banners expand on mouse-over or when clicked.

Standard banner sizes

There are standard sizes (measured in pixels) for static, animated and rich media banner adverts. Creating banners in these sizes means the ads can be placed on many websites (advertisers sell space in these sizes as well). And here, size (both dimensions and file size) does matter – you can expect varying rates of clickthroughs and conversions across the range of sizes. Bigger is usually better, but if you want to know what works best for your brand, test.

Banner sizes available on the Google Display Network include (all sizes are in pixels):

- Banner (468 x 60)
- Mobile leaderboard (300 x 50)
- Leaderboard (728 x 90)
- Small Square (200 x 200)
- Skyscraper (120 x 600)
- Wide Skyscraper (160 x 600)
- Square (250 x 250)
- Medium Rectangle (300 x 250)
- Large Rectangle (336 x 280)

NOTE

Google AdWords offers a rich media banner advert builder. You can find it in the 'Ads' tab in the AdWords account interface.

NOTE

Start with the most common banner size.

Banners may be animated, static or Flash, but must be under 50k in file size.

Bear in mind that the advertising network often includes a small graphic overlay on the bottom of the advert, and does not resize your advert to accommodate this. To avoid this obscuring your advert, you can leave a few pixels of blank space on the bottom of your advert.

All adverts need to be supplied with a destination URL. Some rich media adverts allow for multiple destination URLs.

11.5.2 Interstitial banners

These are banners shown between pages on a website. As you click from one page to another, you are shown this advert before the next page is displayed. Sometimes the advert can be closed.

11.5.3 Popups and pop-unders

As the name suggests, these are adverts that pop up, or under, the web page being viewed. They open in a new, smaller window. You will see a popup straight away, but will probably become aware of a pop-under only after you close your browser window.

These were very prominent in the early days of online advertising, but audience annoyance means that there are now 'popup blockers' built into most good web browsers. This can be problematic as sometimes a website will legitimately use a popup to display information to the user.

11.5.4 Floating adverts

NOTE

Remember: your goal is to inform and motivate customers, not annoy them.

This advert appears in a layer over the content, but is not in a separate window. Usually, the user can close this advert. In fact, best practice dictates that a prominent close button should be included on the advert, usually in the top right hand corner. Floating adverts are created with DHTML or Flash, and float in a layer above a site's content for a few seconds. Often, the animation ends by disappearing into a banner advert on the page.

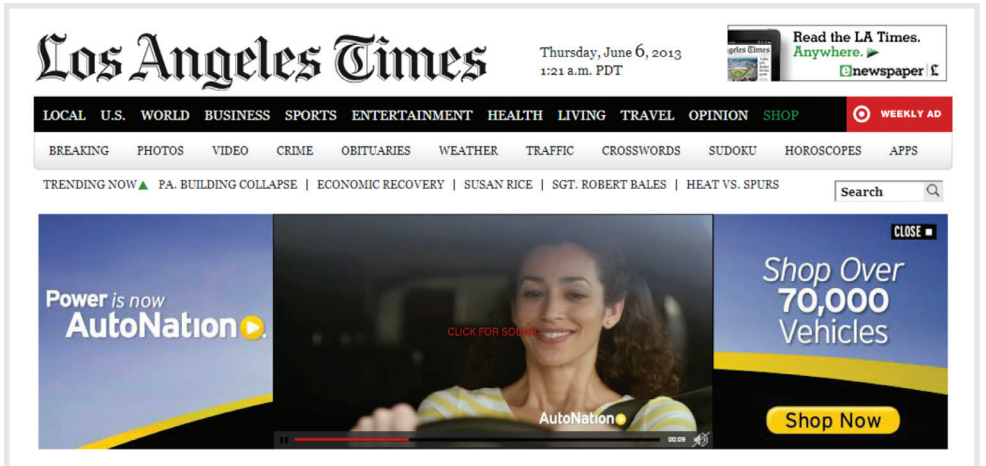

Figure 4. ***An expanded banner ad, including video, on the Los Angeles Times website.***

11.5.5 Wallpaper adverts

This advert changes the background of the web page being viewed. It is sometimes possible to click on an advert of this type, but not always. The effect of these adverts is difficult to measure as there is often no clickthrough, and its chief purpose is branding.

11.5.6 Map adverts

This is advertising placed on an online map, such as Google Maps. This type of advert is ideal for local businesses and is usually based on keyword searches for the brand's offering.

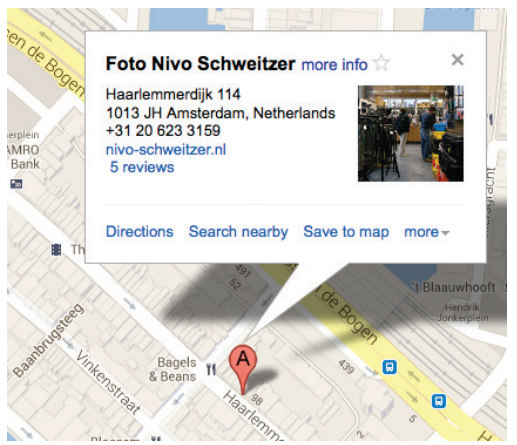

Figure 5. ***A map advert on Google Maps.***

11.6 Payment models for display advertising

As well as a variety of mediums and formats, there are also a number of different payment models for display advertising.

11.6.1 CPM

CPM stands for cost per thousand impressions (M is the Roman numeral for a thousand). This means the advertiser pays for every thousand times the advert loads on the publisher's page. This is how a campaign is normally priced when brand awareness or exposure is the primary goal.

CPM rates for rich media adverts are usually higher than for standard media adverts. This is often based on file size.

11.6.2 CPC

CPC stands for cost per click. This means that the advertiser pays only when their advert is clicked on by an interested party, regardless of how many times it has been viewed. CPC advertising is normally associated with search advertising,

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Search Advertising* chapter.

although it has become very popular in display advertising too, especially when using ad networks. Banners can be priced this way when the aim is to drive traffic and conversions. It is also a payment method sometimes used in affiliate marketing, when the aim is to drive traffic to a new website.

11.6.3 CPA

CPA refers to cost per acquisition. This model means that the advertiser pays only when an advert delivers an acquisition after the user clicks on the advert. Definitions of acquisitions vary depending on the site and campaign. It may be a user filling in a form, downloading a file or buying a product.

CPA is often the best option for advertisers because they pay only when the advertising has met its goal. For this reason, it is also the worst type for the publisher, as they are rewarded only if the advertising is successful. The publisher has to rely on the conversion rate of the advertiser's website, something that the publisher cannot control. The CPA model is not commonly used for banner advertising and is generally associated with affiliate marketing.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Affiliate Marketing* chapter.

11.6.4 Flat rate or sponsorships

Sometimes, owners of lower-traffic sites choose to sell banner space at a flat rate – in other words, at a fixed cost per month, regardless of the amount of traffic or impressions. This would appeal to a media buyer who may be testing an online campaign that targets niche markets.

There are several variations to what a sponsorship on a website entails. Examples include exclusive adverts on all the pages and slots on a specific page, newsletter or section, and sponsoring content. Sponsorship means that no other advertiser will appear in that section. Sponsorships are often difficult to measure and are mostly used to raise brand awareness. These can be very effective when launching a new brand.

11.6.5 CPE

With the cost per engagement (CPE) model, advertisers pay for interactions with adverts, normally placed in videos or applications (such as Facebook applications). An interaction, referred to as an engagement, usually starts with a rollover (or mouse-over) that expands the ad. Once expanded, an advert may contain a video, game, form, or other interactive content. The ad doesn't take the user away from the web page, and marketers pay only when an individual completes an action.

11.6.6 What payment model can you expect?

The advertiser rarely has a say over the payment model used – this comes down to the website owner or publisher, advertising type and other factors, such as the popularity of the site.

CPM favours the publisher, while CPA favours the advertiser. Sometimes, a hybrid of the two payment models is pursued.

High-traffic, broad-audience websites (often referred to as 'premium' or booked media) will typically offer CPM advertising. Examples include web portals such as www.yahoo.com or news sites such as www.cnn.com.

Niche websites with a targeted audience are more likely to offer CPC or CPA advertising to advertisers with an appropriate product. These can also fall under the umbrella of affiliate marketing.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Affiliate Marketing* chapter.

Types of advertising can be seen on a scale from more intrusive (and thus potentially annoying to the consumer) to less intrusive. In the same way, payment models can be scaled from those that favour the publisher to those that favour the advertiser.

When planning a campaign, it is important to know how the advertising will be paid for and what kinds of advertising are offered by publishers. A lot of this can be solved by using a company that specialises in advert serving, media planning and media buying.

NOTE

Which is the best payment model for you? This will depend on the purpose of your ads and the return you expect on your investment. Each payment model can be effective and lucrative if used appropriately.

11.7 Getting your ads online

To get your ads to appear online, you need to find and pay for the space where it will appear. There are several options for doing this:

- Premium booked media
- Advertising networks
- Advertising exchanges
- Social media advertising placements
- Mobile advertising
- Ad servers

11.7.1 Premium booked media

Premium booked media works very much in the traditional way of booking advertising – the advertiser contacts the premium media provider (usually a single group that oversees a key, high-profile online space) and discusses options for placing an advert. This will involve negotiating on targeting and pricing for the space desired, and is usually a costly but high-profile option.

11.7.2 Advertising networks

An advertising network is a group of websites on which adverts can be purchased through a single sales entity. It could be a collection of sites owned by the same publisher (for example, New Line Cinema, Time Inc. and HBO are all owned by Time Warner Inc.) or it could be an affiliation of sites that share a representative. The Google Display Network is one of the largest advertising networks in the world.

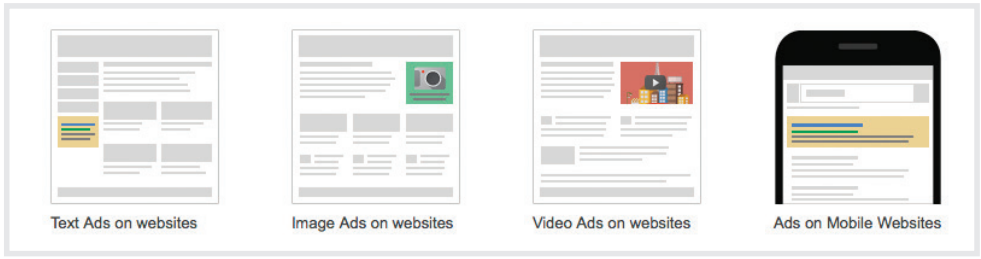

Figure 6. *Ad formats available on the Google Display Network.*

The advertising network acts as an intermediary between advertisers and publishers, and provides a technology solution to both. As well as providing a centralised ad server that can serve adverts to a number of websites, the networks offer tracking and reporting, as well as targeting.

Advertising networks usually categorise the sites by factors such as demographics, topic, or area of interest. Advertisers pay to advertise in specific channels, and not in individual sites. Most times, the campaign will then be optimised based on the best converting sites.

Rates are often negotiated with the network, and placements are booked over a period of time.

11.7.3 Advertising exchanges

Advertising exchanges, on the other hand, are where unsold advertising space – called inventory – is placed by publishers for bidding. The inventory is sold to the highest bidding advertiser. Giving advertisers far more control, this type of advertising mimics the PPC model of search advertising (Generalised Second Price auction) – but bids are for audience profiles and space rather than for keywords. It allows publishers to fill unsold inventory at the highest available price, and can give smaller advertisers access to this inventory.

11.7.4 Social media advertising

Many social media platforms offer an advertising option, as this is their primary source of revenue. Social media can be an excellent place to reach prospects because you can usually target very accurately based on user-provided demographic information.

Facebook

Facebook offers four paid-for advertising solutions:

1. **Facebook Ads** are standard adverts that appear in the user's right-hand sidebar. They have no minimum spend and can be bought on either a cost per thousand impressions (CPM) or cost per click (CPC) basis. These adverts are served based on interests and demographic information. For example, an advertiser can request to have their advert shown to all women in London who are interested in men, who are single and between the ages of 25 and 35, and who like dogs or puppies.

Figure 7. *Targeting options on Facebook.*

2. **Facebook Engagement Ads** are similar to standard ads, but include an element that fans can engage with, such as a Like or Share button, a video, an event, or a poll. These are bought on a CPM basis with a minimum spend threshold.

3. **Sponsored stories** are posts that are created whenever someone engages with a specific element of the brand's Facebook Page; these then appear in their connections' news feeds. You allocate a budget to the specific post, and this is spent to have the ad appear.

4. **Promoted posts** allow you to publicise an existing post that you have made. A page must have at least 400 Likes before this option becomes available.

NOTE

Facebook will show you the size of the audience you have targeted and how much each click is likely to cost.

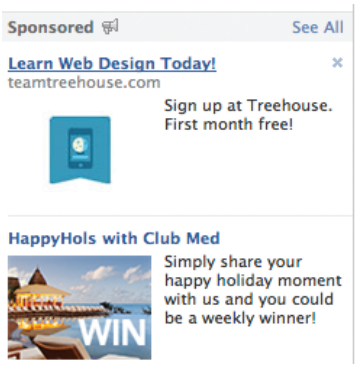

Figure 8. *Ads on Facebook.*

NOTE

Facebook Advertising information can be found at www.facebook.com/advertising.

Twitter

Twitter offers a self-service ad platform with several options and allows a degree of specific targeting. The service is still relatively new, which means that it changes frequently, and not all options may be available to all regions or user accounts.

- **Promoted tweets** are tweets that appear at the very top of a user's timeline, or in Twitter mobile apps. There is no minimum spend, and advertisers pay when users retweet, @reply to, favourite or click on a promoted tweet.
- **Promoted accounts** are user accounts that appear on the left of the user's Twitter timeline, in the section called "Who to follow", which recommends accounts the user may like. Advertisers pay when a user follows the promoted account.

Figure 9. *A Promoted account on Twitter.*

- **Promoted trends** is available only to full-service Twitter Ads customers and allows a brand to list their brand name, hashtag or slogan in the left-hand 'Trends' section of a user's Twitter timeline, which is usually reserved for the most popular topics of the moment on Twitter. These generally have a flat fee and can cost hundreds of thousands of dollars, depending on how wide the geographic targeting is.

NOTE

More information on Twitter advertising can be found at business.twitter.com/advertise/start.

YouTube

YouTube offers a wide range of advertising formats and options for businesses. These are covered in detail in the chapter on video marketing.

NOTE

You can find out more at www.youtube.com/yt/advertise.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Video Marketing* chapter.

LinkedIn

LinkedIn Ads is a self-service advertising platform that allows you to create and place adverts on prominent pages on the LinkedIn website, including a user's home page, search results pages, groups and more. There are many targeting options available, including job title, job function, industry, geography, age, gender, company name, company size, and LinkedIn Group. There is a minimum budget requirement of $10 a day (though no minimum spend), and ads can be served on a CPM or CPC basis.

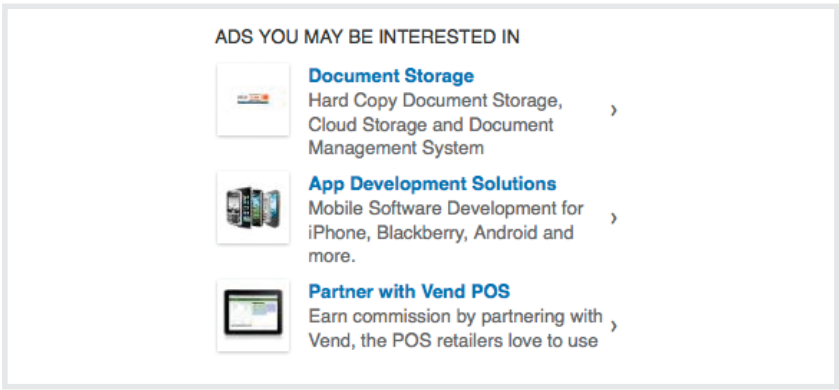

Figure 10. *LinkedIn ads.*

NOTE

More information about LinkedIn advertising can be found at www.linkedin.com/advertising.

11.7.5 Mobile advertising

There are three types of mobile networks that you can choose from when embarking on a mobile advertising campaign.

Blind networks

These networks target a large number of independent mobile publishers, and generally allow you to target by country or type of content, but not by specific websites. Payment tends to be on a CPC basis, which can vary. An example of this kind of network is BuzzCity (www.buzzcity.com).

Premium blind networks

Advertising on premium blind networks tends to be more expensive, but allow the advertiser to target better-known brands and high-traffic sites. Broadcasters or operator portals fall under this category. Payment here is often on a CPM basis. Millennial Media (www.millennialmedia.com) is an example premium blind network. While targeting options are available, different networks can work in different ways, with varying levels of support.

Premium networks

These networks often offer sales as a direct extension of the big brands that they offer. More detailed targeting and sales support is available, but they also charge higher rates. An example of this kind of network is Widespace (www.widespace.com/en).

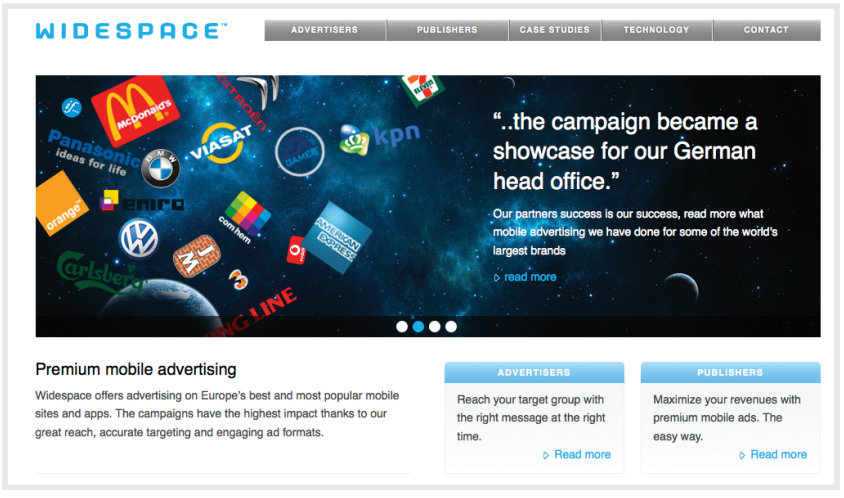

Figure 11. *Widespace is an example of a premium mobile ad network.*

NOTE

The Mobile Marketing Association publishes a set of useful guidelines for mobile advertising. Download the latest version at time of publishing here: www.mmaglobal.com/files/mobileadvertising.pdf.

11.7.6 Ad servers

Ad servers are servers that store advertisements and serve them to web pages. Ad servers can be local, run by a publisher to serve adverts to websites on the publisher's domain, or they can be third-party ad servers, which serve adverts to web pages on any domain. Ad servers facilitate advert trafficking and provide reports on advert performance. They have two functions: to help publishers manage their ad inventory, and to help advertisers monitor and optimise their campaigns.

The benefits of ad servers

Rather than distribute copies of each piece of creative advertising to each publisher or media buyer, you can send out a line of code that calls up an advertisement directly from the ad server each time an advert is scheduled to run. The agency loads the creative to the server once and can modify rotations or add new units on the fly without needing to re-contact the vendors. This is referred to as third-party ad serving.

The ad servers provide a wealth of data, including impressions served, adverts clicked, CTR and CPC. While publishers have their own ad servers, most of the third-party ad servers also have the ability to provide performance against post-click activities such as sales, leads, downloads, or any other site-based action the advertiser may want to measure.

Ad servers provide a consistent counting methodology across the entire campaign enabling the advertiser to gain an 'apples to apples' comparison of performance across the entire media schedule, which includes multiple websites. This ensures that the advertiser gets what they are paying for, and avoids fraudulent activities, such as click fraud, as a good third-party ad server should be audited.

The ad server also allows sophisticated targeting of display advertising. Examples of third-party ad servers include Google DoubleClick, Atlas and MediaMind.

11.8 Targeting and optimising

Ad servers serve adverts across a number of websites, and can track a user visiting websites using cookies or IP addresses. This means that ad servers can offer advertisers:

- **Frequency capping:** this limits the number of times a specific user sees the same advert in a set time period.
- **Sequencing:** this ensures that a user sees adverts in a particular order.
- **Exclusivity:** this ensures that adverts from direct competitors are not shown on the same page.
- **Roadblocks:** this allows an advertiser to own 100% of the advertising inventory on a page.

The ad server can also target adverts based on the business rules of the advertiser or the profiles of the users:

NOTE

Location targeting can be very cost-effective for physical events and regional offers.

- **Geo-targeting:** online advertising has the ability to target markets by country, province or city, and can even drill them down to something as specific as their IP address. This is also known as IP targeting.
- **Network or browser type:** markets can further be targeted via networks or browser types such as Mozilla Firefox, Internet Explorer, Chrome and Safari.
- **Connection type:** users can be segmented and targeted according to their Internet connection type, for example, whether they use broadband or dial-up connections.
- **Day and time:** advertisers can choose the time of day or day of the week when their adverts are shown. Advertisers can specify when their campaign should flight, down to the minute. This usually depends on the client's objective for the campaign or the product itself.
- **Social serving:** websites gather demographic data about users and then serve each user targeted and relevant advertising. For example, Facebook will allow advertisers to select specific characteristics of users who will be shown an advert.
- **Behavioural targeting:** the ad server uses the profile of a user (built up over websites visited previously) to determine which adverts to show during a given visit. Ad servers can base this profile on cookies or on IP addresses. For example, the ad server may choose to show adverts for pet insurance on a news page to a user who has visited the pets and animals section of a general media site previously.

  Re-marketing is another form of behavioural targeting. This allows the ad server to display ads to users after they have interacted with a website in a certain way – for example, by adding an item to their cart on an eCommerce page but not checking out. The user may then see an ad for the product they have in their cart, to encourage them to go back and make a purchase.

  Another approach to behavioural targeting is to set up parameters to determine when a certain advert needs to be shown. For example: if the user has clicked on a banner advertising a test drive, and the user has actually booked the test drive, the next time they see an advert from the advertiser, a different advert will be shown because the user has already responded to the first one.

- **Contextual advertising:** the ad server deduces the optimum adverts to serve based on the content of the page. For example, on an article about mountain bike holidays in Europe, the ad server would show adverts for new mountain bikes, or adverts from travel companies offering flights to Europe, or perhaps adverts for adventure travel insurance.

11.9 Tracking

The trackability of online advertising is what makes it so superior to conventional advertising. Not only can an advertiser tell how many times an advert has been seen (impressions), but also how many times the advert has been successful in sending visitors to the advertised website (clicks). As discussed in the chapter on conversion optimisation, the tracking needs to continue on the website to determine how successful the advert has been in creating more revenue for the website (conversions).

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Conversion Optimisation* chapter.

As well as tracking adverts, advertising networks can also provide information about the people who saw the advert, as well as those who acted on it, including:

- Connection type
- Browser
- Operating system
- Time of day
- Internet service provider

Many third-party ad servers will set a cookie on impression of an advert, not only on clickthrough, so it is possible to track conversions that happen indirectly (called view-through conversions). Simply put, third-party ad servers can track not only the post click data, but also the post view data: when a user sees an advert, does not click on it, but goes to the website after viewing the advert (either by typing in the URL, or by searching for the site).

Using this information, the ad server can target the adverts displayed, helping advertisers to optimise campaigns and get the most from their budgets.

11.10 Step-by-step guide to online advertising

Knowing the various types of display options and payment models available is all very well, but you may be wondering how to put this all together as you plan your campaign. Here is a step-by-step guide that you can follow to ensure that you run effective adverts.

NOTE

Don't forget to keep an eye on any non-digital advertising that the brand is doing – this could have a significant effect on your results, and you want to ensure that you are communicating the same message.

1. Determine the goal of your campaign.

Are you embarking on a branding campaign, or is your primary focus direct response?

2. Identify your key performance indicators (KPIs).

Which figures will let you know if you are succeeding? This should tie in closely to your goal.

3. Investigate your target audience.

What websites are they likely to be visiting? The type of creative you use and the payment model you follow will largely be determined by the websites that you advertise on.

Online advertising is an acquisition and awareness channel. It does not require users to seek an interaction actively, as search advertising and email marketing do. So, it is crucial that the adverts are placed in front of the audience that is most likely to convert.

4. Research potential websites to host your adverts.

Niche websites with a smaller, more targeted audience will most likely charge a flat rate for display advertising, or a CPA rate. They could be flexible in display options that they give you, but you will need to take into account their bandwidth costs if they serve the adverts.

High-traffic websites with a broad audience will usually charge on a CPM basis. They will broker their advertising inventory through an advertising network, or even a number of advertising networks.

5. Set a budget.

Most advertising platforms will let you set and dynamically manage your budget. Decide how much you are willing to pay per click, impression, action or engagement, and set your total budget in line with this.

6. Create your adverts.

Now, you will need to brief your creative team to ensure that you have the optimum banners for your campaign.

Your online adverts will need to:

- **A**ttract attention
- **C**onvey a message
- **E**ntice action

Animation attracts attention, but be wary of being one of several animated banners on a website. Banners should not be considered in isolation, but rather in the context of the website on which they will appear.

Web users respond well to being told what to do, and the content of an online advert should be concise and directional. Examples of these CTAs include:

- "Phone now for the best deals on insurance."
- "Click here for fast home delivery."
- "Donate now."

7. Choose or create a landing page.

All advertising needs an appropriate landing page or destination URL. Whether this involves creating a microsite, or merely leading users to an existing page on the website, ensure that clickthroughs are not being wasted. Generally, sending advertising traffic to your home page is not a good idea as it leaves the user confused about where to go next.

8. Run your adverts.

Now that you're all set up, you can let your ads go live! Keep a close eye on your spending to ensure that you're getting a decent return for your money, and that nothing unusual is occurring.

NOTE

If a problem comes up, you can simply stop your campaign, change the creative elements or modify your approach – the beauty of online advertising is that it can be revised almost instantly.

9. Track, measure, optimise.

As with all online marketing tactics, you need to track what your ads are doing and the results they are generating, measure your returns and successes, and then optimise your online advertising campaigns to get even better returns in future.

11.11 The future of online advertising

On the web, the convergence of digital devices and channels is leading to new avenues for online advertising. Digital advertising can reach customers anywhere where they can access the web.

While we have become used to the Internet as a free medium where we can read and interact with any content we want, it is the fact that it is an advertiser's medium that keeps it free. And that means that as technologies evolve and the way we interact with content changes, so advertising follows.

Previously the level of interaction a web user had with a website could be measured by the number of pages of that website the user viewed. Now, technology such as AJAX and rich media such as video mean that the time spent on a web page can be more meaningful than the number of pages viewed. The key word here is 'engagement', and technology and data analysis is working towards being able to determine how websites can quantify the level of engagement with a viewer.

A little online research will reveal plenty of commentary declaring the decline of display advertising. Increasingly, consumers are becoming both weary and wary of advertising. Clickthrough rates on banners are dropping, so the effectiveness of display advertising is being questioned by some. With the focus in digital marketing on tracking and measuring response and engagement, should a company spend money on less measurable activities such as 'brand building', where they are paying on a CPM basis?

NOTE

View-through conversions are important to look at as well, especially if your campaign is focused around raising awareness.

Using third-party ad servers and post-impression tracking, the effect of different advertising and marketing channels on each other can be observed. Banner advertising can see an increase in search volume, for example.

What does this tell us? Measurement should take place across all channels, and no channel should be utilised in isolation. The best results will be gained through an integrated and holistic approach to digital marketing.

11.12 Advantages and challenges

11.12.1 Advantages of online advertising

Banner advertising goes a long way towards bridging the advertising divide. Adverts have a set size, they can look very similar to print adverts, and they occupy a particular bit of real estate in a publication with a particular number of views. It's easy to understand, and it does the things with which buyers are familiar.

Online advertising can take advantage of the emotive qualities of images, videos and animations. Some campaigns are better suited to images rather than plain text.

Since banners can contain rich media, they offer levels of interactivity that other forms of advertising cannot achieve. This allows your target market not only to see your banner, but also to play with it. Interaction builds a bond and improves the chances of the consumer remembering your brand tomorrow. Cognitive learning is a powerful outcome of interactive display advertising.

Modern online advertising is able to bring together a number of other online marketing tactics such as animations, games, video and Flash.

Banner ads, like all digital marketing tactics, are measurable. Track clickthrough rates and you get an idea of exactly how many people are responding to your Call to Action. Some publishers even have the ability to do post-click tracking, which means that you can track the user all the way to a sale if that is the purpose of the advert.

11.12.2 Challenges of online advertising

A lot of display advertising is intrusive, so popup blockers can often prevent adverts from being served as they were intended by the advertisers. There are also extensions available for web browsers, such as AdBlock Plus, that will block advertising on web pages. Technologically savvy consumers are increasingly using these methods to limit the advertising that they see.

Bandwidth can also be an issue, although this is a shrinking problem. However, campaigns should be planned according to demographics in determining the richness (and investment) of interaction.

Consumers are suffering from advertising fatigue, so while new technologies can provide great results, as soon as the market moves mainstream it can get saturated. Consumers are increasingly ignoring adverts.

NOTE

Advertising blindness is not a problem that's unique to the web - for example, TV viewers are increasingly fast-forwarding through ads or watching episodes through online streaming services.

11.13 Case study – Toyota Prius

11.13.1 One-line summary

Toyota launches a display advertising campaign to draw awareness to the new Prius and increase sales.

11.13.2 The problem

The Prius is a hybrid electric car. Toyota needed to raise awareness and drive sales around the introduction of new models to the Prius line. To address this challenge, they brought the Saatchi & Saatchi LA team on board (WorldsBestCaseStudies.com, 2012).

11.13.3 The solution

Since the idea for the second Prius had been conceived, debate had surrounded the question of what exactly the term for the plural of Prius would be (Walsh, 2013). The Saatchi team identified this as a potential talking point among customers and launched the 'Prius goes plural' campaign.

The promotional video posted on YouTube asked fans what they thought the plural of the name 'Prius' should be. The video then gave social media users a month to vote for the best term.

In order to drive awareness and interest in the campaign, they created a series of animated, interactive display ads.

Some of the display ads featured animated Prius vehicles that sped into life by driving across the page into the text that the viewer was reading.

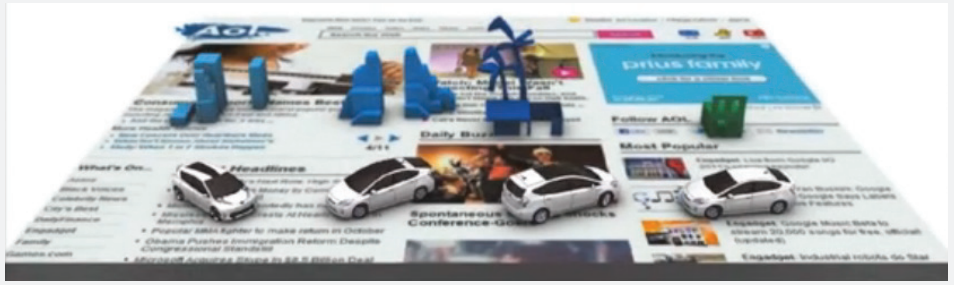

Figure 12. *An animated Prius ad. (Source: WorldsBestCaseStudies.com, 2012)*

11.13.4 Results

The display advertising campaign was incredibly successful in driving awareness, interaction and traffic to a range of portals. It achieved this by incorporating a fun concept with some eye-catching display adverts that also encouraged interactivity – a perfect blend that speaks to display advertising best practice.

Here are some figures that demonstrate the success of this display advertising strategy:

- The YouTube video alone was viewed over 250 000 times, with almost 300 comments (ToyotaUSA, 2011).
- The Facebook Page received over 400 000 likes with 1 141 likes for a single post, although comments on posts were lacking (Toyota Prius, 2000).
- The hashtag #PriusGoesPlural trended on Twitter.
- The campaign received just 1.2 million votes – and the Prius plural was announced as Prii (Walsh, 2013).
- This campaign also drove sales with a record of over 1 million Prius sales, even in a tough economy (WorldsBestCaseStudies.com, 2012).

Figure 13. *An interactive ad that allowed users to enter their suggestions.*

11.14 The bigger picture

Offline advertising and marketing campaigns can be adapted for an online audience in order to ensure maximum brand exposure. It is very effective in enhancing offline marketing and advertising activity and in ensuring a wider reach.

As mentioned, online advertising can be used as an acquisition channel, reaching out to a new audience. It can be used to initiate a buying cycle and customer relationship, which then plays out across other online channels. Addressing advertising and other channels to complement each other will result in a consistent message, and optimum results. Online advertising can be used to reach a large audience, and then other digital marketing tactics can be used to refine and engage this audience further. Social media advertising in particular is crucial for building communities and keeping the brand top of mind.

Online advertising and affiliate marketing go hand in hand. Affiliate networks also act as advertising networks, allowing for advertising to be purchased on a performance basis.

When seeding new products and viral campaigns, display advertising can be used to reach a wide audience at a low cost. It can expose a campaign to many new users, and increase the chance that those who are most likely to pass on a message receive it in the first place. Display advertising also supports other advertising and marketing channels, such as search advertising and marketing.

11.15 Summary

Online advertising has two main objectives:

- Branding
- Direct response and sales

The Internet allows for highly targeted and highly trackable advertising across a variety of online media. Some ways that advertisers can use the Internet are:

- Banner adverts
- Interstitial banners
- Popups and pop-unders
- Floating adverts
- Wallpaper adverts
- Map adverts

Ad servers provide trafficking, tracking and reporting solutions to both advertisers and publishers. They allow advertisers to target display adverts based on parameters, including:

- User profile (location, operating system, browser, connection type)
- Behaviour
- Frequency and sequencing
- Exclusivity
- Context of content

Technology allows for increased levels of interaction within an advert, and for advertising tailored to engagement media such as online videos and social network applications.

11.16 Case study questions

1. Why did display advertising play such a critical role in the Prius campaign?
2. Why did people find the concept of coming up with a plural for Prius so engaging?
3. What is the benefit of using interactive adverts, as demonstrated in the case study?

11.17 Chapter questions

1. Online banner advertising and outdoor display advertising both use images to try to increase sales. In planning, both need to consider placement so as to be seen by their most likely audience. What are the key differences?
2. Why is display advertising an effective acquisition channel?
3. Go to www.wheels24.co.za and www.thetimes.co.za. What advertising can you find on the front page of these two websites? What products are being advertised, and how are they being advertised? What can you deduce about the target market for these products?

11.18 Further reading

www.adrants.com – Commentary on online advertising campaigns. US focused.

econsultancy.com/uk/blog – UK industry-focused advertising articles.

www.bannerblog.com.au – Have a look at Bannerblog for rich media examples.

11.19 References

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[Accessed 8 May 2013].

13

Video Marketing

What's inside: An **introduction** to video marketing and the **key terms and concepts** you need for this chapter. We look at how to **produce an online video within a sound content strategy**, and how to **promote** it through paid, earned and owned media channels.

13.1 Introduction

Unlike text and even images, video offers an extremely rich, engaging and stimulating experience for viewers. With the increased availability of bandwidth and improvements in video technology, people have started watching and sharing videos on a scale never seen before. From music videos and funny clips of animals to reviews, how-to's and exciting commercials and movie trailers, people are turning to video for entertainment, information and valuable content.

In early 2013, Google was the world's largest search engine with almost 19.5 billion searches in January alone representing a 67% market share in the US (comScore, 2013). Interestingly, the second largest search engine was in fact YouTube, the popular video-sharing website. This indicates that people are turning to YouTube with precise, intent-driven behaviour: they're not just browsing randomly or waiting for a link to land in their inbox. YouTube boasts over 1 billion unique users per month (YouTube, 2013).

Online, we turn to search engines to help us answer questions and find content. That content can be anything, from images to text, and of course, video. Text content can be read by search engines, but content such as images and video cannot be read nearly as well. With more and more people using searches to find video content, understanding how to create videos for online and optimise videos for searching is an important part of any digital strategy.

According to YouTube, there are more than four billion hours of video viewed each month on its website, while every minute, 100 hours of video are uploaded (YouTube, 2013).

Videos can come from anyone, and from anywhere. Small home videos can experience massive global reach, as was the case with the popular *Charlie Bit My Finger* video which has accumulated 558 million views as of September 2013. Musicians often use social video platforms to share their music videos and, of course, brands use video-sharing platforms to communicate messages via video. People are increasingly interacting with brands via video by creating opinion videos, parodies and responses. More importantly, they have the power to market themselves, their ideas, who they are and what they do. For example, Laura Vitale has created a series of engaging cooking videos right at home – her informative and valuable videos (created on a budget) have garnered over 69 million views and 500 000 subscriptions.

Video content helps you connect with your audience, creating an experience and encouraging engagement.

In this chapter, you will learn:

- Why video marketing is such a powerful, versatile and effective marketing channel online
- How successful online videos are produced, step by step
- Paid, earned and owned methods of promoting your online video

13.2 Key terms and concepts

Term	Definition
Annotation	A comment or instruction (usually added as text) on a YouTube video. A YouTube annotation may contain links directing users to other pages within YouTube or, if a brand is willing to pay, to outside websites.
Captions	Text that appears over a video that labels a scene, identifies a location or person, or narrates dialogue onscreen. Captions can be either open or closed.
Embedding	Taking video from an online video provider and posting it elsewhere on the web.
Google AdWords	Google's search advertising program, which allows advertisers to display their adverts on relevant search results and across Google's content network.
Meta data	Information that can be entered about a web page and the elements on it to provide context and relevance information to search engines.
Search engine results page (SERP)	The actual results returned to the user based on a search query.
Thumbnail	The still image that is shown at the start of the video. This can be selected, and can make a video more enticing.
Video search engine optimisation (VSEO)	Optimising videos for search engines, similar to the way in which one would optimise a website to rank higher on the SERPs.
Video syndication	The process of distributing and getting search coverage for videos.
Views	The number of times a video has been seen. Multiple views can come from one user.
Viral video	A video that becomes immensely popular, leading to its spread through word of mouth on the Internet via email, social networks and other hosting websites.
Vlogger	Video blogger. A person who produces regular web videos about a chosen topic on a video-enabled blog.

13.3 Video content strategy

Videos are powerful because they can have a strong emotional effect on viewers – it's no secret that funny, shocking, amazing and inspirational videos do particularly well online. Video is the ideal tool for experiential marketing – giving viewers the chance to experience something alongside the onscreen actors and consider how they would feel or act in that situation. It also helps to show off a brand's personality, tone and communication style.

Many people are still under the misconception that online videos are expensive and difficult to produce. That's not the case – the many millions of successful home video bloggers (vloggers) and marketers prove otherwise.

Unlike content made for TV, web video content can be filmed at a much lower cost and quality, using readily available home video equipment. Affordable high-quality cameras have made quality content production a reality for everyone. Viewers don't necessarily expect a super-slick offering (though even this is possible with some basic video editing software). To get started with making video marketing content, you will need:

- **A camera** – depending on what you can afford, this can range from a simple webcam or your mobile phone's camera to a (top-of-the-line) professional camera, though there are many excellent mid-range options available at a low price.

- **A microphone** – while some cameras have a built-in microphone, it's worthwhile investing in a proper mic to ensure that you capture better sound quality (built-in microphones tend to catch a lot of background noise at the expense of the main audio).

- **Video editing software** – you will need a software package to cut, edit and finish your video; there is a wide range of options, including free built-in software (Movie Maker for Windows and iMovie for Mac) and professional video editing suites (such as Final Cut Pro or Adobe AfterEffects), which can be more costly. YouTube also offers an online video editing tool.

NOTE

There are many useful, free resources and tutorials on creating videos online - www.wikihow.com is a good place to start looking.

13.3.1 Video content versus video ads

Video marketing covers two approaches:

1. **Video content**: These are videos made to entertain, inform, share updates or otherwise enlighten or delight the viewer. Much like syndicated articles or blog posts, these are usually not directly promotional, but instead provide shareable content that gives value to the viewer. Some examples of video content include:

   - How-to guides and tutorials
   - Video presentations
   - Educational lectures
   - Entertainment
   - Conference talks
   - Valuable industry updates
   - Product reviews and advice

NOTE

Think about it now: if your company or brand wanted to create content videos, what format and approach would you use?

2. **Video ads**: These are simply adverts that are filmed and formatted for online use. These can be existing TV commercials that are shared online, or custom ads made specifically for the web. We'll cover a range of options for posting your video ads below, in the section on paid video promotion.

13.3.2 Going viral

The holy grail of video marketing (and, in fact, any marketing on the web) is having a piece of content 'go viral'. This means that the content spreads from person to person through the web at a very high rate, attracting an exponentially growing audience as it gains popularity. The key to this viral effect is social media, where each user is connected to a wide network of others and can easily share content with their friends. Because this is a trusted social referral, it's more likely that they will view and share it themselves (if it's good enough).

Figure 1. *A screenshot of the Will it Blend video on YouTube, indicating the number of times it has been viewed.*

Nobody quite knows the secret recipe for getting content to go viral, and quite possibly there isn't one – the sheer variety and scope of viral videos shows that almost anything might catch the interest of the Internet on the right day. This means that it's very difficult to craft a video in order to make it go viral. But there are some principles that can help you make great video content with the potential for viral spread:

- **Address a currently trending topic**. Find something that people are already excited about or interested in, and see how you can contribute meaningfully to the conversation. For example, make your own edited version of a viral video.
- **Make it enticing**. Craft the video's description, title and thumbnail so that they draw attention.
- **Make it remarkable**. Whether it's funny, astonishing, scary, shocking or informational, your content has to have value for your viewers – and it has to give them social capital for spreading them.
- **Make it unique.** The Internet loves new, fresh, crazy ideas – so don't rehash somebody else's success or stick to a formula. Be truly creative and inventive.
- **Make it shareable.** Include the tools and incentives to make your video easy to share; consider social media chiclets, annotations, encouraging comments and more.
- **Make it short.** With very few exceptions, successful viral videos tend to be short, impactful clips. People have short attention spans, so make sure you get the message across quickly.

13.4 Video production step by step

Creating video content for the web is easy and cost effective. Consider the following process.

13.4.1 Identifying your audience

As always, you first need to identify the audience for whom you are creating this video content. What are their wants and needs? What video content are they already consuming? How can you engage their attention, provide something valuable, and promote your brand at the same time?

Some solid market research will reveal the answers to these questions.

13.4.2 Planning and concept

Now you need to come up with the core concept for the video, which will be dictated by what will resonate with your target audience. Will it be a once-off clip or part of an ongoing series? What marketing message do you hope to convey? Decide on the best style and tone in which to convey this.

Once you have decided these aspects, it's time to start planning your actual video shoot. You will need to write a script (or at least prepare a breakdown of what the video should include), and schedule the shoot – consider the venue, crew required, actors, and any other props or elements you need. How long this takes will depend on the complexity of the video you're planning.

13.4.3 Producing the video

Now it's time to get filming! Once you have all the footage and audio, you will need to edit it together, add any special effects and other elements, and save it as the final video.

NOTE

For some helpful pointers and advice on producing your video, take a look at the Vimeo Video School: vimeo.com/videoschool.

13.4.4 Choosing and uploading to platform

Once you have the video, you need to decide where it will be uploaded to.

There are two options for making your video content available online. These are not mutually exclusive and there are techniques for both to ensure the best distribution and search coverage for your video. For example, you could be embedding videos posted elsewhere on your site.

Online video can be **hosted** on your own site, or it can be **posted** to one or many video distribution channels. If you post your video somewhere such as YouTube or Vimeo, it is then easy to embed it into your website as well.

The main advantage of posting a video to a third-party site is the opportunity to exploit an already existing audience quickly. These websites also usually have a built-in social and viral media aspect to their user experience. Video-sharing sites tend to have simplified algorithms which are easier to take advantage of, leading to more rapid universal search exposure.

YouTube (www.youtube.com) should be your first port of call when posting videos, since it is the biggest and most popular video hosting site on the web. Rather than posting a video under a normal username, create a branded channel – a YouTube 'home page' for videos created by your brand.

YouTube channels allow you to add a logo, background, branded elements, a brand description and links to your other web properties. This means you can customise the page as you see fit. Channels also have a range of analytical features for measuring video engagement, and as an added bonus, they work well on mobile devices, too. Furthermore, you gain many benefits in ranking well on the world's most popular search engine – Google.

Figure 2. *The Miller Genuine Draft Channel on YouTube.*

Other good options for video hosting include:

- Vimeo (www.vimeo.com)
- MetaCafe (www.metacafe.com)
- Dailymotion (www.dailymotion.com)

If your video is hosted on your own website, the obvious advantage is that you have control over the whole website and environment in which it is hosted, from the look and feel to on-page text, meta data and user experience. When it comes to advertising and related content, you control both, and you decide how to monetise it. Traffic and links go directly to your website, and can therefore be integral to a longer-term search strategy. However, consider embedding your videos from your account on your chosen video-sharing site. Not only does this allow you to cross-pollinate content, but you will also gain more views via more points of entry.

NOTE

YouTube Analytics lets you see where people are viewing your videos – this can give you insight into your most effective video-sharing channels.

13.4.5 Optimising

At this point, you need to optimise your video for easy discovery on the web.

Most searching on the web is keyword based: you type keywords relevant to your query into a search box, and the results of the search should list content that matches your keywords. Whether you are using a search box on a website, on YouTube, or Google, this outlines the very basic way in which we expect the search function to work.

The search engine tries to match your keywords to the content it has indexed, and is also trying to determine how to rank the results so that you get the most relevant content at the top of your search results page.

This is all covered in great detail in the *Search Engine Optimisation (SEO)* chapter. Optimising video for search involves understanding the basics of SEO, and then the particular challenges and tactics of optimising video content.

Search engines rely on being able to use text in the content to determine what it is about, and other indicators to determine how relevant that content is. When it comes to web pages, search engines can 'read' the text on the page to determine what the page is about, and can measure the links coming in to determine how relevant the page is. When it comes to video, the search engine cannot 'watch' or 'read' the video in the same way that a human can (though there are technological solutions that are starting to make this possible). Instead, it must rely on other text on the page, as well as the meta data added, to determine what the video is about. The search engine also needs to look for ways to measure relevance.

Marketers and website owners now need to optimise all their various forms of content – be they text pages, images or videos – in order to achieve better rankings. Video search engine optimisation (VSEO) involves the use of basic SEO foundations and additional creative optimisation methods to ensure that online video content appears higher up on the SERPs.

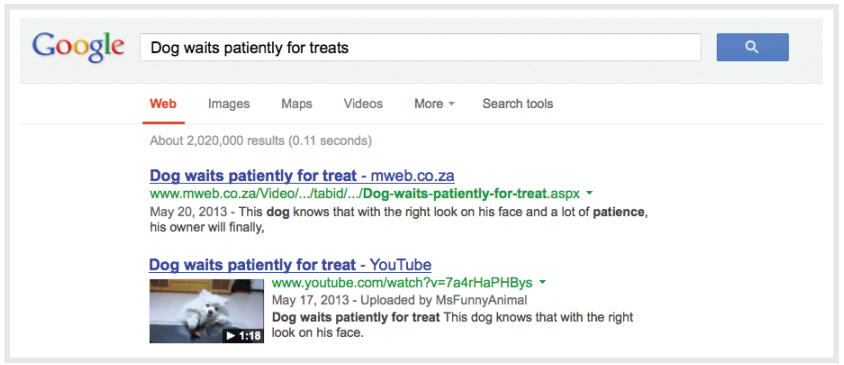

Figure 3. *A search for the words "dog waits patiently for treats" brings up website and video results.*

Optimising video for video-sharing sites such as YouTube means that you will appear not only in search results on the video-sharing site, but also on SERPs such as Google. While each video-sharing site will use its own algorithm, the guidelines below can be considered best practice across most of the video-sharing sites.

1. Video title is very important.

Video title is one of the first things a user sees when clicking through to a video, and is used first and foremost by the video search engines to determine the relevance of your video to the search query. Your most important keywords should appear in the first three words of the title. Longer, descriptive titles are better than short, concise and obscure ones.

NOTE

If you are creating a video series, use a standard naming structure for the title to make all the videos easier to find.

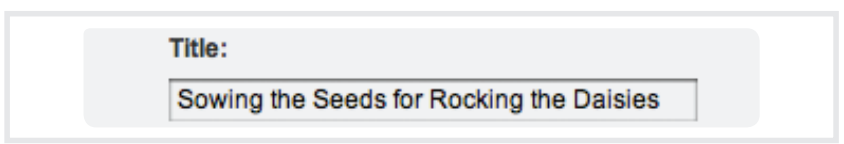

Figure 4. *Video title.*

2. Use informative, long descriptions.

Descriptions will contain key terms that search engines should be looking for to determine what the video is about. Use your most important keywords here! You can include as much information as possible, but put the most important stuff in the first 25 characters. You can include a link in your description, enabling you to direct users to other content that you have.

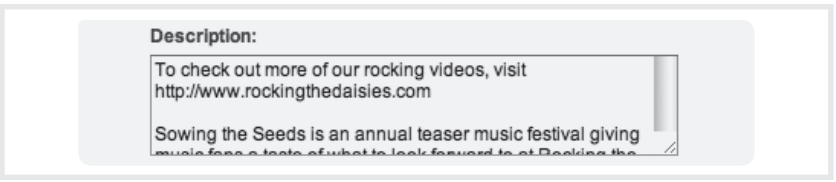

Figure 5. *Video description.*

3. Use the tags to input several keywords.

Put your most important keywords first. You can also capitalise on popular search terms and piggyback on popular or topical phrases. YouTube will use your tags to help categorise your video. Ensure that these are relevant to your video. and utilise terms from the same category.

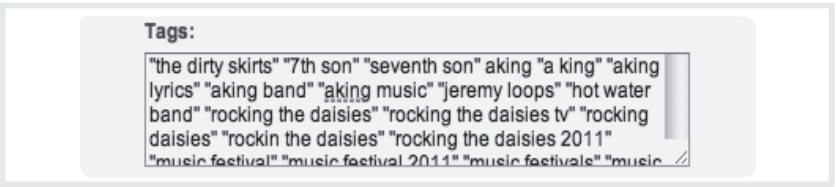

Figure 6. *Video tag.*

YouTube Suggest and Google Suggest are useful tools for generating ideas.

4. Encourage comments, subscriptions, ratings, embedding and sharing.

Get people to engage with your video in any way you can, and don't forget to respond to relevant comments – it's critical that your budding community feels that they matter and that you are taking them seriously. This is a key point to remember if you want to create a thriving community. Engagement is a massive factor in search engine rankings, so it is very important to focus on content – strong optimisation is no substitute for weak content.

To incite discussion, consider posting a comment as soon as you have uploaded a video, or adding an annotation to encourage feedback. Pose a provocative question to spark discussion and lead the conversation – the absolute key to success in the social media space is engagement.

Figure 7. *YouTube comments.*

5. Optimise the thumbnail.

Consider adding an enticing thumbnail frame. YouTube allows you to choose any moment in the video to be the thumbnail. Simply optimising the thumbnail image can encourage increased clickthroughs and views, which helps to increase search visibility.

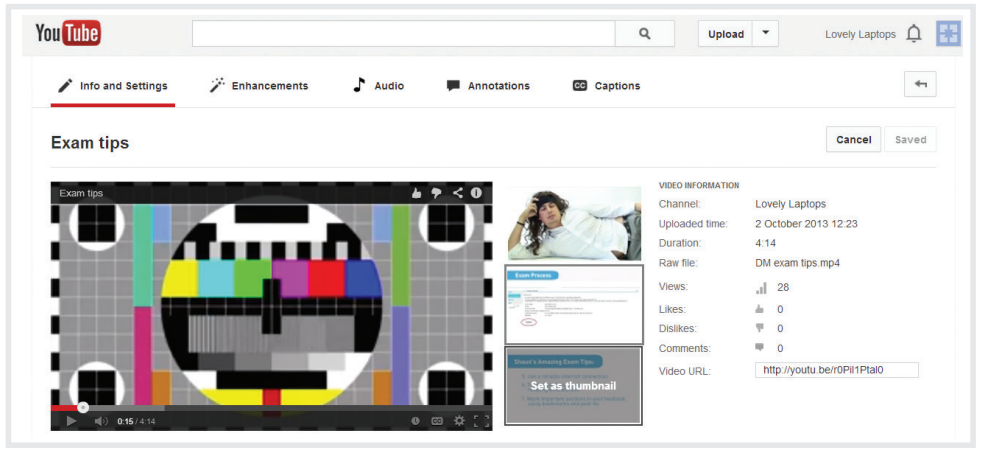

Figure 8. *Three thumbnail choices on a YouTube video.*

6. Use annotations

NOTE

A great way to use annotations is to link to some of your other videos at the end - this works similarly to "articles you may like" at the end of a blog post.

Use annotations to link to and from other video properties. Annotations allow you to add text boxes with clickable URLs (which are crawled by the search engine spiders as well) at points of your choosing in your video. Annotations in already popular and current videos can be used to drive traffic to new videos, although it should be standard practice to include them in a video as soon as it has been uploaded. It's also a great way to encourage viewers to subscribe to your YouTube channel.

The nature of YouTube is such that the number of views for pages on which videos are watched is always higher than channel views. However, if a paid search campaign is being run, the option to play clicked videos on the channel page exists. This is optimal as it could boost interactions with the branded channel header image, increase engagement with the playlist, and raise the channel view stats.

7. Upload videos regularly

Upload videos regularly to ensure continuous channel activity and topical interest. Consider the nature of the brand and what you are trying to communicate to your viewers; you must decide how often videos are uploaded. But remember, the more videos you upload, the higher your channel will rank as a result of Google picking up on your fresh content. Think of it like a TV schedule – let people know when your 'show' is on so they know when to come back.

The amount of content you upload is also dependent on the service or product your brand offers, and your video budget. It's a careful balance of not overloading your channel with useless media and keeping content fresh and engaging.

13.4.6 Promoting

We've covered promoting your video in detail in the next section. There are three ways you can promote your video – using owned, earned and paid media channels.

13.4.7 Engaging the community

As we mentioned earlier, it's essential that you engage with your community to keep them coming back for more. Respond in a timely manner to any comments or questions, and take feedback on your content into account when planning new videos. The audience won't stay hooked for long – after all, there are millions of new videos being added every day – so ensure that you engage with them to create a sense of community, the ability to relate to them, and genuine interest.

3.4.8 Reporting

As with all digital marketing tactics, in video marketing it's essential to track and analyse data about your activities, and then optimise your strategy accordingly. When creating video content, use the various measurement options available to determine what you can do better going forward.

YouTube Analytics is a free tool that enables anyone with a YouTube account to view detailed statistics about the videos they upload to the site. You can see how often videos are viewed in different geographic regions, as well as how popular they are relative to all videos in that market over a given period of time.

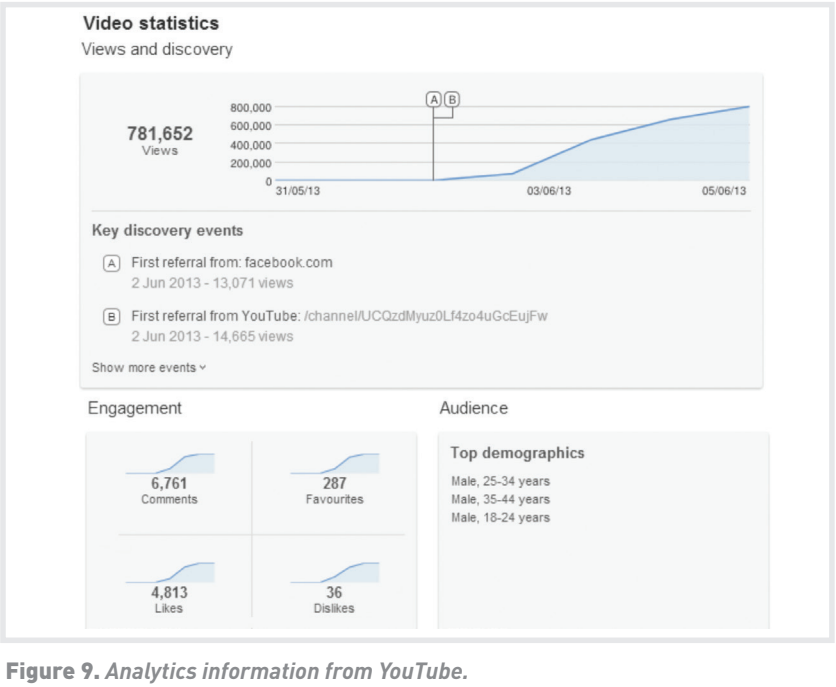

Figure 9. *Analytics information from YouTube.*

You can also delve deeper into the lifecycle of videos, such as how long it takes for a video to become popular, and what happens to video views as popularity peaks. YouTube even breaks down the specific seconds when people stop watching the video.

Using these metrics, you can increase your videos' view counts and improve popularity on the site. For example, you might learn that your videos are most popular on Wednesdays, that they have a huge following in Spain, or that new videos that play off previous content become more popular more quickly. If you see people dropping off halfway into the video, add an annotation to mix things up. There are many creative ways to approach this.

With this information, you can concentrate on posting compelling, fresh content that appeals to selected target audiences, and post these videos on days when you know these viewers are on the site. You could even go a step further and customise the video, dubbing it in Spanish (closed captions also support SEO efforts). The range of possibilities to customise – and optimise – your content is limited only by the brand's level of willingness.

Furthermore, you can access a breakdown of how viewers discovered a specific video, which can then be used to optimise the keywords, tags and descriptions of videos.

13.5 Video promotion

There are four main ways in which users find content and video online:

- A user knows what sort of video they are looking for and goes directly to a search engine to search for content. This relies on **SEO** (or search advertising, if you decide to promote the content on Google).
- A user follows recommendations from others, found through emailed links, social bookmarking and sharing services, or social media such as blogs, Twitter, Facebook, and YouTube. This relies on **social sharing**.
- Someone knows exactly what they are looking for and navigates to the appropriate URL directly. This relies on good **branding and market awareness**.
- The user finds the video through paid advertisements and promotions. This relies on **paid advertising**.

13.5.1 Earned video promotion

We covered the general guidelines for optimising your video for search earlier in this chapter. Here are some specific considerations for YouTube search optimisation, as well as social sharing.

YouTube video search optimisation

YouTube, which is owned by Google, is the dominant player in the video-sharing market. While we focus in this section on optimising for YouTube in particular, many of the same approaches apply to other video-sharing sites.

Once you've determined how users are already accessing your videos and where they appear in SERPs, you can use various techniques to improve your rankings.

While YouTube, like Google, keeps its search algorithms a closely guarded trade secret, digital marketers can speculate and experiment to see what works (and what doesn't).

Firstly, the following components are evaluated on a keyword and key phrase level by the search engine spiders:

- Titles
- Descriptions
- Tags
- Playlist additions
- Inbound links

Additionally, YouTube defines relevance in accordance with the popularity of a given video as well as the interaction taking place around it. The following factors play a dominant role in the algorithm:

- Video views
- Channel views
- Ratings
- Comments
- Shares
- Embeds
- Subscribers
- Age of video

Keeping YouTube content current and entertaining is vital if a video is very new. This will allow the video to engage with viewers. Remember, a new video growing in popularity (that is, views), will take preference in the SERP over an older video with more views.

Social sharing

You should initiate and encourage social sharing – ask your viewers to post your video on social networks, aggregators, social bookmarking sites and other channels. The more people share, the wider an audience you can potentially reach – and the more likely your video is to go viral (or, at least, spread far and wide). Social sharing and recommendations are also increasingly relevant ranking factors for search engines.

13.5.2 Paid video promotion

In the same way as with Google's search advertising, you can pay to have your video recommended on YouTube. You are able to bid on searches or popular videos, show pre-rolls on other videos, and have your video content displayed alongside the search results of other videos.

Paid promotions on YouTube are a cost-effective and quick way to promote video content, especially if the content is topical. It's targeted and controlled. For InStream, you pay only when a user watches 30 seconds or more of your video, or, if your video is shorter than 30 seconds, you'll pay only if they finish watching the entire clip. For InSearch and InDisplay, you pay per click on your video. This is a great opportunity for brand awareness, coupled with a potentially lower cost.

However, some users find this form of advertising highly intrusive, particularly in markets where bandwidth is slow and expensive, and it may take several seconds for the ad to load before it can be skipped. Some ad blockers block YouTube advertising.

YouTube offers a wide variety of video ad types:

- **TrueView In-Search**: These video ads appear to the right of the search results on the YouTube search pages. These ads are triggered by keywords, so it's important to know what users are searching for and ensure your ads contain the right keywords.
- **TrueView In-Display**: These ads appear to the right of the YouTube video the user is currently watching.
- **TrueView In-Stream**: These ads appear at the start of regular YouTube videos. Viewers have the option of skipping these ads after five seconds.

NOTE

The video you use for these ads doesn't have to be an advert in itself – you could choose to promote some of your regular video content too. Ensure that the key message appears in the first few seconds, to get viewers intrigued enough to keep watching.

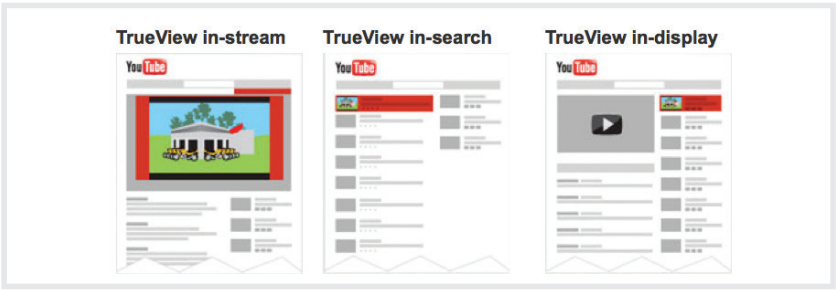

Figure 10. *YouTube advertising options.*

Be sure to check out the YouTube Trends dashboard (www.youtube.com/trendsdashboard) to stay on top of the most popular videos at any given time.

13.5.3 Owned video promotion

If you are hosting your video content yourself, you can and should still optimise the content around it for best search opportunities. As with posted video, it's the text content on the page with the video that is so important.

Make sure that your page title is descriptive, as well as the video title and the video file name. The text on the page with the video is important, so optimise it to reflect the content of the video.

You can also use speech-to-text software such as Blinkx or Spinvox to transcribe the video. The text can then be used in the video meta data.

Use social media sharing chiclets to make it easy for visitors to share the video on their social networks, aggregators and blogs. If you have a Facebook page, post it there. If you have a Twitter account – tweet about it!

And don't forget to drive website visitors to your video content – put a link or strong Call to Action on your home page or main landing pages, to encourage visitors to view and engage with your videos.

13.6 Tools of the trade

When it comes to video content, there is a wide range of tools at your disposal. Most of these are listed in the chapter already, so look at the relevant sections for pointers on what to use.

YouTube is the king of video content marketing and offers a full suite of tools – from video hosting and optimisation to paid advertising, analytics and social promotion.

AdWords for Video (www.google.com/ads/video) is a feature of Google's AdWords PPC tool that allows you to link your existing Google paid advertising account to your YouTube channel, and manage all your YouTube advertising from a single interface.

TubeMogul (www.tubemogul.com) is a video advertising tool that lets you buy paid video placements across the web. This simplifies the process of placing and paying for video adverts.

Feed (feedcompany.com) is a video seeding tool – a very handy thing to have if you host your videos on a variety of video platforms. Video seeders allow you to upload the video once, and then automatically upload that video to all of your chosen profiles and platforms for you.

Brightcove (www.brightcove.com) is a leading video hosting and publishing platform. Brightcove Video Cloud gives you everything you need to deliver professional quality video to audiences on every screen.

13.7 Advantages and challenges

Posting regular video content shouldn't result in any negativity, provided it is done in a focused, engaging way. Videos are great for engaging viewers and growing your social media community.

By studying analytics, platform insights and comments, you can see which videos on your channel are providing users with what they're looking for. You can then choose to advertise your best videos with the various formats YouTube and Google have on offer.

The number of views you get is an important factor in getting ranked or featured on YouTube and, by pushing your best content through the paid medium, you can get the ball rolling and significantly increase your chances of picking up organic traction (both within YouTube and Google's universal SERPs).

Starting out with video production can be a bit challenging as you learn the ropes of what makes a viewable, entertaining video. It can also be difficult to come up with constantly new and interesting ideas – but this will become easier with time.

Optimising video can also take a while to show results (as with normal SEO).

13.8 Case study – Woolworths: 'Cook like a MasterChef' for MasterChef South Africa

13.8.1 One-line summary

A case study about Woolworths and Quirk using video advertising and marketing to generate brand awareness, increase customer engagement and create product associations between Woolworths and MasterChef.

13.8.2 The problem

Woolworths is a premium national retailer that stocks apparel, food and homeware. As a MasterChef South Africa sponsor, Woolworths wanted to maximise this association for brand benefit. Their goal was to increase brand awareness for Woolworths through customer engagement, and highlight associations between their products and MasterChef South Africa. To meet these goals, Woolworths partnered with Quirk, a marketing agency specialising in creative, results-orientated digital marketing.

13.8.3 The solution

Quirk leveraged MasterChef-themed video content to launch MasterChef South Africa at scale on various digital platforms. The videos showed gourmet cooking of various cuisines to inspire

food enthusiasts. The video marketing strategy utilised the MasterChef brand to achieve its goals, which included:

- Producing great video content
- Effective targeting to drive traffic
- Engaging with users on platforms with video content

Producing great video content

The team made sure that their video content followed best-practice principles and provided lots of value to viewers in the form of great quality and entertainment. For example, they ensured that the first five seconds held the viewer's attention and clearly stated the benefits of watching the full video. They uploaded videos according to a consistent schedule to maintain audience interest and set expectations. Video titles were crafted to incite users to click, and formed part of a larger playlist, ensuring the viewer always knew where to click next.

Effective targeting to drive traffic

To ensure the campaign was a success, the team used a series of channels to drive traffic to the videos. Google search and display advertising, YouTube ads and Facebook advertising were used to drive paid traffic directly to the videos. Videos were also shared on the existing Woolworths blog, Facebook page and Twitter feed.

Quirk negotiated with Google to allow Woolworths to use YouTube functionality that allowed users to click out to the Woolworths site) from within videos. Externally linking directly to the Woolworths website from YouTube in this way was a first in Africa.

During the video, annotations directed viewers to bespoke recipe pages on the Woolworths online store, or subtly encouraged them to subscribe and share the videos easily with their connections.

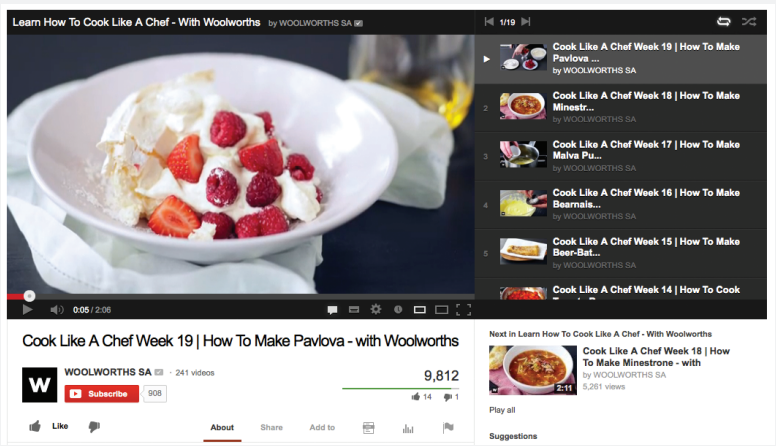

Figure 11. *One of Woolworth's 'Cook like a MasterChef South Africa' campaign videos.*

Engaging users directly

Engaging with users directly drives better engagement. Strategies to encourage this included asking viewers about their video experience and requesting suggestions for future improvements to be incorporated.

13.8.4 The results

The video marketing campaign achieved solid results and met all the intended goals. Throughout the process, the video content and campaigns were optimised with weekly insights, which were gathered from AdWords for video, YouTube Analytics and Google Analytics.

The aim was to get a view rate of at least 10% and a cost per view of under $0.20. The most cost-effective engagement and awareness driver was AdWords for Video. Between 20 March and 31 July 2012, it generated:

- Over 18.2 million impressions
- Over 109 000 views
- 17 332 clicks
- A cost per view (CPV) of $0.16.

Overall, the video content was well utilised to meet the brand goals, maximised reach and engagement of the video assets on relevant cost-effective platforms. Finally, it met the overarching goal of facilitating brand association with MasterChef South Africa and Woolworths.

13.9 The bigger picture

Video marketing can form the cornerstone of a great content marketing strategy, linking closely with the other content that you create to engage and provide value to your customers.

Videos can also be added to marketing messages such as email newsletters to improve engagement.

Because search engines serve a range of media types on their results pages, video content plays an important role in search engine optimisation. Not only can optimising videos for search increase your search engine ranking, but data show that it increases clickthrough rate from the search engine results pages, and that these visits are longer and more engaged than other search visits.

Social media provide a great tool for spreading your video, and video content can be a strong driver for people to join your social media platforms. Make sure that you provide great value.

13.10 Summary

Video has become an integral part of the online world. The potential for exposure – as well as interaction – is massive, and brands that fail to capitalise on this risk being left behind as competitors build thriving communities.

As with most content, it is up to the brand to decide how to represent its video content. Videos can be hosted on popular video-sharing websites to capitalise on already existing audiences and developed interfaces, or on bespoke websites that allow for free reign in customisation.

Brands should then aim to optimise their videos on the chosen platforms to increase their visibility on search engines.

Creating a healthy community is also important in increasing exposure. Very rarely, if ever, does an audience come to video content without input from the creators. On top of optimising for search and other tweaks, brands should upload content regularly or risk losing any ground gained.

Social media should also be considered as its platforms allow for the sharing of content, as well as commentary.

Overall, brands should be aware that there is no quick fix for video. It requires planning and investment as well as long-term commitment to creating brand advocates.

13.11 Case study questions

1. When producing video content, what key points do you need to keep in mind?
2. Why is the way in which the video appears as part of the playlist important?
3. What are the strengths and weaknesses of different types of paid advertising?

13.12 Chapter questions

1. Why should commenting on videos be encouraged?
2. What sort of personalisation would self-hosting of a video allow?
3. How do you feel social media affects video marketing?
4. What possible obstacles could a brand face when seeding a viral video?

13.13 Further reading

www.reelseo.com – Regularly posts updates and developments in the world of online video.

www.youtube-global.blogspot.com – YouTube's official blog. If there are announcements likely to affect a YouTube user, this is where you'll find them first.

mashable.com/category/online-video – Insightful and current articles on online video trends.

vimeo.com/channels/staffpicks – Curated Vimeo videos picked by staff members – some great creative inspiration.

www.reelseo.com/online-video-monetization-what-are-your-options – Some people aim to make money from their online videos by creating excellent content, rather than relying on marketing. Here are some guidelines about this.

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14 Social Media Channels

What's inside: An introduction to **social media channels** and **the important differences** between these and more **traditional forms** of media. You'll find an explanation of the categories into which these channels fall – **social networking**, **content sharing**, **aggregation** and **location** – as well as the powerful role they can play in the marketing process.

14.1 Introduction

In many ways, social media epitomises what the web is about: collaborating and sharing content, ideas and information. Social media is behind the explosion of content on the Internet, as various channels have allowed anyone with an Internet connection to create and share content easily and for free. Because social media has so many participants, it is also very dynamic. In fact, this is the chapter that is most likely to be out of date the second this book has gone to print.

Simply put, social media are media (from written to visual to audio) that are designed to be shared. Sharing means that it easy to comment on, send and copy the media, and that there are no high costs associated with this. And, because of the connected nature of the Internet, it means that sharing, commenting and viewing can all be tracked and measured.

Social media are also referred to as Web 2.0, consumer-generated media, citizen media and new media. In fact, comparing social media to traditional media is probably the most useful way of defining what exactly this means.

Traditional Media	Social Media
Fixed, unchangeable	Instantly updateable
Commentary limited and not real-time	Unlimited real-time commentary
Limited, time-delayed bestseller lists	Instant popularity gauge
Archives poorly accessible	Archives accessible
Limited media mix	All media can be mixed
Committee publishers	Individual publishers
Finite	Infinite
Sharing not encouraged	Sharing and participation encouraged
Control	Freedom

NOTE

You don't need sophisticated coding or technical skills to set up your online presence any more. Most services provide pre-made templates, widgets and tools that allow you to jump right in.

The Internet, and the software developed to run on it, has made it simple for anyone to publish and distribute media. It has also made it simple for anyone to access the content that has been published.

The realm of social media is about collaborating, creating content, sharing and, most of all, connecting.

This chapter focuses on the various social media channels, while the next chapter looks at how to use those channels strategically.

In this chapter, you will learn:

- The four main social media channels – social networking, content sharing, bookmarking and aggregating, and location-based media
- A wide variety of platforms that fall under these four channels
- How to track and measure your social media marketing success
- The best ways to engage with audiences on social media

14.2 Key terms and concepts

Term	Definition
Blog	A type of website that allows users (bloggers) to post entries on different topics and often allows readers to comment on these posts.
Blogosphere	The world of blogs, bloggers and blog posts.
Bookmarking	Saving the web address of a web page so that you can easily refer back to it. Bookmarks can be managed with a browser, or with an online tool.
Crowdsourcing	Taking a job traditionally performed by a professional and distributing it to an undefined, generally large, group of people in the form of an open call.
Chiclets	A small icon adjacent to a blog post, article or web page to indicate the availability of an RSS feed, or to allow users to share the information via social media. Named after the gum of the same name because of its unique, pillow-shaped icon.
Forum	A website where users can engage in discussions by commenting on threads or previous posts made.
iFrame	Stands for inline frame. An HTML structure that contains another document which you can draw information from another website to display, such as with Facebook tabs.
Microblogging	The practice of publishing brief text, image and video updates, usually limited to between 140 and 200 characters.
Permalink	A unique URL that points to the permanent location of a single blog post and its associated comments and TrackBacks.

Social network	In the online sense, a type of website model where individual members become part of a broader virtual community.
Tag	In social media, tags indicate or label what content is about.
Taxonomy	Classification and division into ordered categories, usually hierarchical. In social media, taxonomy can refer to the categorisation of content on the Internet.
TrackBack	A mechanism used in a blog that shows a list of entries in other blogs that refer to a post on the first blog.

14.3 Social media channels

Social media has changed the world of marketing. Social media is all about the ways in which we create, connect and share content online, and can be used as an integral part of an online marketing campaign.

To keep up with their audiences, traditional media have had to adapt. This has changed the way in which they publish, both online and offline, as well as how they can sell advertising.

For example, many newspapers now publish their content online as well as in their print publications. Online, they can get instant commentary on their articles. This snapshot of what their readers think can then be used to make editorial decisions. Print stories can be supplemented online with video, and this has been embraced by many news organisations. Visit www.bbc.co.uk/news/video_and_audio to see how one newspaper is using video online. News also comes from citizen journalists – people on the ground who post instant updates to social media about events unfolding around them.

The following chapter addresses the strategic use of social media to achieve a variety of outcomes. Here we look at the various social media channels. Categorising social media into channels is challenging, but it is a useful way to compare them.

And not all platforms fall neatly into one channel – for example, Twitter is part microblog, part social network, part aggregator, and even includes some location-based elements. We've categorised the platforms below according to their dominant properties, but always keep in mind that these aren't exclusive and may change as social channels adapt to meet their users' growing requirements.

Social media channels can be categorised as:

- **Social networks**: social channels that are built around social profiles.
- **Content creation**: using social channels to create and share content.
- **Bookmarking and aggregating**: social curation and sharing content.
- **Location**: a subset of social networks that are based on location.

NOTE

These are broad groups, not absolute categories. One platform could have the characterisitics of several channels, for example.

14.4 Social networking

Social networking refers to forming and maintaining online social networks for communities. The communities are people who share real-world connections, interests and activities, or are interested in exploring the interests and activities of others. And to complete the definition: building these social networks requires the use of software.

Social networking is all about using the tools of the Internet to connect and build relationships with others. Social networking sites such as Facebook (www.facebook.com), MySpace (www.myspace.com) and LinkedIn (www.linkedin.com) allow users to create personal profiles and then interact with their connections by sharing media, sending messages and blogging. Not only do social networking sites allow you to interact with the members of your own virtual Rolodex, but they also allow you to extend beyond your personal network. In addition, organisations – anything from businesses to bands and charities – can also create and maintain profiles on many of these networks.

Figure 1. *LinkedIn, a professional social network.*

Social networks have created new meaning for the term 'friend', with many connections existing solely online. In the realm of social networking, it is unnecessary to have met someone in order to connect with them.

NOTE

To see how much of your social data is being shared publicly, try logging out and viewing your profiles as an anonymous viewer. Are you surprised by what you see?

Personal profile pages remove much of the anonymity of the Internet. Users of social networks reveal a great deal of information about themselves, from basic demographics such as age, gender and location, to nuanced and detailed lists of likes and dislikes. They are also divulging this information to the networks, and hence to the networks' advertisers to allow more relevant targeting. Users tend not to be aware of the data that is amassing in their online profile, and this can lead to privacy risks and concerns.

Social networks can be general, such as Facebook, or niche, such as LinkedIn or Dopplr (www.dopplr.com). LinkedIn is a network for business professionals. Members connect to people they know professionally and are able to recommend members they have worked with. Dopplr is a social network for frequent travellers. Members can share their trips, and make plans to meet up when schedules overlap.

There are social networking platforms that allow anyone to build their own social network using the underlying technology of the platform. One example of this is Ning (www.ning.com).

14.4.1 Facebook

Facebook has become the most dominant personal social network in the world. According to official figures, over 1 billion people are now registered on the platform – that's one in every seven humans on earth – and more than half of them are active on Facebook every day (Facebook, 2013). Because people are spending so much time on Facebook, advertisers and marketers naturally want to capitalise on this audience.

Over the past few years, Facebook has launched a number of ways for brands and organisations to use the social network to connect with potential customers.

Pages

A Page is profile for a brand, organisation or celebrity. It looks very similar to a personal profile, and in the same way in which two people can add each other as friends on Facebook, people can choose to connect with a brand on Facebook by liking its Page.

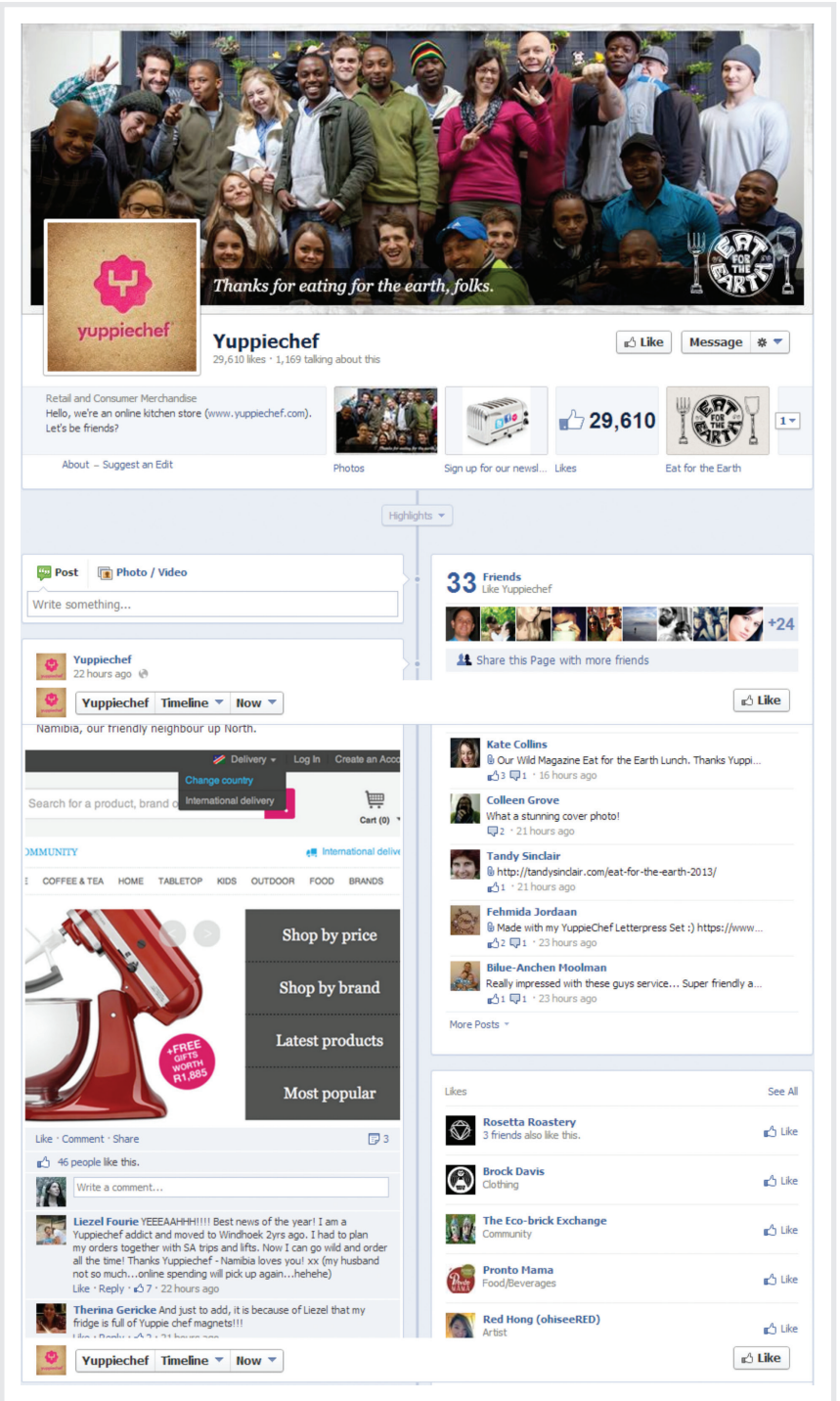

Figure 2. *The Yuppiechef brand page on Facebook.*

Each Page consists of the following elements:

- A cover image (the large banner at the top)
- A profile image that represents the brand
- Some 'About' information that can include links and more detailed information
- The 'Wall', where the brand's posts and interactions are displayed in a chronological timeline

Tabs are distinct pages of information on the brand's Page. Tabs can be used to house richer, more graphic content. Information in the tabs can be served through an application or through an iFrame, allowing for interactions within them.

Applications

Applications are developed by third parties, and include games such as Farmville (www.facebook.com/farmville), contests, virtual gifting, photo uploaders, interactive tools, and more.

Figure 3. *Facebook applications on the Skittles Facebook page.*

Applications are a way for organisations to create branded experiences for their Facebook fans. Sharing can be built right into the application, exposing it to the user's Facebook friends, and making it easier for the user to invite friends to use the application as well.

Figure 4. *The Budgetanator is an example of a Facebook application developed for Capitec Bank. It provides a convenient way for peope to manage their budgets.*

Facebook makes frequent updates that may affect applications, so they've made several developer resources available. The one to watch is the Developer Roadmap (developers.facebook.com/roadmap).

Promotions and competitions

Brands can run promotions and competitions through their Facebook Pages, but must ensure that they comply with Facebook's terms and conditions. Wildfire (www.wildfireapp.com) is an application that can be used to run promotions on Facebook.

NOTE

Read more about Facebook competition regulations here: www.facebook.com/page_guidelines.php

Facebook Connect

Facebook Connect allows users to log into services external to Facebook using their Facebook login details. They can then grant permission to have information, such as profile data and photos, shared between Facebook and the service they have logged in to. This can make it easier for users to log in to new services without having to create new usernames and passwords. They can also easily see who else in their social circle is using that service, and share information back to their social circle.

NOTE

You can set up your own Facebook Like button from here: https://developers.facebook.com/docs/reference/plugins/like/.

Like button

The Facebook Like button allows users to indicate that they like or recommend content, images, media or websites, and to share that recommendation with their social circle. The Like button can be used by any website, allowing visitors to recommend their site and content easily, and to see who of their friends might like the same content.

News feed

The news feed is the stream of content that users see when they log in to Facebook. It's a selection of recent posts and updates from their friends, and from the brands with which they have connected on Facebook. Facebook uses an algorithm, based on relevance to the user, to determine what information to show in their news feed.

This algorithm is called the News Feed Algorithm, and is a more sophisticated version of the original algorithm, which was called EdgeRank. According to an official Facebook update, the following factors are considered by the algorithm before it displays content in a user's news feed:

- Is this timely and relevant content?
- Is this content from a source you would trust?
- Would you share it with friends or recommend it to others?
- Is the content genuinely interesting to you or is it trying to game News Feed distribution? (e.g., asking for people to like the content)
- Would you call this a low quality post or meme?
- Would you complain about seeing this content in your News Feed?

  (Facebook, 2013)

Brands want their Page posts, stories and comments to appear in a user's news feed. The user is more likely to interact with content in the news feed, or to follow through to the page, than if there were nothing to prompt them. It is therefore vital to ensure that your page content takes this algorithm into consideration.

14.4.2 Google+

Google+ is Google's answer to social networking giant Facebook, and is slowly but surely being integrated into all of Google's products.

Google+ provides seamless ways to interact through Circles, Hangouts, Local information and more.

- Circles allows users to create customised groups (friends, family, classmates, and so on) and target their sharing to just the right people. By using Circles, users are able to limit sharing by breaking up their network into distinct clusters of contacts.
- Real-time communication is available through Hangouts, where users enter video chat rooms and let others know that they're interested in chatting. If users are already chatting within a circle, other circle members will be notified and can join in.
- Google+ Local integrates user data based on the person's location, and shares information about nearby businesses, events, places and user reviews pertaining to where the user is.

14.4.3 Social networking as a marketing tool

NOTE

People come to social networks to socialise and connect, not to see marketing messages; try to respect this by keeping your presence personal and valuable.

Social networks, which are usually free for their members, tend to rely on advertising for their revenue. Because demographic and psychographic information is collected by the social networks, advertisers are able to target their adverts to a very specific audience segment.

Most social networks offer opportunities for brands to create a presence on the social network, and to make use of the existing social network to connect with and reach out to customers.

14.5 Content creation

YouTube may be the first content-sharing site that comes to mind, but users share images, audio and other media, too. If it can be created, it can be shared. There are many sites that make it easy to share videos, images and audio, and they are exceptionally popular. From Instagram to YouTube, they have all tapped into the fact that we love to create content for others to view.

The key word here is free: there are no fees for joining, whether you are uploading or viewing content (although premium paid-for memberships can provide added features). This means that these sites attract an enormous audience. In fact, according to Alexa rankings, YouTube is the third largest website in the world (Alexa, 2013)!

Many of these services also encourage distribution of their content. YouTube allows videos to be embedded easily into other websites, and Flickr has generated a number of applications and widgets that allow the images to be shown all over the web (and even printed onto cards and stickers via www.moo.com).

Most of these websites rely on advertising to support the free services they offer. Some do, however, have premium memberships that are advert free.

14.5.1 Image sharing

People love to share photos, images, art and funny pictures online. Images tend to attract higher engagement than text-only posts (as you saw with Facebook's EdgeRank above).

Flickr (www.flickr.com) is a website that allows users to store and share their photos online. Users can publish these publicly or share them privately with chosen connections.

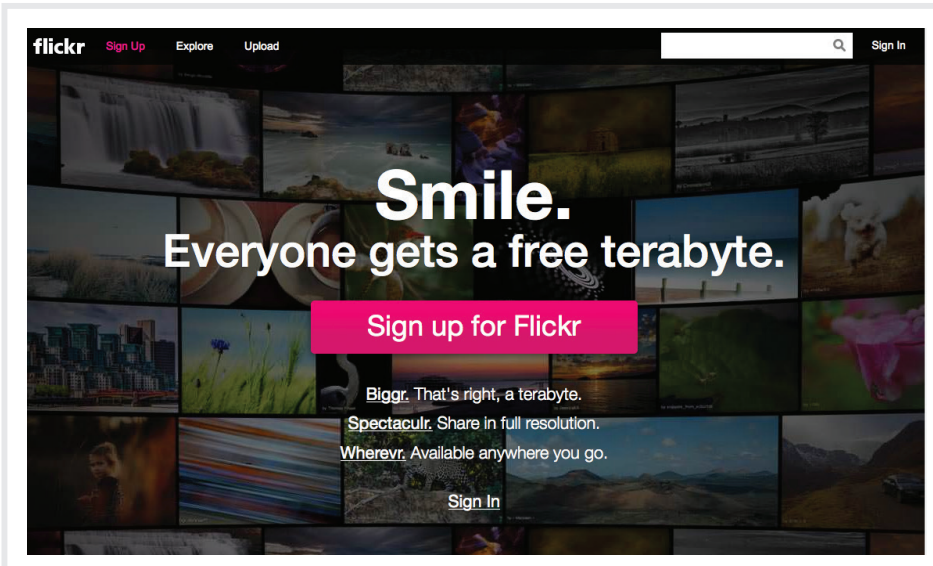

Figure 5. *Flickr.com, a photo-sharing network.*

NOTE

Instagram pictures can be labelled with a hashtag to categorise them - popular tags include #love, #me and #cute.

Instagram (instagram.com) is a mobile-based photo app that allows you to take a picture with your phone camera, and then add an interesting artistic filter to make it look polished and beautiful. These can then be shared on social networks for followers to view and comment on.

Pinterest (pinterest.com) takes image sharing to a new level by allowing users to create virtual pinboards of their favourite curated images (either their own ones, or images they have found online). These boards are usually grouped by topic or theme; images can be shared, commented on, or 'repinned' to another user's board.

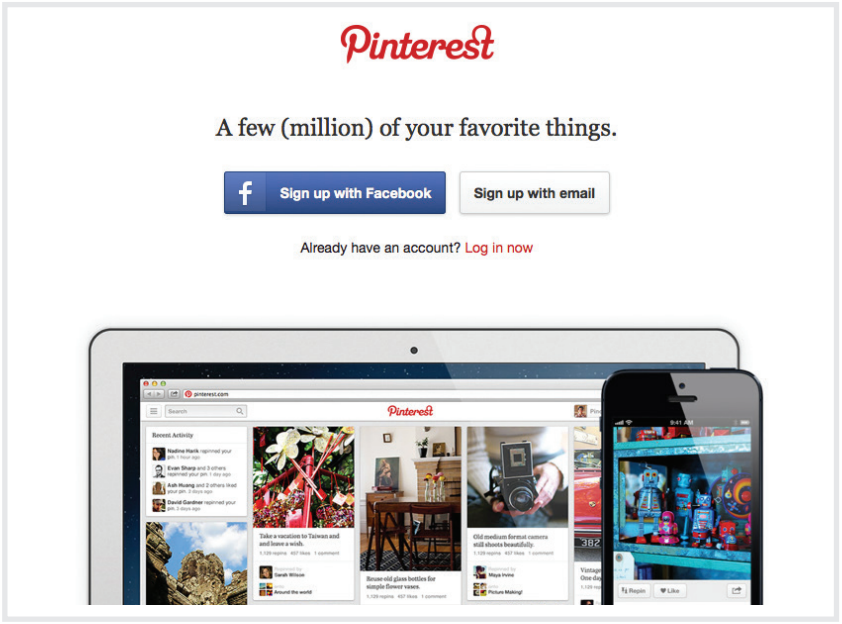

Figure 6. *Pinterest allows users to share their favourite images.*

14.5.2 Video sharing

Online video consumption continues to grow year on year as bandwidth gets faster and cheaper. Sharing video content is easy with social video sites such as YouTube. Anyone can upload videos captured on simple devices such as webcams and mobile phones, or on high-end professional cameras.

There are several video-sharing platforms. Some of the most popular include YouTube (www.youtube.com), Vimeo (www.vimeo.com), Instagram Video (instagram.com) and Vine (vine.co).

On YouTube, which is owned by Google, users upload 100 hours' worth of video every minute, and 4 billion hours of video are watched every month (YouTube, 2013). This makes it the premier social video-sharing site on the web. Most video consumption is based on social media – the top videos have succeeded because they have been spread virally over vast social networks – and over one billion unique users visit YouTube every month (YouTube, 2013).

YouTube offers many features to video uploaders and viewers, and is simple to use. While it is possible for unregistered users to watch most of the publicly available videos, a quick, straightforward registration process allows members to upload an unlimited number of clips, comment on and add video responses to them,

NOTE

Vine is a video-sharing tool that allows you to append six-second video clips to tweets on Twitter and Facebook.

NOTE

The most watched video in YouTube history is PSY's Gangnam Style music video, which has netted over 1.7 billion views.

and subscribe to content feeds that catch their attention and interest. Frequently enhanced functionality and clever features continually push YouTube to deliver bigger and better services to its ever-increasing user base.

YouTube and marketing

There are two aspects to marketing through YouTube: promoting video content through YouTube, and advertising next to (or during) content on YouTube.

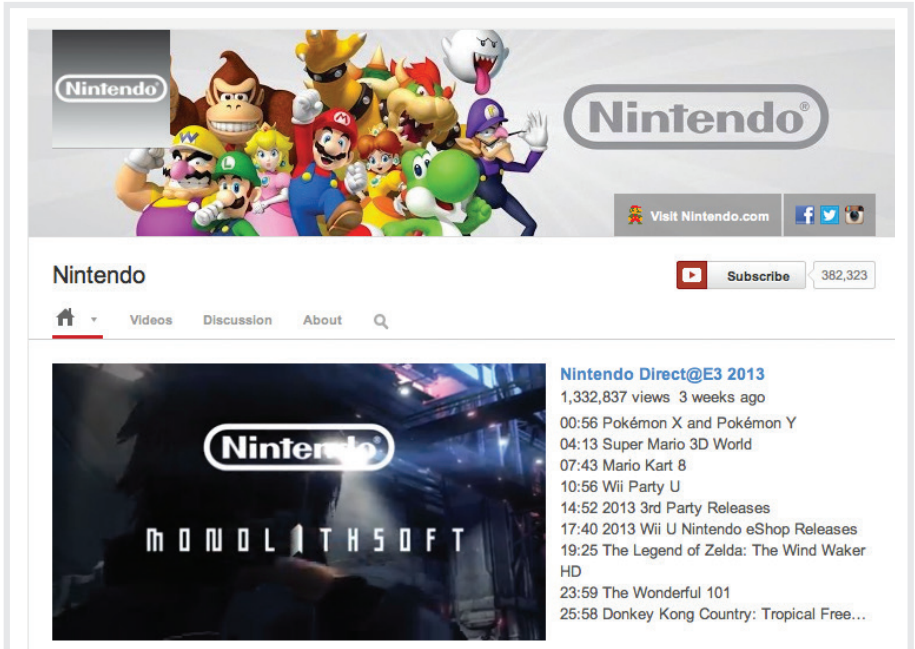

Figure 7. ***Content promotion through YouTube can be a powerful tool.***

YouTube offers Brand Channels. Brands can sign up for and customise their own channels on YouTube, adding backgrounds, logos, playlists and additional community features. Organisations and brands can also promote their own content using YouTube's Promote Your Video feature, and can post adverts through Google AdWords.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Video Marketing* chapter.

Using social services such as YouTube allows video creators to tap into an existing community of avid video viewers. For example, YouTube has changed the way we view video commercials. Marketers have shown that if an advert is good enough, many people will choose to watch it. Super Bowl commercials, for example, are highly anticipated each year, and the best ones receive millions of online video views. These are people who have chosen to watch this advert at a media cost of zero! Other advertisers have realised that far longer adverts can be created and uploaded. As long as the content is good, people will watch (and hopefully share). Time constraints are not the same as they are for television networks.

Online video sharing also makes it possible for conferences to generate a far greater audience than ever before. The companies that run these conferences are able to engage with a massive audience by posting videos of the conference presentations – an excellent example of content marketing. TED (www.ted.com) and Nokia's, which runs Nokia World, are excellent examples of organisations that increase interest by making their remarkable presentations available for free.

14.5.3 Blogging

A blog is a website where entries (blog posts) are typically displayed in reverse chronological order. Technorati, a blog and social media tracking engine, defines a blog as a "regularly updated journal published on the web". Blogs usually allow readers to comment on blog posts. A typical blog will feature text, images and links to other related blogs and websites.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Content Marketing Strategy* chapter.

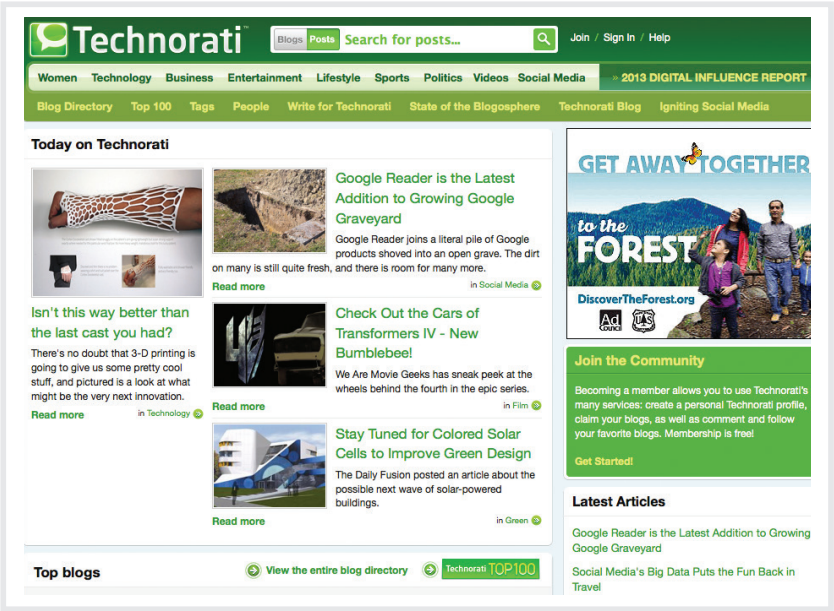

Figure 8. ***Technorati, a blog aggregator.***

Blogs can be about anything – from personal journeys to political commentary and everything in between. They can be written by one person or by a group or company. Some are aimed at the blogger's immediate family and friends, and others rival leading newspapers in terms of reach and readership. Blogs are mostly text based, but can comprise solely of images, videos, audio or a combination of any of these.

According to Wikipedia, by 2012, there were 77 million Tumblr blogs and 56.6 million WordPress blogs worldwide – that's a lot (Wikipedia, 2013).

The basic elements of a blog post are:

- **Author**: the person who wrote the blog post.
- **Title**: the title of the blog post, which is usually used to create a unique URL, or permalink, for the blog post.
- **Tag**: the categories used to describe the blog post, and aid services such as Technorati in categorising them.
- **Comment**: the comments left by readers of the blog, usually shown below the blog post.
- **TrackBack**: a notification of other blogs linking to a post, often displayed below the blog post.

Some other elements of a blog include:

- **RSS feed**: an RSS feed allows readers to subscribe easily to the blog.
- **Categories**: blog posts can be allocated to categories.
- **Blogroll**: a collection of links to other blogs or websites frequently read or used by the blogger.
- **Archives**: previous posts remain available for visitors to search through, and are usually categorised by date.

Whether blogging as an individual or a company, there is plenty to be gained from the process. You can:

- Create an online identity.
- Create a voice for yourself or your company.
- Promote engagement with your audience.
- Build a community.

Corporate blogging

Blogs can be very successful marketing tools. They're an excellent way to communicate with staff, investors, industry members, journalists and prospective customers. Blogging also helps to foster a community around a brand, and provides an opportunity to garner immediate feedback on developments.

Generally, the tasks that a blogger undertakes include:

- Writing posts
- Replying to comments from readers
- Monitoring other blogs within the industry
- Keeping up to date with the latest industry news
- Building relationships with other bloggers in the community
- Commenting on other blogs

It is important to outline a strategy and establish guidelines before starting a corporate blog, especially as there will most likely be a number of contributors. Transparency and honesty are important, but companies should also be aware of sensitive information being blogged. If there are 'no go' areas, they need to be clearly defined to the parties involved. While certain topics can be restricted, ultimately the bloggers should be granted the freedom to express both negative and positive points of view about the approved topics.

NOTE

It can take a lot of time for a blog to gain momentum – don't get discouraged if your audience is small initially, and stick to your content strategy.

Positive claims are more believable if the blogger is able to express negative views as well. For example, Robert Scoble, in his popular blog www.scobleizer.com, admitted that the Firefox browser was better than Microsoft's Internet Explorer. Robert Scoble was an employee of Microsoft at the time. This honesty gave him a credible voice, and so his positive views on Microsoft are respected by the community.

Corporate blog content should be:

- Industry relevant
- Appealing to your target market
- Transparent and honest
- Personal and entertaining
- Related to what's going on in the blogosphere
- Posted regularly

Blogging and SEO

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Search Engine Optimisation* chapter.

Search engines value regular, fresh content, and blogging can create just that. The more you post, the more often search engines will crawl your site, looking for additional, relevant content. Basing your blog on the keyword strategy created during the SEO process can also ensure that your website ranks for those key phrases. Blogs, by their social nature, can also increase the incoming links to your website.

Using a blog platform designed to be search engine-friendly is crucial to harnessing the SEO power of blogging. Some features of SEO-friendly blogging platforms:

- Each blog post should be assigned a unique page that can easily be accessed and indexed by the search engines (this is called a permalink).
- It should be possible to tag pages with keywords relevant to your SEO strategy.
- Each post should be able to have its own unique metadata (title, description and key phrases).
- Social sharing and bookmarking functionality should be built in.

Promoting blogs

While there may be around 200 million blogs on the web, it doesn't mean that all of these will still be up and running a year from now (Hughes, 2013). Longevity rests in the hands of the blogger, but here are some tips to raise the profile of a blog:

- **List the blog in blog directories**: while they're not as popular as search engines, many Internet users do visit them when looking for information. Examples include Blogarama (www.blogarama.com), Bloggeries (www.bloggeries.com) and BlogCatalog (www.blogcatalog.com).
- **Ping web services with updated content**: sites such as Ping-o-Matic (pingomatic.com) and Feed Shark (feedshark.brainbliss.com) offer a service whereby they ping multiple web services, blog directories and search engines to let them know that a blog has fresh content.
- **Use TrackBacks**: If a blogger writes a new post commenting on, or referring to, an entry on your blog, and both blogging tools support the TrackBack protocol, then the commenting blogger can notify your blog with a 'TrackBack ping'. The receiving blog will typically display summaries and links of all the commenting entries below the original entry. This allows for conversations spanning several blogs that readers can easily follow.

- **Participate in the blogosphere**: You can't expect anyone to engage on your blog if you're not engaging on theirs. It's all about fostering a sense of community.
- **Make use of aggregators**: Examples of aggregators include Technorati and Reddit (www.reddit.com).

Blogs as a marketing tool

Blogs are powerful because of their reach, their archives (information is seldom deleted and is thus available long after it has been posted) and the trust that other consumers place in them. For a marketer, they present opportunities to learn how others perceive your brand and to engage with the audience. Some brands get this right; some get it wrong.

We've provided some guidelines for corporate blogging, but marketers do not need to be bloggers to benefit from this tool. As with all other social media, blogs provide a snapshot of audience sentiment regarding a brand. Marketers can also listen to blog activity around competitors to gain market insights.

Although blogging is the best way to engage with bloggers, companies can also interact with bloggers by commenting on relevant posts. Demonstrating the capacity to listen to bloggers and then respond using the same medium can reap tremendous benefits with this community.

Blogging platforms that can be used to set up a blog quickly and easily include:

- WordPress (www.wordpress.com)
- Tumblr (www.tumblr.com)
- Blogger (www.blogger.com)

NOTE

Tumblr is a unique blogging platform that encourages very short posts, usually featuring images. It falls somewhere between a blog and a microblog.

14.5.4 Microblogging

Microblogging is a form of blogging that allows a user to publish short text updates, usually limited to 140 characters, that can be viewed by anyone or restricted to a specific community. The most popular microblogging service is Twitter (www.twitter.com), which was launched in July 2006. These 140-characters posts, called tweets, are usually short thoughts or links to interesting articles. As of June 2013, Twitter has more than 500 million members, with 400 million Tweets being written each day (Smith, 2013).

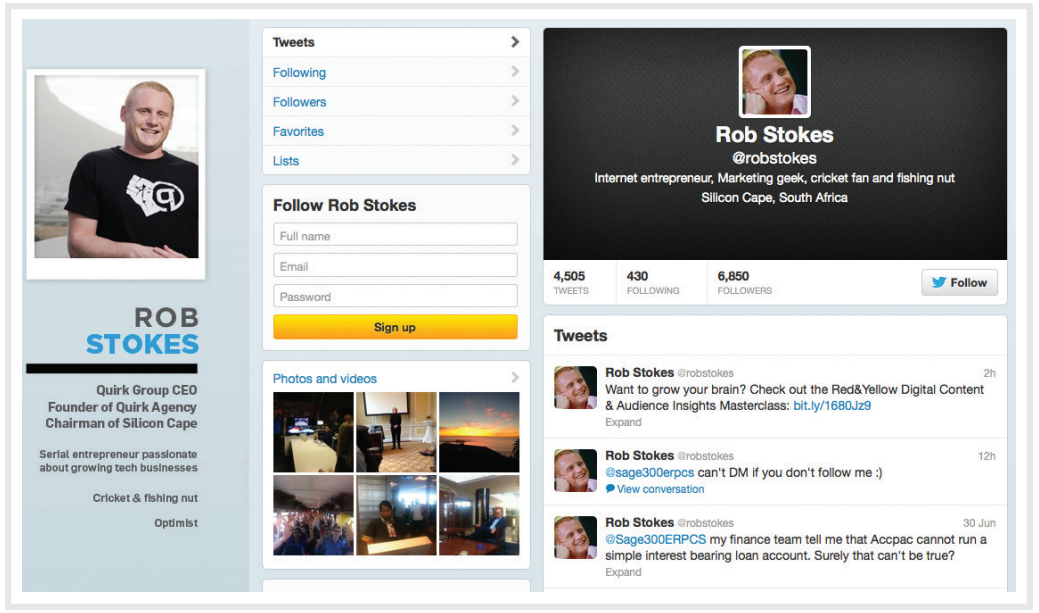

Figure 9. *Profiles on Twitter can be branded to represent your organisation's identity.*

Twitter has some specific jargon that it's worth knowing:

- **Tweet**: A post on made on Twitter.
- **@username**: users are denoted with @ and their chosen name (e.g. @robstokes for www.twitter.com/robstokes). Tweets can be directed to a specific user simply by typing their @username at the start of the tweet.
- **Hashtag**: users can categorise their posts by adding a word or phrased prefaced with the # symbol (for example, #DigitalMarketing). The hashtag will become a link that you can click to see other tweets that share this tag. You can also choose to follow a hashtag, meaning that you will see all public messages with that tag, whether you follow the user or not. This can be a very useful way of collating information at events such as conferences. If you're not at the event, you can still follow messages from the event by following the hashtag. For those at the event, all tagged messages can be broadcast in a shared location.
- **Trending**: if a hashtag or keyword is used very frequently in a short time, it can become a trending topic and is displayed to the left of a user's tweet stream. Events of global interest usually feature heavily, but sometimes brands can trend, too (although not always for the right reasons).
- **Retweet (RT)**: retweeting means reposting somebody else's tweet to your own profile, along with their user name. The letters RT are usually added to the start of the tweet to indicate that it comes from someone else.

NOTE

Trending topics can be global, national or focused around a smaller area, like a city.

Twitter has proved immensely valuable in breaking events, where real-time information is useful and powerful. For example, Twitter users broke the news of events such as the 2013 Boston Marathon bombings.

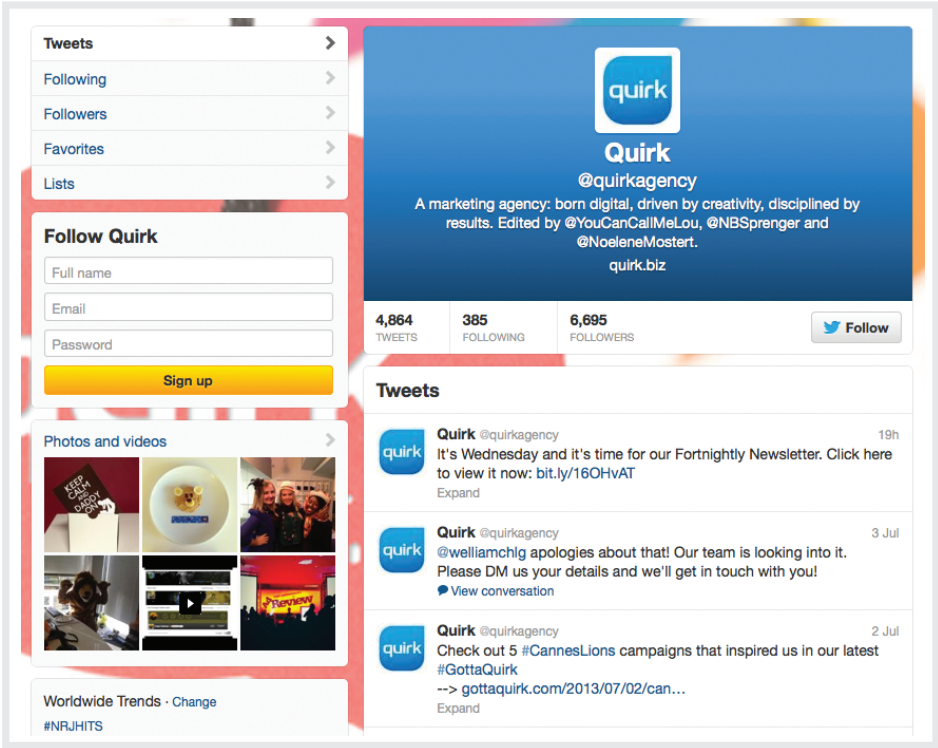

Figure 10. *A Quirk Twitter feed (www.twitter.com/quirkagency).*

Twitter as a marketing tool

Twitter has become a popular and important marketing tool for many organisations, brands and individuals. Many brands use it successfully for rapid customer service (for example, @comcastcares, @klm and @mwebguy).

Its immediacy allows for news to be broadcast to dedicated followers and fans first, as pop star Lady Gaga has done with single releases (@ladygaga).

Dell lists several Twitter channels (www.dell.com/twitter), many of which exclusively release offer information (@delloutlet).

Twitter also has a series of self-service advertising options, which are covered in detail in the module on online advertising. These include Promoted Tweets, Promoted Accounts and Promoted Trends.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Online Advertising* chapter.

14.5.5 Podcasting

NOTE

Have a look at the National Public Radio podcast shows as one good example of a traditional radio broadcast embracing podcasting: http://www.npr.org/rss/podcast/podcast_directory.php

A podcast is a digital radio (or video) programme downloadable from the Internet. It is possible to subscribe to a podcast as one would to a blog. You can listen to a whole range of programmes and voices; just as blogs have allowed people to become writers without having to deal with a media channel controlled by someone else, podcasting has allowed anyone who fancies doing so to become a broadcaster. Many traditional radio shows are now also available in podcast format.

'Podcatching' software allows you to download the latest edition of any podcast you subscribe to automatically. Most people use iTunes – go to www.apple.com/itunes/store for loads more information on podcasting and a huge list of available podcasts. You can listen on your computer or transfer the file to an iPod or MP3 player. Podcasts are usually free, and the most successful ones have very high-quality content and production value.

Creating a podcast

Podcasts are usually recorded and edited using home equipment, and done for the love of it. There is specialised podcasting software available, such as Apple's Garage Band or QuickTime Pro. These packages make it quite simple to record, mix and format the audio files correctly. Just like bloggers, though, many podcasters are trying to figure out ways of making money from their podcasts and turn listeners into revenue.

Podcasts as a marketing tool

Podcasts offer an incredible opportunity for marketers. The bottom line is that you now have a way of getting content to your target markets without having to persuade a media channel to carry it or to pay huge advertising rates.

Podcasts are:

- **Targetable**: you can create highly relevant, niche content and then promote it to a specific target market.
- **Measurable**: you can see exactly how many downloads and subscribers you have.
- **Controllable**: it's your content.
- **Responsive**: set up a blog alongside your podcast and alter content according to the comments; you are actually having a conversation with your market.
- **Boundary free**: it's the Internet.
- **Relatively inexpensive**: the equipment, software and skills are readily and cheaply available, and there are few or no distribution costs.

However, the content must be:

- **Excellent quality**: like anything on the Internet, it is just as easy to unsubscribe as it is to subscribe. Quality content is what keeps listeners coming back.
- **Real and valuable**: while there is value in having product or service information embedded in a website, there is no point at all in producing an audio version of a company brochure as a regular podcast. Consumers are losing faith in the content of traditional media. Even if editorial is not actually paid for, a lot of the time it has been influenced in some way by advertisers. Although there are podcasts that carry adverts, people can fast forward straight past them, and the chance of real success lies in branded content.

This is not about advertising or even just product information. It is about coming up with ideas for real programmes that, through informing or entertaining, enhance your customers' experience of your brand.

14.6 Bookmarking and aggregating

If there are websites you visit often, or that you would like to keep as a reference to come back to, it is easy to use your browser to 'bookmark' them. This means that you store the URL so that you can locate it again easily. It also gives you a personal library of websites that you can store on your computer.

Social bookmarking sites, however, allow you to store these links online, use tags to describe them, and share these lists with other users. Some of these sites allow you to submit URLs that other users vote on, while others allow you to use the tags saved to browse through the lists and libraries that have been generated.

Websites that encourage users to submit content to bookmarking and aggregating sites use chiclets. These are buttons placed around the content that make it easier to submit and share the article.

Figure 11. ***Examples of chiclets.***

These services allow you to see what the community of web users finds useful, interesting or humorous. You are able to find other users with similar interests to yours, and explore the websites that they have found that you might not have come across yet.

Content submitted to a social bookmarking or aggregating site can dramatically increase traffic to a website, and expose the site to many new views.

Delicious (www.delicious.com) is a social bookmarking site designed to help Internet users organise online media in a quick, easy-to-access and user-friendly format. The primary function of Delicious is to allow you to store all of your bookmarks online and then access those bookmarks from any computer anywhere in the world. Delicious is more of a community-based tool than other social bookmarking sites, as it allows others to see your bookmarks. Essentially, it lets you identify other people whose interests and concerns parallel yours and grants you access to all of their bookmarks as well.

Digg (www.digg.com) and **Reddit** (www.reddit.com) are sites where users submit content that other users can vote on. Popularity, based on votes, moves the submitted content up and down the rankings. Submitting and voting requires registration, but there are many people who visit these sites just to get an overview of content that is 'hot'.

NOTE

Some aggregators, like Reddit, also have lively discussions about the content shared. If you want to get involved on behalf of your brand, ensure you build up a respected presence in the community first.

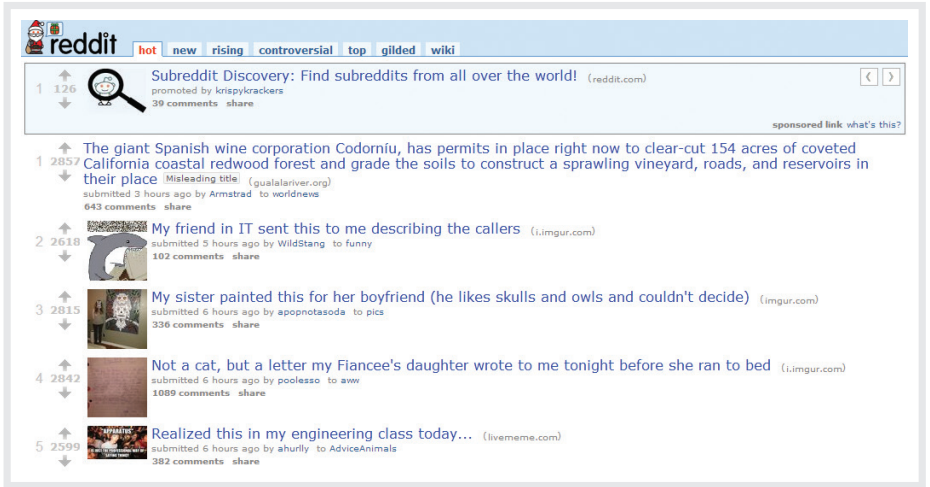

Figure 12. *Reddit.com, a social aggregator.*

Appearing on the top of these lists generates a huge increase in traffic for the content sites, so much so that servers can crash if the leap in visitors is unexpected. Getting into the top listings is the goal of many a marketer, but any attempt to manipulate listings usually backfires and can generate plenty of community backlash.

The communities around these sites differ demographically, and this is reflected in the content. For example, Digg has been technology focused, while Reddit tends to feature more general news.

Stumbleupon (www.stumbleupon.com) allows you to explore the web through your interests, based on how other web users tag content. Users select categories of interest and bookmark URLs to those categories. You can then choose to 'stumble' through the web using the category of your choice. The service will randomly show you a website that has been submitted to that category.

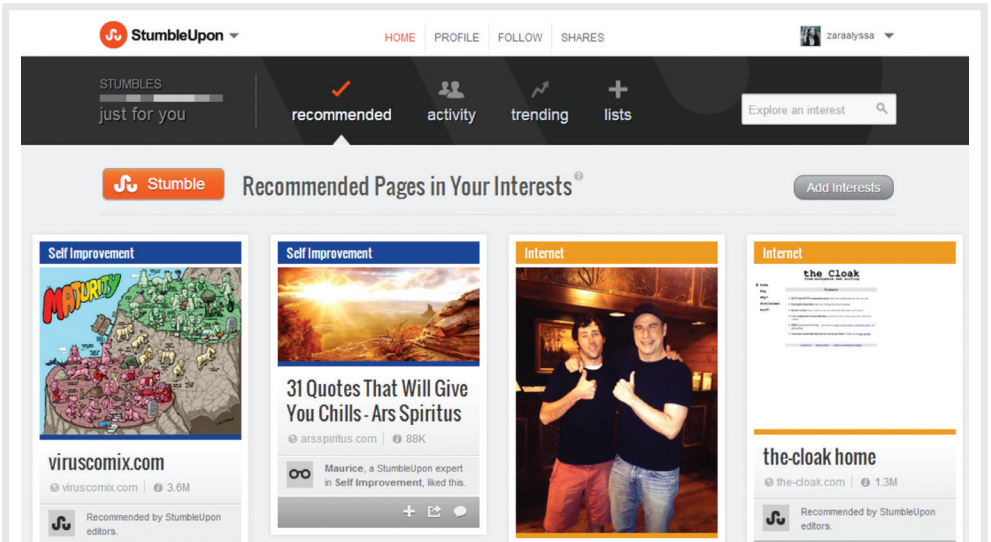

Figure 13. *Stumbleupon is another approach to a social aggregator.*

14.6.1 Bookmarking and aggregating as marketing tools

Seeing how users categorise your content will give you an idea of how your audience perceives your website and company. It may be remarkably different from what you think they see you as. Look at other websites which are tagged similarly. You may find new competitors, and possibly new ideas.

You can also use these services to share what other URLs your company finds interesting. This can be a useful resource to add to an online press room, as well as a utility that fanatics of your company would get really excited about.

To generate links and traffic, investigate the sort of content for which your target audience loves voting, and create that content. A word of warning: never do the content submission and voting yourself. It's one sure-fire way to incur the wrath of these communities.

Organic growth is the only way to go here. It may take time as you build your reputation and value among the community, but the end result can be very worthwhile.

14.7 Location and social media

Social media have also seen the introduction of location services such as Foursquare (foursquare.com) and Facebook Places (www.facebook.com/about/location). These services allow users to 'check in' at locations they visit with equipment such as mobile phones and tablets.

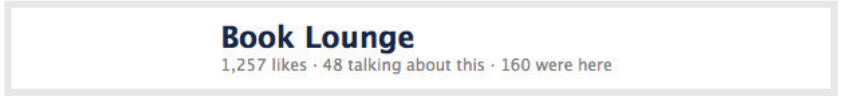

Figure 14. *Users can check in at physical locations on Facebook.*

By checking in, users are able to share their location with their friends and find others who are checked in as well. Depending on the tool, they can add reviews, post messages and upload photos of the locations they are checked into. Foursquare lets users become 'mayors' of locations they have visited more than anyone else.

These location services appeal to marketers for a number of reasons, since they can obtain, engage with and retain customers by leveraging their interactions with the real-world. For instance, if people see their friends checking in at certain places, they are more likely to want to go there, particularly if their friends have posted a positive review of the location.

These services also offer rewards and special deals to users who have checked in, incentivising them to return and share the location with their friends. Starbucks offers a range of location-based incentives, for example, offering all mayors of Starbucks stores a discount at any branch.

14.8 Tracking social media campaigns

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Data Analytics* chapter.

As with any digital marketing tactic, you need to be able to track and measure your campaigns in order to understand how successful they are, and what you can do to improve them.

With most social networking channels, you do not actually host your presence, which means that custom tracking is limited. There is often a strong reliance on the built-in tracking offered by the various channels, although new third-party tracking services are emerging and offering competitive and sophisticated tools (often for a fee). In some cases, it is also possible to integrate tracking to some extent if you are directing traffic to a web property that you own.

14.8.1 Facebook Insights

Facebook Insights is available to page administrators, and provides data on how people are interacting with your content and your page. This includes demographic information about the people connecting with your content (age, gender and location breakdown), which tabs and which content posts are seen and interacted with, and how many people hide your content from their news feed, and when. There is also data that shows how people got to your page.

14.8.2 YouTube Analytics

YouTube Analytics is available to all YouTube users for their videos and channels. As well as showing video views and popularity broken up by geographical territory, there is some demographic information shown as well. Discovery data shows how people got to your video.

One of the most useful reports for any video is audience attention, showing when people stop viewing a video, or rewind sections of video, and comparing this to videos of a similar kind.

NOTE

You can also see where people watched the video - did they come to the dedicated YouTube watch page, or did they view the embedded video in a website, email newsletter or social profile?

14.8.3 Twitter Analytics

Currently, Twitter Analytics is available only to Twitter advertisers, but there are a number of tools that use the Twitter API to provide analysis. HootSuite's Twitter management tools have built in analytics (www.hootsuite.com), and Twitalyzer (www.twitalyzer.com) is another tool that can provide insightful data.

Important metrics for Twitter include how many people interact with your content by clicking through on links, replying to you or retweeting messages.

14.8.4 Click tracking with URL shorteners

URL shorteners offer analytics that show how many people are clicking on links, when they are clicking, and where in the world they are. When you are sharing links on services like Twitter, you should be tracking this data. When selecting a URL shortener, consider whether or not they keep the click analytics private.

URL shortening services provide an easy way to share long links by generating a short URL that redirects to the original link. This is especially important when sharing links in messages with limited character counts, such as tweets.

There are several URL shortening services: bit.ly, goo.gl and ow.ly are three examples, and some websites have their own bespoke services, such as nyti.ms for The New York Times (which is excellent for reinforcing brand recognition).

For example, we may want to tweet a link to a blog post on GottaQuirk, Quirk's blog. The URL to a post may be:

http://www.gottaquirk.com/2013/02/08/my-quirky-tips-for-digital-marketing/.

That's 89 characters!

Using bit.ly, a URL shortening service, the link becomes: http://bit.ly/153sjC6. It's now just 19 characters long, and can be tracked.

Even better, some link shorteners allow you to customise your link, so the result could be: http://bit.ly/QuirkyTips, which is much easier to read and share.

14.8.5 Web analytics for social media

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Data Analytics* chapter.

Web analytics software such as Google Analytics plays a part in social media tracking. On Facebook, tracking script can be inserted in applications and tabs where content is served through an iFrame. When you are sharing links to your own site and content, campaign tracking parameters can be used to track the source of visits and report on them in your web analytics tool.

NOTE

You can easily create a tagged campaign tracking URL with Google's URL Builder: http://support.google.com/analytics/answer/1033867?hl=en.

For example, we may use campaign tracking before we shorten the URL, so the URL before shortening becomes: http://www.gottaquirk.com/2013/02/08/my-quirky-tips-for-digital-marketing/?utm_source=twitter&utm_medium=social_media&utm_campaign=ORM

The campaign tracking is appended on the end of the URL:

?utm_source=twitter&utm_medium=social_media&utm_campaign=ORM

14.9 Social media marketing: Rules of engagement

Social media implies a democratisation of information, and requires authenticity and openness from those who deliberately use it for marketing. This means that good and bad stories spread and stick around. Jeff Jarvis may have had problems with Dell way back in 2005, but you can easily find all the relevant information with a quick Google search for 'Dell hell'.

Although they are engaging publicly with a wide audience, marketers need to remember that they are communicating with individuals. While marketers should engage in the conversation, and possibly lead it, they cannot control it.

Marketing to content creators

Because they are so influential, approaching online influencers should form a part of any PR strategy.

Supply content creators with the tools and resources they need to talk easily about your product, including links to your social profiles, Twitter handles and hashtags.

Marketing to content consumers

Social media allow anyone to have a say, and the same tools that are available to individuals are available to companies. Company blogs allow a brand to build a personality and to interact with their target market. Entertainment created and spread via social media increases brand touchpoints. Using the same channels that are available to your consumer aids in understanding the consumer, and levels the plane of conversation.

When using social media to reach out to content consumers, go to where your consumers are. The media you use is dictated by your users. For example, a nightclub for students can create a Facebook Page to advertise its weekly specials, and interact with fans, while Land Rover enthusiasts may be more comfortable with a discussion forum.

With all interactions, marketing messages need to be clearly identified and labelled, with a disclaimer added if necessary. Trying to hide them as something else will only decrease your authenticity.

Marketing to content sharers

Content sharers are content consumers who also pass your message on, whether it's by chat or email, by sharing a link on a blog or by submitting your content to a bookmarking or aggregating service. They are a crucial link in the chain that passes your message around. Make it as easy as possible to share your content by using chiclets and unique and easy-to-read URLs.

Advertise on social media platforms

While marketers can use the tools of social media to convey their message, the characteristics that define a social media website are also important. Social media allows users to express themselves, and this means that demographic information can be compiled to allow for more useful and targeted advertising. This presents

many opportunities for targeting advertising, and for finding creative ways to reach an advert-fatigued demographic. It also introduces the risk of dealing with personal information – make sure you're up to speed with the relevant laws in your country.

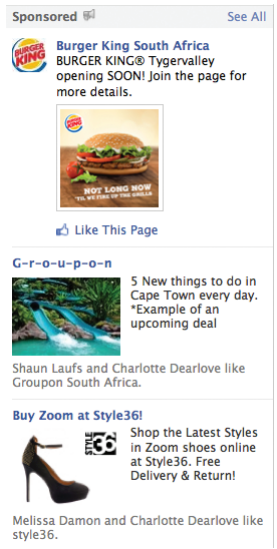

Figure 15. *Facebook ads are often used as a form of targeted advertising.*

14.10 Tools of the trade

As a content creator, there is a plethora of platforms for the budding social media enthusiast. Throughout the chapter, we have listed the URLs for some of the most popular services, most of which are free.

14.11 Advantages and challenges

People are finding it easier to switch off or ignore traditional advertising, particularly through traditional media environments such as TV or radio. Social media gives brands the opportunity to interact with customers through relevant and targeted communications that customers can choose to engage with on their terms. For example, a consumer may visit a branded YouTube channel as opposed to deliberately ignoring advert breaks on television.

Social media's potential to go viral is one of its greatest benefits – if users like your content, they will share it with their own communities. It also allows marketers to capitalise on the creativity of their consumers to spread their message further, often at very low cost.

NOTE

It's nearly impossible to craft content that will "go viral" - you can never know what users will pick up on or ignore. Instead, aim to make amazing content that your audience will appreciate.

Social media allows you to engage with an online community and allows you to connect your brand to the appropriate audience, creating an online community for your brand and its supporters. Social media has created a forum for brand evangelists.

The numerous interactions allow you to garner feedback from your communities, which helps drive both future business insights and innovation, as well as marketing strategies. You can learn more about your audience's likes, dislikes, behaviours and needs.

However, companies need also be aware that bad messages spread as quickly as good ones, and the connectedness that can prove so useful can also be a conduit for negative messages and brand attacks.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Social Media Strategy* chapter.

Social media facilitates a two-way conversation between customer and company. This necessitates that the company shifts approach from 'deploy and watch' to one of constant involvement with the audience.

This new landscape is one in which the customer really is king, and any attempt to dethrone the king can have dire consequences. Efforts to control the conversation in social media are soon found out, and can backfire horribly. Any company embarking on a social media strategy needs to be sure to monitor their reputation online regularly. It is crucial to know what is being said in order to be able to respond timeously and communicate in the social media sphere.

Finally, never forget that special rules and laws apply when you are dealing with personal information provided by users – be very careful how and where you use this data.

14.12 Case study – Col'Cacchio #PriceSlice

14.12.1 One-line summary

Col'Cacchio, a popular South African pizzeria chain, created a solid social media footprint and encouraged pizza lovers to tweet for discounts.

14.12.2 The problem

Col'Cacchio wanted to create a social media strategy that would grow an engaged community and tie into their overall marketing objectives.

The challenge lay in finding a unique and innovative mechanism to drive their social media presence. The brand had already established a Facebook brand page, as well as a Twitter profile with around 2 100 followers. However, content on these channels had been largely promotional in nature, as opposed to tactical or engaging.

The key lay in leveraging their existing efforts to drive awareness, and ultimately increase ROI. They also needed to define the brand identity and tone of voice through their social media channels.

14.12.3 The solution

To achieve this, Col'Cacchio partnered with the social media team at Quirk to create the #PriceSlice Twitter campaign, a pay-with-a-tweet-inspired activation that would encourage Twitter users to eat more pizza.

The campaign had the following objectives:

- Increase the number of Twitter followers
- Increase consumer engagement
- Drive in-store sales

The campaign mechanism was simple yet effective, working on the basis of value exchange – tweets for discounts. Twitter users were prompted to tweet a message using the #PriceSlice hashtag, and the more tweets the hashtag received, the higher the in-store discount on Col'Cacchio pizzas.

Figure 16. *The landing page for the Price Slice campaign.*

As people tweeted, Quirk automatically captured and recorded them. Once they reached a certain level, the temperature would rise on the thermometer represented on the campaign landing page.

Figure 17. *The campaign landing page with the thermometer showing a R10 discount.*

The campaign also involved in-person activation through blogger engagement. Pizzas were delivered to selected bloggers, with the campaign message secretly hidden beneath the pizza slices.

14.12.4 The results

The campaign got off to a great start. After one hour, the #PriceSlice hashtag was trending in Cape Town, and within three hours both @Colcacchio and #PriceSlice were trending in South Africa:

Figure 18. *A Tweet showing the brand trending on Twitter.*

The results in the campaign showed the following:

- A total increase of 23% in Twitter followers through the course of the campaign, and in the days following it.
- Around 21% of the campaign website visitors returned to the site more than once, indicating that they were following the discount and were likely to visit a Col'Cacchio branch to take advantage of it.
- The campaign achieved a great deal of PR and blogger engagement through a variety of posts crafted around the campaign mechanism:

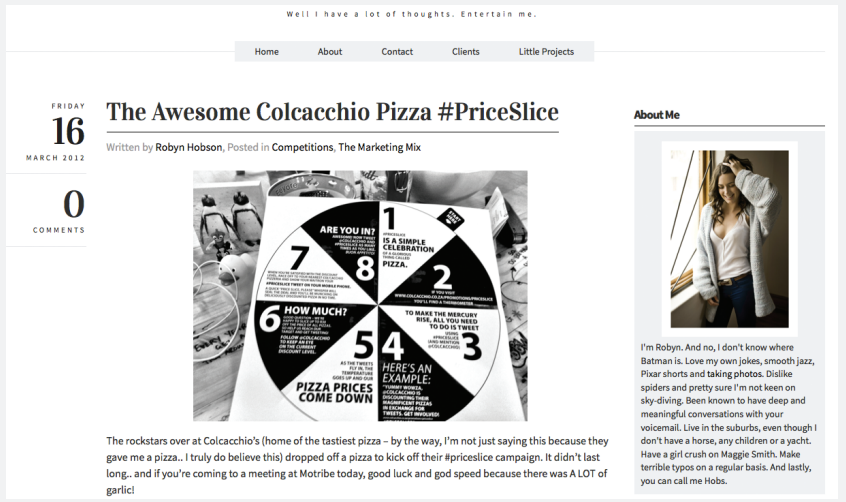

Figure 19. *A blog post promoting the brand.*

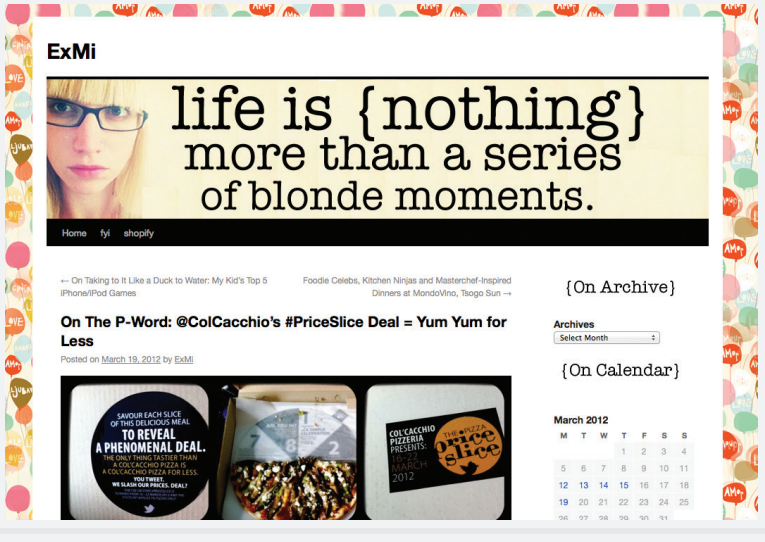

Figure 20. *A blog post promoting the brand.*

During the course of the campaign, the Quirk social media team closely monitored the campaign and noted some other interesting observations:

- The campaign seemingly drew new individuals to the Twitter platform, since a number of users created Twitter accounts simply to participate in the promotion.

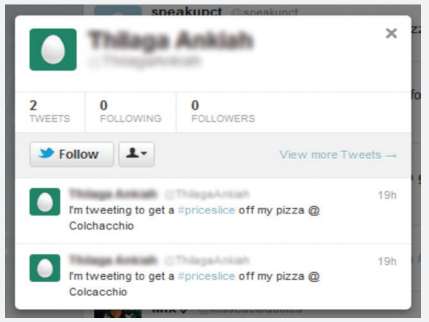

Figure 21. *Tweets using the #PriceSlice hashtag.*

Even bloggers not targeted through the pizza delivery activation crafted posts about the promotion:

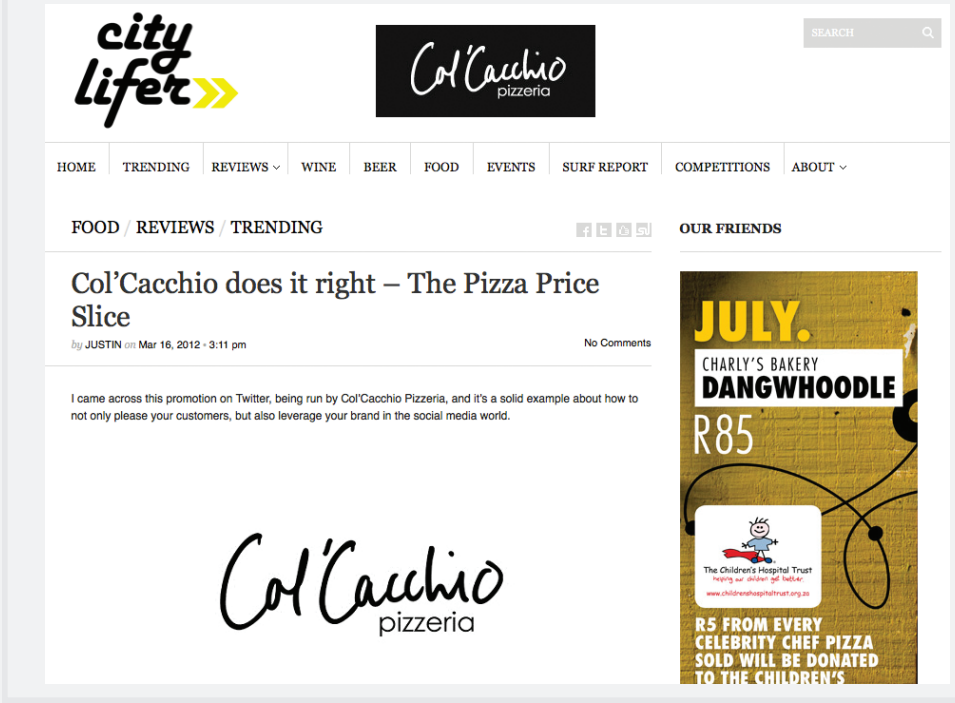

Figure 22. *A blog post about the campaign.*

- There was also a great deal of positive sentiment about the campaign itself, shared via Twitter and other online channels:

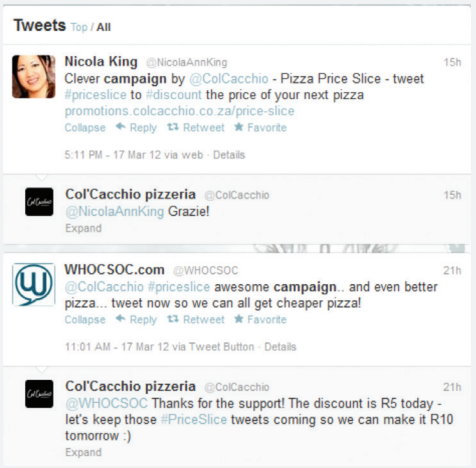

Figure 23. *A Twitter search reveals the brand featured in Top Tweets.*

Col'Cacchio and Quirk also went further to capture a range of data related to online mentions of the campaign.

Here are some key observations:

- There was an increase of 440% in @mentions of the @Colcacchio Twitter handle during the campaign, when compared to the days prior to launch.
- There was also an increase of more than 800% in the number of @Colcacchio retweets during the campaign when compared to the week prior to it.
- Over 3 000 mentions of the #PriceSlice hashtag were achieved through the course of the campaign.
- As a result of the exposure of the campaign across various channels, the campaign reached just short of three million 'opportunities to see', meaning that the Price Slice initiative potentially reached almost three million Internet users. For example, if a Twitter user with 2 000 followers tweeted about the campaign, then 2 000 people had 'opportunity to see'.
- The majority of Price Slice conversation came from respected sources in the online community.

This campaign not only highlights the value of social media engagement for a brand, but also indicates how offering consumers something in return can really endear a brand to its followers. Col'Cacchio and Quirk embraced the strengths of Twitter and used the platform to build brand awareness in a positive and meaningful way.

14.13 The bigger picture

Social media can tie in nicely with any of your other online marketing tactics – a holistic digital marketing strategy is always the best strategy.

Social media is inextricably linked to content marketing strategy, since content is the foundation of any social media marketing endeavour – whether you're creating digital copy, images, videos or other media.

Social media can have SEO benefits for a website. By using social media services, either to create or share content, websites can attract links and generate engagement, helping to enhance search engine rankings. Signing up to several social media channels can help a company to own a larger chunk of the search engine results page. Companies can also use their SEO keyword strategy to focus their social media efforts.

Social media can provide a targeted network for online advertising, allowing detailed demographic information to play a role in media planning and buying. Companies can also make use of increased consumer engagement to create interactive advertising for these mediums, such as advertising within videos and social network applications, or merely making use of increased time-on-page metrics to create more intricate advertising.

Affiliates often use the opportunities presented by social media to find new avenues for targeted traffic, resulting in revenue growth for the company being marketed this way.

Social media plays a large role in online monitoring and reputation management, viral marketing and digital PR. Social media is used to express opinion, and so is the bedrock of online reputation. Any company that wants to communicate to this connected audience needs to listen to social media.

14.14 Summary

Social media refers to the creation and sharing of content by consumers on the Internet. All Internet users – companies included – now have the opportunity to be creators as well as consumers of content.

Social media refers to the online platforms that allow users to:

- Create and engage in social networks
- Create and share content
- Bookmark and aggregate content
- Connect to physical locations and contacts
- Use other Internet users' preferences to find content

Most social media services are free to all users and rely on advertising for revenue. Social media provides targeted demographic information to advertisers looking to direct their advertising.

14.15 Case study questions

1. Why was Twitter well suited to the Col'Cacchio #PriceSlice campaign?
2. How were hashtags useful for this campaign?
3. Comment on the interaction between offline and online touchpoints used in this campaign.

14.16 Chapter questions

1. Visit www.guardian.co.uk. List the ways in which this print publication is embracing social media.
2. Why is transparency so important to marketing using social media? Has this halted or accelerated the use of social media for marketing?
3. What is the difference between advertising using social media and marketing using social media? What are the benefits of social media to each, and what are the challenges?

14.17 Further reading

www.gottaquirk.com – the blog from the minds of Quirk, filled with the latest in social media and digital marketing.

www.mashable.com – a blog that covers social networking and social media.

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15

Social Media Strategy

What's inside: This chapter is an **expansion** on the previous chapter dealing with social media, the **different ways of creating** and then **engaging with a thriving community**, and how **social media has wiggled its wa**y into almost **every facet** of the **online world**. We discuss **guidelines when dealing with difficult customers**, and how to **map out a social media plan**. We then wrap it up with a **case study** showing how **communities and brands can come together** for the good of all involved.

15.1 Introduction

In the previous chapter, we introduced the concept of social media, and detailed some of the major social media channels and platforms. This chapter addresses how to use these spaces strategically. While the channels and platforms available may change, the foundations of a successful social media strategy won't. By planning and thinking strategically, while leaving room to be flexible and dynamic, you'll be able to make the most of what social networking has to offer.

Social media channels are communication channels that can be used to solve business, marketing and communication challenges. As more time is spent by consumers online, and that time is increasingly dominated by social media usage, organisations need to incorporate social media into their marketing strategies. The Pew Research Center's *Internet & American Life Project* shows that 67% of Internet users visit social networking sites (Center, 2013). The Nielsen and NM *Incite's Social Media Report* indicates that American computer users spend about 20% of their time online visiting social networks, while mobile users spend 30% of their time on these sites (Nielsen, 2012). This means more time is spent on social media than on any other category of sites.

In this chapter, you will learn:

- Several valuable strategic uses of social media
- The steps to creating a social media strategy
- Which documents and protocols you should have in place for social media success

15.2 Key terms and concepts

Term	Definition
Community guidelines	The rules and principle that community members must adhere to when communicating on a brand platform.
Key performance indicator (KPI)	A metric that shows whether an objective is being achieved.
Lead	A person who has shown interest in a brand, product or service and could be converted into a customer.
Objective	A desired outcome of a digital marketing campaign.
Online reputation management (ORM)	Understanding and influencing the perception of an entity online.
Search engine optimisation (SEO)	The process of improving website rankings in search engines.

Social media dashboard	A service that allows you to centralise management of your social media properties.
Social network	In the online sense, a type of website model where individual members become part of a broader virtual community.
URL shortener	A web tool that creates a shorter version of a full URL.

15.3 Using social media to solve business challenges

Social media can be used strategically in a number of marketing and communication challenges:

- Communication and outreach
- Community management
- Support and customer service
- Reputation management
- Advertising and awareness
- Sales and lead generation
- Search engine optimisation
- Insights and research

NOTE

Not all businesses face all of these challenges - which ones are relevant to your brand?

Figure 1. *Social media marketing can help with a number of business challenges.*

15.3.1 Communication and outreach

Unlike other options, social media offers brands an effective two-way communication and real-time broadcast channel. This bi-directional communication is what makes social communities so exciting (and challenging). Just as consumers can communicate with each other, and send messages to businesses and brands, so businesses and brands can use this medium to communicate with and reach out to the public. Increasingly, social media is becoming a highly effective public communications tool.

NOTE

Ideally, you want to be the trusted go-to source of information about your industry.

Businesses, governments and other organisations use Twitter and Facebook to broadcast timely messages, allowing interested parties to keep informed in real-time. This is fast becoming a vital aspect of newsworthy and breaking news events such as elections, disasters and global sports. Many organisations also use social media tools to broadcast service updates.

15.3.2 Community management

Social media platforms are built around communities, and are sometimes virtual representations of real-world networks and communities. This feature of social media can be used to build and maintain a community around, or supported by, your organisation.

'Community manager' is a role that has risen to prominence as more organisations start using social media, but it has always been an important role in any community – from groups that thrive on forums to communities run on platforms such as Facebook.

Creating, building and nurturing a community means that organisations don't just participate in conversations that are happening around and about them, but also actively lead and guide those conversations. These communities are generally made up of the organisation's biggest fans: brand evangelists who feel as if they have a big stake in that organisation. This creates an environment where those fans can interact directly with the organisation, and where the organisation can send messages directly to those fans and solicit their feedback.

Figure 2. *MWEB responding to customer queries on Twitter.*

Building and maintaining a community is a long-term project. It starts with determining what the best platform is for that community: something that already exists (such as Facebook), or a brand new platform specifically created for it (either from scratch or using a service such as Ning – www.ning.com).

15.3.3 Support and customer service

Social media is becoming an additional customer service channel. As consumers are increasingly comfortable transacting online, there is an expectation that the businesses with which they transact will also respond to customer queries in the social space, as they would do through a call centre or email. Some customers have found that problems or questions on social media tend to be resolved more quickly, as brands are wary of having unresolved issues left out in public. For any organisation that runs a social community, customer service is often one of the channel's primary functions.

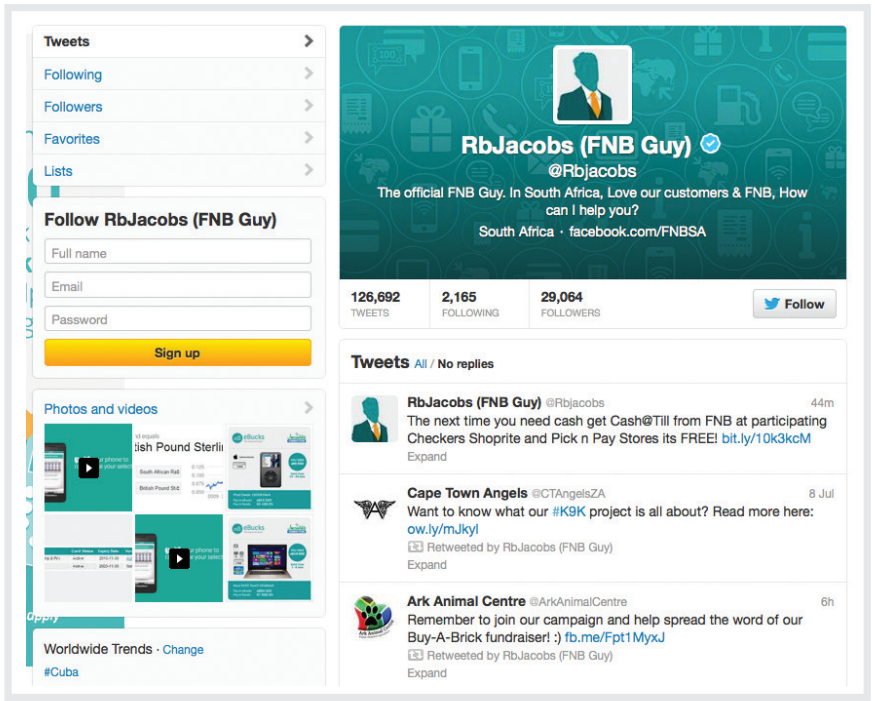

Figure 3. *FNB responding to customer queries on Twitter.*

Interestingly, customer service in social media channels starts to become collaborative, with customers assisting each other and, in doing so, reducing the reliance on the organisation for support. Collaborative support tools such as Get Satisfaction (www.getsatsfaction.com) are used to great effect. According to Get Satisfaction's website, over 70 000 communities use their service, including Microsoft and Intuit's Mint (Get Satisfaction, 2013). Even businesses that use social media channels such as Facebook for customer support can see other community members helping each other.

15.3.4 Reputation management

The need for online reputation management and monitoring is growing, and brands are now realising this. Through the combination of search and social media, all mentions of a brand or individual are only a quick search away, whether they are positive or negative. Social media are in one of the spaces where a brand or individual can easily respond to mentions, create a stir, or find ways to further their own agenda.

Brands can use social media in two ways to manage their online reputations – first, by monitoring what customers and fans are saying to identify issues proactively; and second, as a means of communicating and getting their side of the story out.

15.3.5 Advertising and awareness

Where there is an audience, there is advertising. The more time people spend in social media, the more brands want to advertise there. It's not just the time people spend on social networks that make them appealing to advertisers – it's also the rich demographic and psychographic targeting opportunities. Adverts can be targeted based on the profile information that individuals provide, either overtly or through their actions on the social network.

Most social networks offer advertising options that are accessible to both the small advertiser as well as the big spender. This is a dynamic space, as the networks experiment with different formats and models. The advertising opportunities for Facebook, Twitter, YouTube and LinkedIn are covered in full in the *Online Advertising* chapter.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Online Advertising* chapter.

15.3.6 Sales and lead generation

Adding a social layer to a commercial transaction can create a richer experience for online consumers. These can be based overtly on social connections, or on inferred connections based on behaviour.

Levi's Friends Store (store.levi.com) is an example of the former. Visiting the website while signed in to Facebook allows you to see which of your friends like which styles. Levi's can then present this information with data that includes your friends' upcoming birthdays. This is useful feedback for you, as you can see which styles are more popular among your friends, as well as users in general. This provides insight for Levi's on which styles are more popular than others.

NOTE

You can see how it works at http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ed5vJeaEuzA.

An excellent example of the layer based on inferred connections is Amazon's collaborative filtering. If you've browsed on Amazon.com, you will no doubt have seen product information such as "People who bought this also bought that". In real time, based on consumer purchase behaviour, Amazon presents products that you are likely to have an interest in, based on people who browsed and purchased products that you like. Although you may not realise it, this is a social layer on the online shopping experience.

Social communities can also be lead generation or sales generation assets. Within Facebook, for example, applications on brand pages can allow eCommerce transactions or lead generation within the Facebook environment.

15.3.7 Search engine optimisation (SEO)

Social media plays an important role in SEO. It provides additional assets that can be optimised so that a brand 'owns' the results page for searches for their brand. A savvy SEO strategy will also make use of social media assets, links and likes for strengthening the position of other web assets in the search engine results pages.

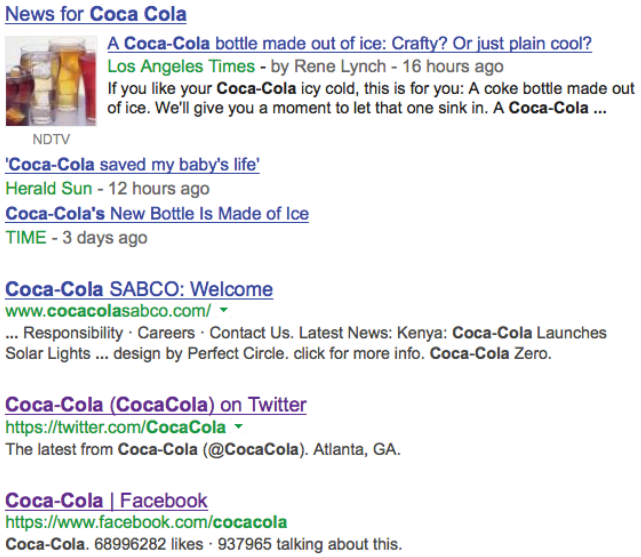

Figure 4. ***Branded social media platforms appearing in Google search results.***

With a little bit of planning and keyword research, a brand can use social assets effectively to own searches on their brand name. This ties back neatly to managing their online reputation, too.

15.3.8 Insight and research

Social media can be a very powerful insight and research asset, but the information needs to be judged in its proper context. When you are planning a campaign, social media can provide a rich source of data, both demographic and preference based.

You can use the information people share freely to understand more about your market, brand or product. ORM tools help you to track mentions and sentiment, giving you insight into how you are perceived. Using social network ad planners, such as Facebook or YouTube's offerings, can give you rich information about the size of your market, and things that they like. You can measure sentiment and the changing number of mentions to help you understand the impact of other campaigns. These can be offline or online campaigns.

NOTE

Try this yourself: do a search for your favourite brand and see how many of the results are social media profiles.

Building your online community also gives you a group you can reach out to for information and feedback, creating an always-on online focus group. However, bear in mind that they are inherently biased just by the fact that they would join your social community.

Doing a Twitter search of branded keywords can reveal what users are saying about your brand. You could also use communities such as Flickr to see what people are sharing about their lives, without even realising. Head over to www.flickr.com and search for 'in my fridge' for a snapshot of this in action.

This social data can be very valuable, but must be treated correctly. It is qualitative and quantitative information, and is in many ways secondary research. For research purposes, it can and should be used to help form research questions for further evaluation.

15.4 Step-by-step guide to creating a social media strategy

Social media is a fast-moving channel, which means proper planning is vital to success. Effective social media strategies come from embracing the fact that social media is a two-way communication channel: organisations interacting in this space need the resources not only to push messages out, but to deal quickly with the messages coming in, too.

Planning is the foundation of success. Here is one method to approaching social media strategically.

1. Get buy-in

It's important that there is buy-in for your foray into social media. It may be seen as a free resource, but even if you are not paying for exposure, there is a time and resource investment required. A number of stakeholders will need to be aware of your social media plans, and these may be both internal and external. And, of course, you will need sign-off for any budgeting or additional resourcing requirements.

Addressing the various stakeholders will also force you to do the necessary research and planning to take the next steps.

NOTE

Be sure to consider the risks of *not* being on social media as well!

2. Listen and understand the landscape

It's important to take a step back first. Social media is more than the social spaces you may interact with in your personal capacity. A good first step to understanding the landscape is to listen.

Some important questions to answer include:

- What conversation already exists around your brand, your industry and your competitors?
- Do they have the facts?
- Where does it take place?
- Who is doing most of the talking? What can you, as a brand, add to this conversation? Is it valuable?

Online monitoring tools such as BrandsEye (www.brandseye.com) or Radian6 (www.radian6.com) can help you with the listening part of your planning, but in the early stages you may want to start with free tools such as Google Alerts (www.google.com/alerts).

3. Analyse

Using all the data you have been gathering, analyse! Think critically about social media and your brand, as well as your brand's broader marketing, communication and business challenges. All of this should be looked at within the context of the information that you already know about your local marketing and business environment.

Your outcomes here should include:

- A list of the social channels and platforms your brand should be in. This is based on who your customers are, where they interact, and where they expect to interact with you.
- Non-official groups or communities that already exist, which may have been created by fans.
- An overview of the existing conversation (volume, frequency and sentiment), as well as any content or conversation themes that occur.
- An overview of what your competitors are doing in this space.
- A list of potential brand evangelists and influencers in your industry.

NOTE

Indicate if the sentiment around your brand is strongly positive or negative; typically, most comments will be neutral or informational.

4. Set objectives

Your objectives are the desired outcome of your social media strategy. These should be based within the context of your marketing and business challenges.

Firstly, you need to address how you will use social media for your organisation. You then need to set objectives for each of those.

To make them tangible and measurable, establish key performance indicators (KPIs) for your objectives, with benchmarks and targets where appropriate.

Determine SMART objectives:

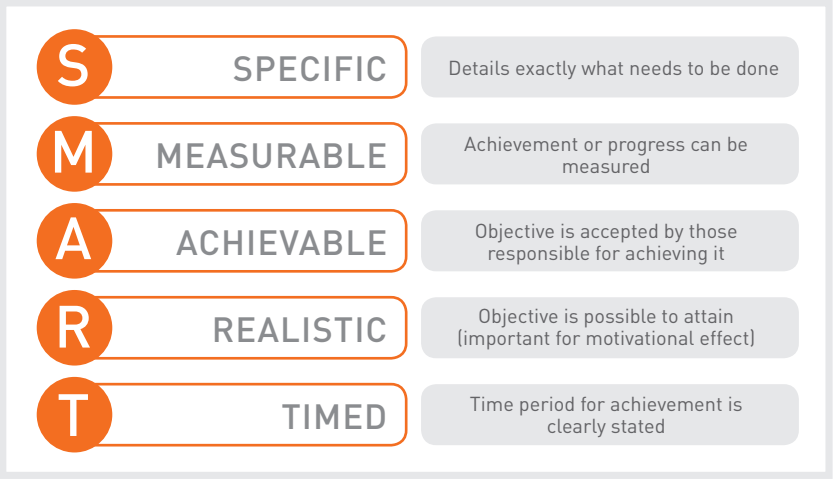

Figure 5. ***The various elements of a SMART objective.***

For example, your objective could be to grow a community of fans around your brand in a particular country. Your KPI might therefore be fan numbers, and you could set a target of 5 000 Facebook fans over six months.

5. Create an action plan

Once you have a clear idea of what you want, you can begin compiling an action plan to get there.

This is where you need to make sure that you have created the necessary documents and processes that form the foundation of your plan.

You will need to:

- Decide on the roles and responsibilities of the project team and other stakeholders.
- Determine what social media tools you will make use of.
- Commit to a frequency and volume of activity, as well as how quickly you will respond.
- Develop a conversation plan.
- Create tone of voice guidelines, frequently asked questions, community guidelines and content plans.

6. Implement

This is the fun part! It's time to kick off your plans and put all that research and thought into action. Set up your platforms according to the guidelines they specify. Alert stakeholders that you are starting your engagement plans, and make sure you have tracking in place. Continue to monitor for mentions of your organisation, and responses to your messages. Keep to your general plan, but be prepared to adapt.

7. Track, analyse, optimise

The beautiful thing about digital marketing is that you can track every single user interaction and use this information to learn from and improve your efforts continually. You should track the success of your social media campaigns on an ongoing basis, and set milestones for your team at less frequent intervals (every couple of months or so), when you will sit down and do a more in-depth review.

There are several tools you can use for tracking social media. You will need to build a suite of tools to suit your measurement and reporting requirements.

Platform insights

Facebook, YouTube, and other social media platforms offer analytics and insights. These are a useful starting point for reporting on your social media efforts, from numbers of followers or fans, to interactions with the content you share.

Web analytics

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Data Analytics* chapter.

If you are using social media channels to send traffic to your own website, you should tag the links so that you can segment that traffic in your website reports. In Google Analytics (www.google.com/analytics), you would use campaign tracking parameters.

URL shorteners

URL shortening services such as bit.ly and ow.ly offer usage data that will tell you how many people click on links you share, when they click on them, and where in the world they are from.

Online monitoring software

Online monitoring software is an important measurement investment that you will need to make. It helps you to keep track of all mentions of your brand, and to understand the sentiment and influence of those mentions. You should be tracking your reputation for trends and changes over time.

Social media dashboards

There are a number of services that make it easier for you to centralise management of your social media properties, as well as making collaborative management easier. They also integrate analytics data from a number of sources, making reporting easier.

NOTE

Some dashboards even let you schedule or respond to posts directly from the interface.

Some services include:

- HootSuite (www.hootsuite.com)
- Spredfast (www.spredfast.com)
- CoTweet (www.cotweet.com)
- Sprout Social (www.sproutsocial.com)
- Socialbakers (www.socialbakers.com)
- Tweetstats (www.tweetstats.com)

15.5 Documents and processes

Good documentation and processes are the foundations of social media success, especially as this dynamic space is likely to involve many stakeholders from across your organisation. To ensure that there is consistency across the various channels, processes and guidelines should be a part of your social media strategy, and should be created before you take any action on social media.

Start with the documentation and processes you already have in place for marketing and communication: for example, brand and tone of voice guidelines, or PR policies. Build on these to create a robust foundation that suits this spontaneous, dynamic space.

A social media checklist is a good starting point to make sure that you have everything in place. Examples of community guidelines, conversation calendars and escalation protocols are also included for you.

NOTE

Never write down or share account passwords in these documents! Only the people working directly on the channels should know them.

	Item
	Account logins: • Facebook • Twitter • YouTube • Blog
	Item
	Community Guidelines available online and linked to where appropriate
	Social Media strategy and content strategy
	Roles and responsibilities
	Risks and escalation plan
	Brand voice guidelines
	Social media guidelines for agencies and employees
	Monitoring and listening plan
	Reporting: tracking and insights

Figure 6. ***The social media checklist.***

15.5.1 Community guidelines

As well as a privacy policy and terms and conditions, it's a good idea to establish community guidelines for the communities you manage, especially when the community is on behalf of a brand. Community guidelines help to set the tone for the community, and are useful to refer to should community members behave in a way that is undesirable. They indicate what will, and will not, be tolerated, such as hate speech, profanity, discrimination and other inappropriate content. Of course, community guidelines don't prevent such behaviour, but are useful to fall back on should you need to remove comments or community members.

Guidelines should be friendly, with the tone in keeping with your community or brand. You can use the information here as a starting point, but customise it for your situation.

WOOLWORTHS SA | House Rules

Like

WOOLWORTHS

MISSION

Welcome to the Woolworths Fan Page.

We run this page to share what's happening in our world and chat to you about what's happening in yours. This is where we can explore your life with Woolies, together. We love chatting and answering questions, as well as listening to constructive feedback. So please... participate, comment and post!

Above all, we want our customers to feel safe, secure and comfortable in this space.

Please read over our community guidelines. We don't take decisions on moderating posts lightly, but believe strongly in respecting each other and we ask that you do the same. Now... let's get chatting!

GUIDELINES

1. We expect that participants post content and commentary that is both relevant and respectful to this community as a whole.
2. We encourage and support our loyal community members to look out for one another.
3. We reserve the right to untag Woolworths from any posts or photos that we deem inappropriate.
4. Please do not share any personal information on our Facebook wall. Rather send us a private inbox message to keep your personal details safe (See 'Message' button, top right on our Page wall).
5. By using or accessing the Woolworths Facebook page, you agree to comply with Facebook's Statement of Rights and Responsibilities & Community Standards.
6. We reserve the right to remove any posts that coincide with these rulings including:
   - Links containing spam that are intended to cause technical disruptions to this page or contain viruses or programs that could damage the operation of other people's computers.
   - Any surveys, contests, pyramid schemes, chain letters, spam, any duplicative or unsolicited messages (commercial or otherwise).
   - Links used to direct traffic to other sites, blogs or Facebook pages.
   - Content in violation of intellectual property rights and confidential, proprietary business information.
   - Harvesting or otherwise collecting information (data) about others, including email addresses.
   - 'Trolling' (false identities) for the purpose of misleading others or deliberate disruption of discussion.
   - Fraudulent, deceptive, misleading or unlawful posts/commentary.
   - Defamatory, offensive, obscene, or vulgar commentary.
   - Abusive language, harassing, stalking, threatening or personally attacking others.
   - Hateful in language targeting race/ethnicity, religion, gender, nationality or political beliefs.
   - Violation of any law or regulation.
   - Anything to do with a legal issue, legal case, or attorneys. This includes legal action involving Woolworths, soliciting individuals to engage in legal action against Woolworths, or offering other legal advice.

NOTE: Repeat offenders may be reported and blocked from our page for the sake of the community.

We do our best to answer all queries posted to our Facebook wall and are online and available from 9:00am to 5:00pm every day. If you post a query outside of the designated times, please be patient - we will assist you as soon as possible.

Should you wish to contact us outside of Facebook, get in touch with Woolworths Customer Services via our email on custserv@woolworths.co.za or phone us on 0860 022 002. Thanks for reading and welcome to the Woolies Facebook community!

Disclaimer: In addition to the rights that you grant to Facebook, you grant to Woolworths and its affiliates a royalty-free license to use your content in any manner or media, globally, forever, without any obligation to you. This includes the right to use any ideas you submit (including ideas about our products or advertising campaigns) in any manner that we choose, without any obligation to you.

WWW.WOOLWORTHS.CO.ZA

Figure 7. ***Community guidelines on the Woolworths Facebook Page.***

15.5.2 Content plan

Content plans help you to plan your community conversations. More than that, they are also useful, centralised planning documents that ensure that various teams are all aware of each other's efforts, and that communications are integrated. For any kind of content and communication strategy, content plans are invaluable.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Content Marketing Strategy* chapter.

As you learnt in the *Content Marketing Strategy* chapter, reaching social audiences requires you to create content that truly resonates with them. Successful social content must be interesting, relevant, shareable and remarkable. It is especially useful to plan and create social content around your content pillars, since this gives you a solid structure and starting point to follow.

To start creating a conversation calendar, you should plot everything that is relevant to your community. This could include public events, dates and anniversaries, or events and communications already planned by your organisation.

You should also use your conversation calendar for reporting. Keeping track of interactions and responses to your planned posts will help you to determine what kind of posts your community responds to, what days are best for posting, and what frequency works best for your community.

Planning the conversation helps to keep momentum, especially in the early days of building a community. However, it should not replace spontaneity – this is a conversation, after all!

NOTE

There are many fields that can go into a conversation calendar (such as suggested copy, links, and more). Take the basic calendar on the right and adapt it to your needs and preferences.

Date	Mon	Tues	Wed	Thurs	Fri	Sat	Sun
Theme							
Facebook							
Twitter							

Figure 8. ***The conversation calendar.***

15.5.3 Communication and escalation protocol

An established communication and escalation protocol helps to ensure that all parties are aware of procedures for handling social messages, and can respond as appropriate. This is especially important for large organisations where several people might be interacting in social media on behalf of a brand, or where several departments or agencies have a stake in the organisation's social media presence.

A communication and escalation protocol should include:

- Anticipated messages, frequently asked questions and appropriate, standard responses (for both positive and negative situations).
- Guidelines for determining the sentiment and risk of messages, which includes a flagging system for comments that need more senior attention.
- The crisis management process to follow if a brand crisis erupts on social media.
- An escalation plan for messages that need signoff or further consideration.
- Contact details of relevant stakeholders.
- Guidelines for responding, including response rate, standard messages, brand voice and tone.

NOTE

Make sure that all stakeholders understand their roles, and appreciate that social media interactions often need to be handled quickly.

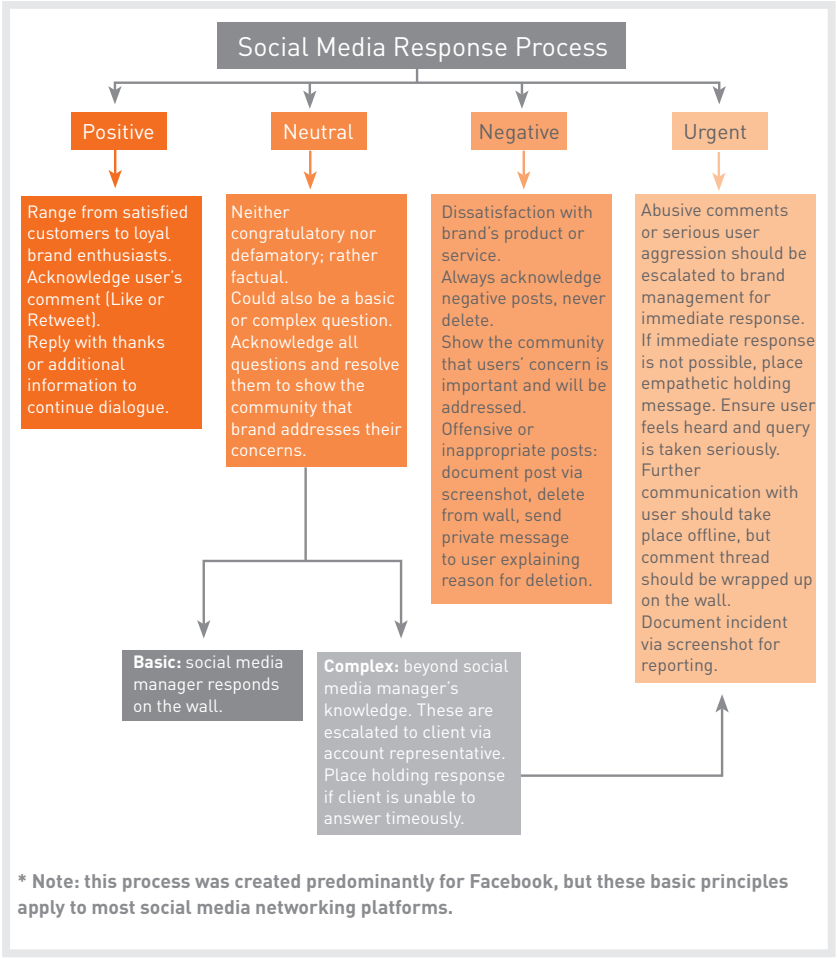

Figure 9. ***A decision flowchart is a useful way of disseminating information.***

15.6 Dealing with opportunities and threats

The use of social media has equipped consumers with a voice and a platform, and the ability to amplify their views and truly inform their decision making. The connected nature of the Internet makes these views easy to share, and the accessibility of social media tools makes it easy for other consumers to find these views, and respond and build on them. All of this contributes to the perception of the brand.

The best way to show that you are listening to customer comments, complaints and questions online is the same as with a normal conversation. Comment when it's appropriate, listen with interest, be polite, be respectful, and add value wherever possible. Brands should become active participants in the conversation.

Brands that are successful in communicating with their audiences are constantly on the lookout for opportunities to propel their brand forward, and are keeping their eyes peeled for risks that may threaten their reputation. In both situations, the power sits in how the brand responds. This response can range from a direct engagement to a full new marketing campaign. Ultimately it depends on how powerful the opportunity or risk is.

15.6.1 When to talk (and when not to)

When everything being said is nice

A fantastic position to be in is that every possible mention is overwhelmingly positive. Well done. However, that does not mean that there is nothing to do. During this time, the brand must do everything in its power to drive high volumes of conversation.

Stakeholders are being positive about the brand because their expectations are being exceeded. Unfortunately, expectations change. Brands need to stay on their toes and constantly be on the lookout for new and innovative ways to meet and develop their brand promise.

When everything being said is neutral

If this is the case, it sounds as if the company is very boring – not a good way to get attention. As Seth Godin puts it, "Safe is risky" (Godin, 2010). If a company is playing it so safe that no one can be bothered to send either praise or criticism its way, it's in danger of being forgotten. The next step is no one talking about the company at all.

When negative things are being said

Negative statements should be understood as broken brand promises. There is underperformance on expectation, and it must be dealt with as a matter of high priority. During this period, brands need to be very careful not to stir up any more conversation than is absolutely necessary. That said, it's certainly not all doom and gloom. If the conversation is broadly negative, it is normally because there is some underlying problem, and this information provides the business with focus to resolve it.

Complaints are from stakeholders who have had dealings with a company which hasn't met their expectations. By complaining, this customer is, often unwittingly, giving the company the opportunity to make things right, and is probably indicating where the company can improve. Usually, the skilled customer service department of a company should deal with these. They should also share insights with the business strategy department so that the underlying problems can be prioritised and resolved.

NOTE

In fact, resolving a serious complaint to the customer's satisfaction can gain you a loyal brand advocate - someone who has first-hand experience that your brand cares and goes the extra mile.

If a complaint is online, the resolution should be there as well, although you can try to have it taken offline first. Even though the customer service will likely take place either over email or by phone, posting a personalised comment in a blog post, for example, will demonstrate to the community that the company listens, responds, and serves the critical objective of actually resolving the underlying issues.

Criticism need not necessarily come from customers, but it is important to be aware of it. If a criticism involves false information, it should be corrected. And if the criticism is true, then it should be dealt with as such.

15.6.2 Responding

Responding involves recognising that consumers hold the upper hand in the relationship. They are better trusted, there are more of them and, in most cases, the barriers to exit from a brand are relatively low.

Customers dictate the channels of communication. An organisation needs to go to the consumer, not the other way around. Ignoring this will result in the business losing customers because they not willing to truly engage. This is why it is so important to research your audience and tailor your strategy to them – not vice versa.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Market Research* chapter.

When responding, be transparent, be honest, and treat the person as you would like to be treated. At all times, remember that you are engaged in conversation, not a dictation.

15.7 Step-by-step guide for recovering from an online brand attack

These rules to recovery provide a practical approach for brands facing an online threat.

15.7.1 Step 1: Be prepared

No brand is immune from an online brand attack. The best brands have strategies in place to identify a reputation crisis immediately and respond to it quickly enough to stop the negative word of mouth spreading.

Keep your brand in front of consumers by engaging in the conversation. This can be done by making use of blogs, communicating with customers, and being as open and honest as possible. Engaging in, and leading, the conversation allows you to build an authentic voice. If a crisis hits, you will be well placed to respond in a way that is authentic.

15.7.2 Step 2: Act immediately!

The easiest way to solve most brand attacks is to respond quickly. A brand that shows it is listening and does indeed care will go far when it comes to ensuring a solid online reputation. Acknowledge what has been said and react accordingly.

15.7.3 Step 3: If what they're saying is false...

If the attack on your brand is factually incorrect, send the person evidence that they are wrong, and in a friendly tone, ask them to remove or retract the entry, and offer to keep them informed of future news. If the person doesn't react or respond, add a comment.

NOTE

Cultivating a loyal community of fans can help immensely when clearing up false information. You will look much more credible if your fans back up your statements.

15.7.4 Step 4: If what they're saying is true...

If the mention is negative but true, send your side of the story and try as hard as you can to take the conversation offline. If appropriate, apologise and offer to make amends.

15.7.5 Step 5: Keep the negative pages out of the search engines

Keeping more people from reading negative things about your brand is imperative. Knock them off the first page of the results with basic SEO and some social media pages, such as Facebook, Twitter or blog posts. Keep adding pages and links until you've forced the offending pages out of sight.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Search Engine Optimisation* chapter.

15.8 Social media risks and challenges

Any social media strategy should account for the risks and challenges of interacting in this environment, and should incorporate a protocol for dealing with these risks. Mistakes on the web can take a long time to recover from.

Some of the common risks and challenges are listed below.

No one cares. Especially when building a community from scratch, it can be difficult in the beginning to get the traction you want. This is why understanding the landscape in the context of your organisation's market is so important. Make sure you are interacting in the spaces where your customers are, and where they are happy to hear from you.

The social media space is used by unhappy customers (who are free to post detractive comments). Even if the only feedback you are getting is negative, this is good feedback! Now you have an opportunity to do something about it.

It requires ongoing attention and monitoring. Social media channels may be free, but there is still a time and resource investment required to make your strategy a success. Understand what your objectives are for using social media, and budget the time required to meet those.

It can be difficult to measure the impact of the campaign. Social media can be difficult to measure, but that does not mean your campaigns are not successful. Don't expect to find a solution (or success) overnight. Start with measuring things that can be measured easily, and watch for case studies in this space that will help you to turn your social media investment into revenue for your organisation.

15.9 Case study – Super Bowl Social Media Command Center

15.9.1 One-line summary

The organisers behind the Super Bowl, the most watched sporting series in the world, used social media to monitor and manage massive crowds.

15.9.2 The problem

Social media monitoring isn't just for brands and products – it can be just as useful during live events. Take the Super Bowl, for example. It's one of the most watched sporting events in the world, with over 100 million viewers. It's also a massive real-world event, where 150 000 people crowd the city of Indianapolis for the day.

15.9.3 The solution

In order to monitor and manage these massive crowds, organisers came upon the idea of creating a 'Social Media Command Center', and hired a team from communications company Raidious to handle it. Working out of an office in the city centre, a big team of strategists, data analysts and volunteers monitored social media conversations for two weeks before and during the event. Their motto was 'monitor, moderate, publish'.

The command centre monitored around 300 keywords from Facebook, Foursquare, YouTube and a series of Twitter hashtags. They responded, gathered data, and kept track of sentiment and congestion, reaching about 49 000 people in the area. Through retweets and shares, they reached around 1 million impressions a day. In total, that translates to about $3.2 million in marketing value.

The team focused on responding to fans who needed advice or help while attending the event. For example, they sent out links to parking information to drivers stuck without a spot.

Figure 10. *A Tweet giving Super Bowl fans information on parking.*

They sent tweets about handy downloads for watching the game and also posted useful information about things such as open Wi-Fi networks in the stadium.

The team managed to identify and respond to several safety issues even before the official organisers knew about them. They were also ready with a crisis communication plan in case of a large-scale emergency.

15.9.4 The results

The overall campaign was a huge success. Sentiment about the Super Bowl had a positive to negative ratio of 3 : 1 (It's unusual to see one higher than 2 : 1). The Command Center also achieved a daily average of 3 500 retweets and 2 500 Twitter favourites or Facebook Likes. They even managed to beat the National Football League's Klout score!

The potential benefits of a system like this are great – from better public safety and smoother crowd management, to branding and social engagement.

Simply monitoring what people say can provide an incredible amount of useful, immediate feedback – something that's essential in this fast-paced digital world (Laird, 2012).

15.10 Summary

Social media can be used strategically in a number of marketing and communication challenges:

- Community management
- Support and customer service
- Reputation management
- Search engine optimisation
- Communication and outreach
- Advertising and awareness
- Sales and lead generation
- Insights and research

Creating a social media strategy requires careful planning, and a strong foundation that will allow you to be dynamic.

The steps to creating a social media strategy include:

- Get buy-in
- Understand the landscape
- Analyse
- Set objectives
- Create an action plan
- Implement
- Track, analyse, optimise!

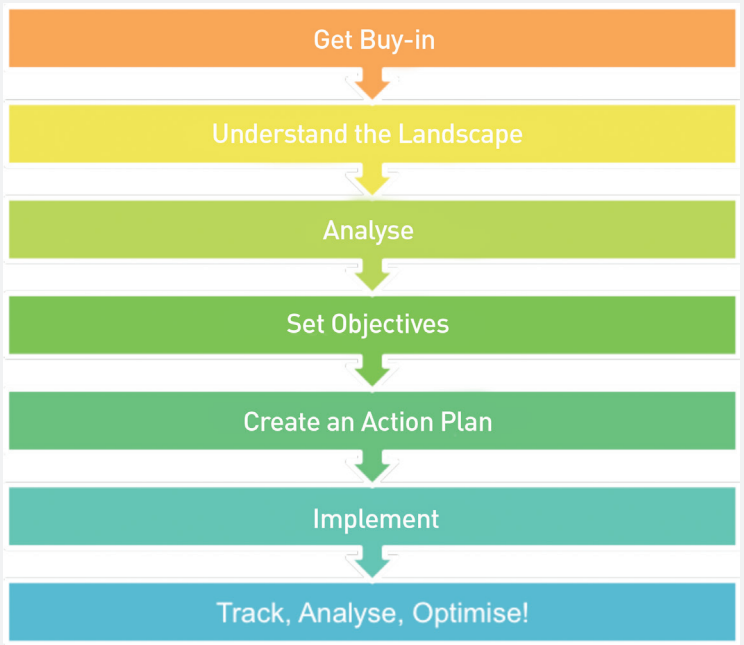

Figure 11. ***The steps involved in a social media strategy.***

Social media is a vital strategic consideration for any brand. Whether your organisation is actively involved in social media or not, your consumers are. If nothing else, this means that there is market data available to you, if you just take a little time to find it.

Organisations that make a considered move in the social media sphere will find it both challenging and rewarding. The rapid feedback loop can often change preconceptions or even marketing plans, as the voice of the customer is amplified through social media. However, the collaboration with passionate customer stakeholders is extremely rewarding.

15.11 Case study questions

1. How would you describe the link between social media strategy and the social customer?
2. How would you advise the strategists in the Social Media Command Center to respond to a very unhappy fan?
3. How would you define a keyword in this context?

15.12 Chapter questions

1. What are some of the pitfalls of engaging difficult customers on social media platforms?
2. What skills do you think are important for a great community manager to have?
3. Should all brands be active in social media spaces? What brands have less to gain from trying to create an online community?

15.13 Further reading

www.socialmediaexaminer.com – Social Media Examiner offers practical advice, tips and strategies for engaging on social media.

socialmediatoday.com – Social Media Today offers news, insights and analysis of social media trends.

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16

Email Marketing

What's inside: An **introduction** to email marketing, and **the key terms and concepts** you need for this chapter. We look at **email strategy and planning** as key to its success, and how to **grow a database** and explore the **creative execution** of emails. We also look at how and when to deploy emails and how **email analytics** can be used to track and measure campaigns. Finally we suggest some **handy tools of the trade** and provide a useful **case study** along with a view of **the bigger picture** and a **summary** of the chapter.

16.1 Introduction

At its core, email marketing is a tool for customer relationship management (CRM). Used effectively, this extension of permission-based marketing can deliver one of the highest returns on investment (ROI) of any digital marketing activity.

Simply put, email marketing is a form of direct marketing that uses electronic means to deliver commercial messages to an audience. It is one of the oldest and yet most powerful of all digital marketing tactics. The power comes from the fact that it is:

- Extremely cost effective due to a low cost per contact
- Highly targeted
- Customisable on a mass scale
- Completely measurable

Furthermore, email marketing's main strength is that it takes advantage of a customer's most prolific touchpoint with the Internet – their inbox. Many of the principles covered in this chapter can be applied to any type of permission marketing – especially SMS communication via mobile phones.

Email marketing is a tool for building relationships with both existing and potential customers. It should maximise the retention and value of these customers, which should ultimately lead to a greater return on investment. Email is being used not only to drive retention, but also for acquisition, mobile strategies, and even social media.

NOTE

Some people consider email marketing to be old fashioned - but it can be one of the most powerful tools in your digital arsenal.

In this chapter, you will learn:

- The basics of email strategy
- How to structure and design an effective marketing email
- How to plan and execute a successful email marketing campaign
- Techniques for measuring and optimising your email campaigns

16.2 Key terms and concepts

Term	Definition
Alt Text	This refers to the 'alt' attribute for the IMG HTML tag. It is used in HTML to attribute a text field to an image on a web page, normally with a descriptive function, telling a user what an image is about and displaying the text in instances where the image is unable to load. Also called Alt Tag.
Business to Business (B2B)	When businesses sell products/services to other businesses and not to consumers.
Business to Consumers (B2C)	When businesses sell products/services to consumers.
Call to action (CTA)	A phrase written to motivate the reader to take action (sign up for our newsletter, book car hire today, and so on).
Clickthrough Rate	The total clicks on a link divided by the number of times that link was shown, expressed as a percentage.
Customer relationship management (CRM)	A strategy for managing a company's interactions with clients and potential clients. It often makes use of technology to automate the sales, marketing, customer service and technical processes of an organisation.
Database	In email marketing, the database is the list of prospects to which emails are sent. It also contains additional information pertinent to the prospects.
Domain name system (DNS)	DNS converts a domain name into an IP address.
DomainKeys	An email authentication system designed to verify the DNS domain of an email sender and the message integrity.
Double opt-in	The act of getting subscribers to confirm their initial subscription via a follow-up email asking them to validate their address and hence opt-in again.
Email service provider (ESP)	A service that helps you design and send emails.
Hard bounce	The failed delivery of email communication due to an undeviating reason like a non-existent address.
House list	An email database a company generates itself without purchasing or renting names.
HyperText Markup Language (HTML)	Code used to structure the information and features within a web page. As an example, HTML emails usually contain graphics and can be interactive.

Internet Protocol (IP) Address	An exclusive number that is used to represent every single computer in a network.
Internet Service Provider (ISP)	The company providing you access to the Internet, for example, MWEB, AOL, Yahoo.
Key performance indicator (KPI)	A metric that shows whether an objective is being achieved.
Open rate	The percentage of emails determined as opened out of the total number of emails sent.
Opt-in	Giving permission for emails to be sent to you.
Opt-out	Also known as unsubscribe. The act of removing oneself from a list or lists so that specified information is no longer received via email.
Return on investment (ROI)	The ratio of profit to cost.
Sender ID	A method used by major ISPs to confirm that an email does originate from the domain that it claims to have been sent from.
Simple Mail Transfer Protocol (SMTP)	A protocol for sending messages from one server to another.
Soft bounce	The failed delivery of an email due to a deviating reason like an overloaded email inbox or a server failure.
Spam	Email sent to someone who has not requested or given authorisation to receive it – EVIL!
Sender policy framework (SPF)	An extension of SMTP that stops email spammers from forging the 'From' fields in an email.
Text	Text emails or plain text emails do not contain graphics or any kind of markup.
Unique forwarders	This refers to the number of individuals who forwarded a specific email on.
White list	A list of accepted email addresses that an ISP, a subscriber or other email service provider allows to deliver messages regardless of spam filter settings.

16.3 Email strategy and planning

The first part of any email campaign should involve planning for the goals you need to achieve. Email marketing can be used as a tool to help you achieve your business and website goals. As with all tactics, email marketing should be considered in line with your overall business, marketing and digital strategy.

As discussed in the chapters on analytics and conversion optimisation, you will decide on the key performance indicators (KPIs) for your campaign. KPIs are the metrics that indicate how well you are performing.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Data Analytics* and *Conversion Optimisation* chapters.

Promotional emails will usually have an immediate goal:

- Users make a purchase
- Users download some content
- Users request further information

Figure 1. *An example of a promotional email from Park Regis hotels.*

Newsletters tend to focus on longer-term goals and are usually geared at creating and retaining a long-term relationship with the reader – so your KPIs are more important here. Useful KPIs include:

- Open rate
- Clickthrough rate
- Number of emails forwarded
- ROI
- Number of social shares
- Database growth
- Conversion rate (activity on your site generated by the email)
- Delivery or bounce rate

NOTE

A third type of email is called a "transactional email". These are sent in response to customer interactions with the brand (for example, a confirmation email sent after a completed purchase).

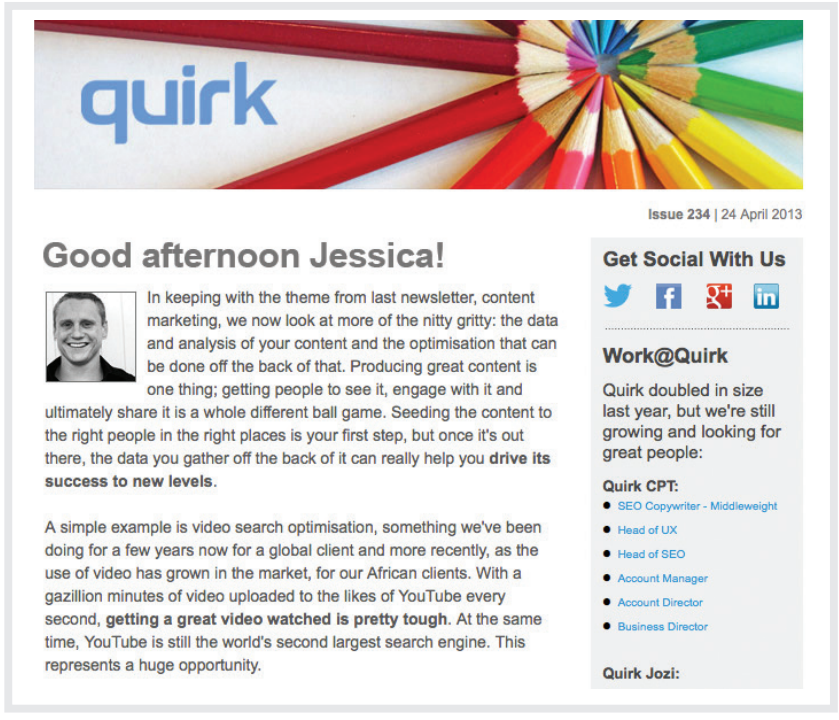

Figure 2. *The Quirk digital marketing newsletter provides useful content and insights.*

Know your audience! They will dictate which interactions you should measure.

16.3.1 Email service providers

NOTE

We've listed some ESPs in the tools of the trade section at the end of this module.

An email service provider (ESP) is a partner who can help manage your email design and send. For bigger organisations, it often makes sense to purchase your own software and server, or partner with an ESP. This is especially true if you are sending more than 50 emails at a time. Most ESPs are do-it-yourself services that do not manage or strategise your campaign, but will give you the tools you need to manage it yourself.

There are some important questions to ask when choosing an email service provider.

- How easy is it to use? This is important if you are managing the campaigns yourself.
- Can you upload and migrate the contact list? It's important that you own your lists.
- Is the process self-service or managed?
- How does the reporting work?

- What is their deliverability like?
- Are they endorsed by email and deliverability authorities, such as ReturnPath or Trust-e?
- Do they adhere to best practices for direct marketing?
- How is the data stored, processed and secured? Who owns it?

16.3.2 Email for mobile phones

With the adoption rate of smartphones increasing, more and more people are viewing their emails on mobile phones. As of January 2013, 42% of emails opened are accessed on mobile devices (Litmus, 2013).

This is a challenge. The mobile screen is obviously much smaller than a desktop screen, and so the way an email is displayed differs vastly as well. Not only that, but different mobile devices also make use of different mobile operating systems, meaning that each one has different standards and default settings and, as such, also renders emails in a unique way.

To make things even more difficult, very few people view an email on only one device. They switch from their smartphone to their laptop to their tablet and back to their mobile phone during the course of a day. This means that, although sending two versions of your email is an option (one for mobile, one for desktops), it's probably not the best solution. You want an email that displays well across as many different clients and operating systems as possible. One way to achieve this is through responsive email design.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Web Development and Design* chapter.

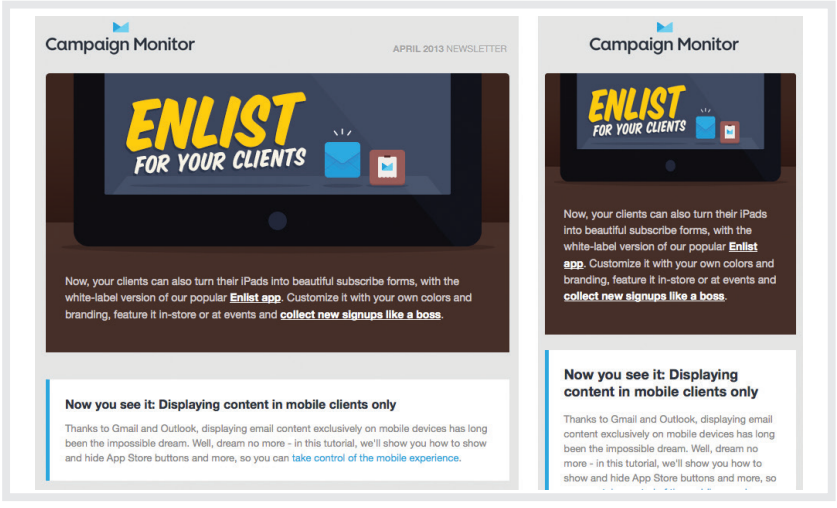

Figure 3. *The Campaign Monitor email template responds to the screen size of the device on which it is viewed.*

Some smartphones do render HTML emails and even auto-fit them to fit the mobile screen, but not all handsets do this.

The most important things to keep in mind when designing an email for mobile are:

- The screen is a lot smaller
- Inputs can vary, with touchscreens being the most common

So, your content must be easy to skim, with clear Calls to Action.

NOTE

Don't worry if some of this sounds a bit too technical. Your web developer will understand and be able to advise you.

Here are some common best practices to follow when designing your emails, to ensure optimal rendering on mobile devices:

- Generally, most emails are designed to be 600px wide to display well in an email preview pane – and this scales well on typical mobile screen sizes. On a 320px screen, an email can be zoomed out to 50% and display perfectly; similarly, on a 480px screen it can display at 75%.
- Host your email newsletters online and link to them from your preheader. That way, anyone who opens your email on a mobile – even those whose mobile phones display emails in plain text – can click straight through to an HTML version of your newsletter.
- Design your email in a grid system. This means your content needs to be laid out in vertically and horizontally aligned blocks, with gaps in between. Doing this will make it easier for various operating systems and email clients to scale your email down to fit a mobile screen. This is not a guarantee that the email will display properly in mobile, but it should solve the problem for most mobile devices (such as iPhone and BlackBerry) which auto-fit HTML emails.
- Make sure that you include alt text for your images! Your email needs to convey its message with or without images.
- Mobile devices that don't automatically scale your email down will display the content on the left of your email first. Make sure that your most important content is placed here.
- Button links need to be at least 44px to render well on mobile phones.

Something important to remember: **design for touch**.

Many mobile devices have touchscreens. This means that, instead of clicking on your links with a mouse, users will be tapping at your links with their fingers. If your links are placed too close together, it will be difficult for users to click on one link without accidentally also tapping the other. To make the user experience easier, make sure your links are placed in a 30–45px area, with a margin of at least 15px around them. By spacing links like this, it will be easier for touchscreen users to follow through on your Call to Action.

16.3.3 Rules and regulations

There are a number of laws across the world to protect people from unsolicited emails and stop businesses from abusing this communication channel. While they vary in severity according to the country (and we recommend that you do some research into your local legislation), it's important to acknowledge one very important rule. If someone requests to be unsubscribed from your communication, you have to meet their request or face penalties in many jurisdictions.

16.4 Step-by-step process

16.4.1 Growing a database

Running a successful email campaign requires a business to have a genuine opt-in database. This database – the list of subscribers who have agreed to allow a company to send them emails with marketing messages – is the most valuable asset of an email campaign.

Permission must be explicitly given by all people to whom emails are sent. Companies that abuse this can put their reputation in jeopardy, and in many countries, legal action can be taken against companies that send unsolicited bulk email – also known as spam.

It is important to track the permissions that are generated for each user – a time stamp is a key part of the data capture and opt-in process and helps to protect you against spam complaints and potential legal action.

Spam is unsolicited bulk email – it means that the recipient has not given permission to be sent that email. It is said to account for 72.1% of all email (Lab, 2013).

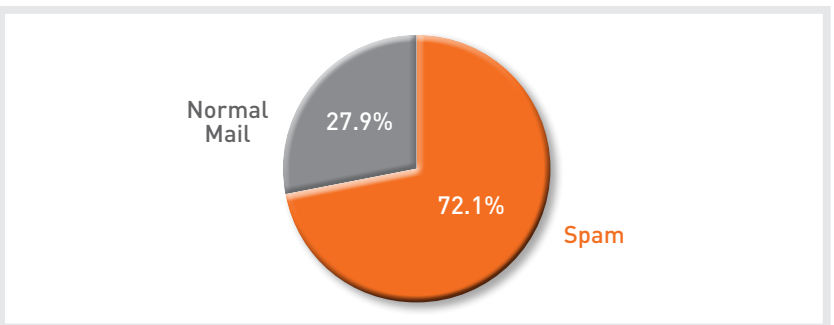

Figure 4. ***Almost three quarters of all email is spam.***

Growing this database, while keeping it targeted, is a key factor in any email campaign.

The database need have only one entry – the prospect's email – but the following should also be considered:

- Name, surname and title
- Date permission granted
- Source of permission
- Gender
- Country
- Telephone number, preferably mobile
- Date of birth
- Frequency (how often they'd like to hear from you)

Fields such as name, surname and title should be separated in your database. You should also gather date of birth as opposed to a prospect's age – it ensures that your database can stay up to date.

However, don't be tempted to ask for more information than required. The more information a marketer can gather, the better he or she can customise marketing messages. However, the more information a prospect is required to give, the less likely they are to sign up. Further information can be requested over time.

NOTE

As always, the best long-term strategy for growing your database is to create valuable, shareable content that people want to read.

There are a myriad of ways to attract prospects to opt in to a database. An email sign-up form on a company website is vital. Visitors to a website have already expressed an interest in a company by clicking through – this is an opportunity to develop that interest further. Following the same principle, any other properties where newsletter sign-up can be promoted should be taken advantage of. Consider a sign-up form on your company blog, email signatures, Facebook page, and mobi site, or perhaps mention it during presentations you deliver. And don't forget other offline marketing channels that you're already using, such as flyers, posters or in-store displays.

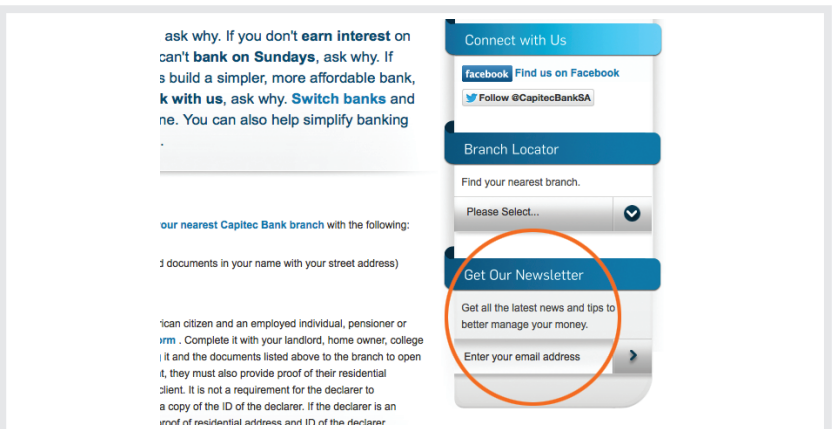

Figure 5. *An email newsletter sign-up Call to Action.*

Here are some best practice tips for sign-up forms:

- Put the sign-up form where it can be seen – above the fold and on every page.
- State your anti-spam stance explicitly, and be clear that you value subscribers' privacy.
- Clearly state what the subscriber's information will be used for.
- Use a clear Call to Action.
- Tell subscribers what they will get, and how often they will get it. Include a benefit statement.
- Ensure the email address is correct by checking the syntax.
- Test to see what works best!

Every interaction can be used to ask permission to send emails.

- Offer something valuable, and ask if they would sign up to your newsletter at the same time (for example, white paper, gift voucher, music track).
- Add a subscribe box to the checkout process of your retail site.
- Use interactions at trade shows to ask for email addresses.
- Ask for email addresses in store.
- Call out your email campaign on your social networks, and link through to your subscription form.

16.4.2 Designing an email

Emails should be created and viewed as HTML for desktop and most mobile devices. Simpler phones require basic text emails.

Text emails are the small, plain ones – text only, as the name suggests. If you use a Windows operating system, and you open Notepad and type there, you will be creating a text file. As these are text only, the copy really counts here.

HTML emails are the emails with more complex design. These emails can contain images, different fonts and hyperlinks. It's probably what you've had in mind throughout this chapter when we referred to email marketing.

Given that HTML emails are likely to take longer to download and use up more bandwidth, you should give your subscribers the choice of how they would like to view your email – in plain text or HTML.

NOTE

Refer to the images of the full newsletter later in this chapter to see how these elements look in context.

Parts of an email

Sender information

This includes the 'to', 'from' and 'reply to' fields. These are opportunities to build a relationship through creating a perception of familiarity. In other words, the reader needs to perceive that the newsletter is somewhat unique and sent personally by the publisher. Using a personalised company email address (for example, trevor@company.com) for the 'reply' field creates familiarity and builds trust with the reader. The 'from' address should also include the organisation's name. A meaningless 'from' address that the reader cannot identify serves only to confuse the origin of the newsletter.

Subject line

NOTE

You could also try personalising the subject line with the recipient's name or location to make your email stand out.

The subject line may be the most important part of an email! Subject lines help the reader to identify the email and entice them to open it. The subject line is also scrutinised by spam filters, and so you should avoid using characters, for example, *'#2$%&^^%###'* or *'!!!!!'*. Consistent subject lines, using the name of the company and the newsletter edition, can build familiarity and help readers to sort their inbox. Subject lines should also reflect the content of the email. As with everything online, testing different subject lines will lead marketers to the formula that works for them.

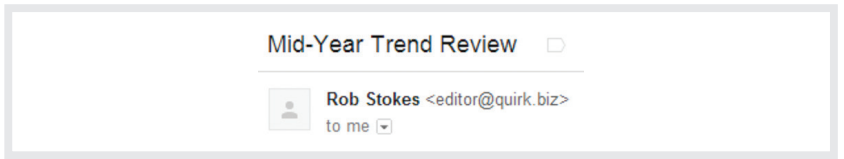

Figure 6. *Sender information and a subject line on an email.*

Preheader

The preheader is a line or two of text displayed above your email header. Most commonly, it's the line of text that will redirect you to 'View online'. With more and more people viewing emails on mobile phones, the preheader is also the ideal space in which to redirect to the mobile version of your email. Where possible, try including your Call to Action in the preheader. This could be difficult, given the limited space – but it does ensure that every recipient (even those who don't necessarily open the email, but who view only the preheader within the preview pane or inbox) will still be exposed to it.

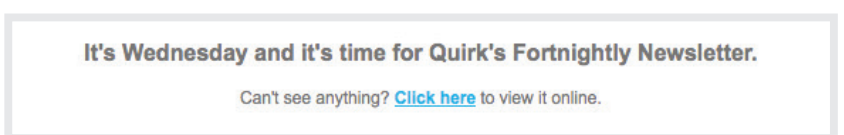

Figure 7. *An email preheader.*

Header

The header is the colourful banner or image that is included in many emails. This often contains the logo, which is important for branding, as well as a CTA or image to catch the recipient's attention. Not every email will have a header, but these do provide added impact.

Figure 8. *An email header.*

Personalised greeting

With a database that has the capability to store readers' names, it is possible to personalise the greeting of the email. "Hi, Kim Morgan" can elicit far better responses than "Dear Valued Customer", but it is possible to create a greeting with personality without personalising it. Occasionally, the subject line can be personalised as well to boost responses.

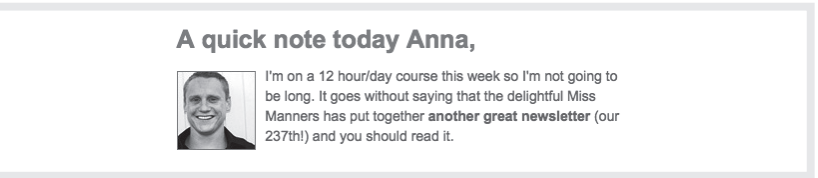

Figure 9. *A personalised email greeting.*

Body

This is where the content of the email goes. Don't be tempted to use too many images; they can increase the size of the email, and obscure text when images do not load. Be sure that text is not on the image, but instead can be read without an image being loaded. The structure must allow readers to scan and navigate the email easily. Short paragraphs, emphasis through bolding and colours, as well as sectioning information with bullets and borders, all contribute to a well-structured email.

Footer

A standard footer for emails helps to build consistency, and is the customary place to keep the contact details of the company sending the email. At the very least, this should include the name, physical address and contact email of the company. It can also include the privacy policy of the sender. One way to grow the email list is to add a 'forward to a friend' link in the footer. The most important part of the

footer is a clear unsubscribe link. Some ESPs enable you to place social media sharing buttons and links in the footer, allowing subscribers to share your email on their social networks.

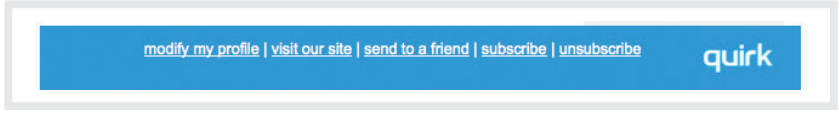

Figure 10. *An email footer with an unsubscribe link.*

Unsubscribe link

In many countries, it is mandatory to have an unsubscribe link on all commercial emails. In best practice terms, you should also include a link for managing subscription preferences – this lets the receiver decide exactly which emails they receive from you, rather than opting them out from all of your email marketing.

Working with templates

NOTE

Read more about this in the *User Experience Design* chapter.

An email template is a predesigned structure you can use for each email you send – you just need to slot content into the appropriate sections. Some email service providers offer ready-made templates for you to use. As with website templates, paid-for email templates come with some benefits and disadvantages. While they are often cheaper than commissioning a custom template, they can be inflexible and generic, meaning that they will not uniquely represent your brand. If you are choosing a template to buy, consider picking the plainest one, so that you can adapt it to your brand as needed.

A custom-designed email template will allow you to plan your own content structure and ensure it displays well across many email readers and devices.

When having your template designed, it's important to test it with a number of email readers, browsers and mobile devices so that you can ensure that it displays correctly. Given that many people choose to look at an email in their preview pane, this can become more challenging.

Design considerations

How an email looks is integral to how well it is received by your database. Design also refers to how it is built, which can impact on whether the email is delivered and on how likely users are to interact with it. Some design considerations are included below. A few of these are a little more technical, so make sure that your email partner has these covered for you.

The look and feel

Studies have found that users read or scan emails following an F-shape (Nielsen, 2006). So, plan your important information to follow this flow.

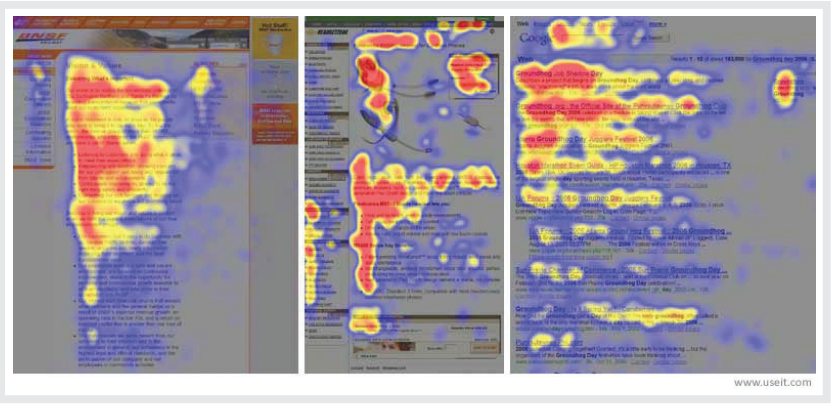

Figure 11. *Online, people tend to read in an F-shape. (Source: Nielsen, 2006)*

Cluttered inboxes and busy subscribers mean an email that's lengthy and difficult to get through probably won't be read. Help your subscribers by structuring your email content into segments, making use of borders or colour blocks to accentuate and divide content. It's important to balance image and text in your emails. Make a point of placing images next to the relevant text.

General design guidelines

HTML and CSS design principles differ for web and email. Here are a few things to keep in mind when designing your email:

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Web Development and Design* chapter.

- Don't make use of external or embedded style sheets and avoid unnecessary embedded rows and columns.
- Make use of table nesting as far as possible, as this is generally considered to render the best results with difficult email clients. Email designers tend to make use of tables to design their email layout, using inline styles within these tables.
- Set a fixed width for your email by specifying the width and spacing of each cell rather than the entire table. When these specifics are not declared, email clients tend to render the email according to their own defaults and can break the design.
- If you are using a block background colour, be sure to include a 100% width table to cover the entire email.
- Keep fonts in your email design larger than 9px. Anything below that becomes difficult to view in some email clients. Also bear in mind that, while coloured text (or light-on-dark text) may look visually impressive, it can be difficult to read an entire email like this and may strain your subscribers' eyes. Rather limit such visual tricks to smaller sections of your email, or to emails that contain less written content.
- Make use of inline CSS – some email clients strip the CSS from the head and body of the email.
- Test your emails in a variety of email clients before you send.

NOTE

Naturally, your email design should echo your overall corporate identity and personality.

Designing for the preview pane

Many email users use desktop clients to manage their email. Given the number of emails people receive on a daily basis, many do not open emails but prefer to view them in their preview panes. This has added another challenge for designers who want to ensure that their emails display properly.

Images and layout should consider the preview pane and be tested for rendering. Preview panes can be vertical or horizontal.

Tips for designing for the preview pane:

- There is no set width, and we reiterate that testing is the way to go. A width of 600px works best for preview pane display.
- Preview panes favour the top left-hand side of an email. While each preview pane may vary according to client or user settings, the most commonly favoured preview pane dimensions cover the area in the top 300–500px of your email (Hamilton, 2012). Given the width of 600 pixels, you're then (generally speaking) looking at the top 600px x 300px of your email as being most likely to be displayed in a preview pane.
- Ensure that plain, email-friendly fonts are used toward the top of your email in order to ensure that the first text encountered is properly displayed.
- Consider carefully what images you display in the top section of your email, and test display accordingly.
- Placing your logo prominently in the top left of your email can ensure optimal brand recognition and exposure.
- Try to include your Call to Action in the area displayed in the preview pane. That way, even if subscribers choose not to read your email, they'll still see your primary message.
- Some successful email templates use the area likely to be seen in the preview pane to provide a table of contents for the email. Users know what they can look forward to when opening the email.

Email and images

Avoid using images to convey important content. Make sure that there is alt text for all images used in the email. This ensures that the message of the image will still be communicated even if the image itself is not seen. Remember, many email clients are set by default not to display images. Your email should make sense whether or not the user enables images.

Tips for using images in email design:

- In the past, background images did not render well in emails, but this is changing. A block background colour tends to display well across most email clients.
- When including images in your HTML, be sure to declare the height and width for each image to ensure consistent rendering across most email clients.

Emails that make sense without images, and render correctly across all platforms, are more likely to persuade a reader to load the images (and open the email), as well as click through to the website.

NOTE

The images you use in the email should support the overall message, rather than convey it directly. If the image doesn't appear, the message should still be clear.

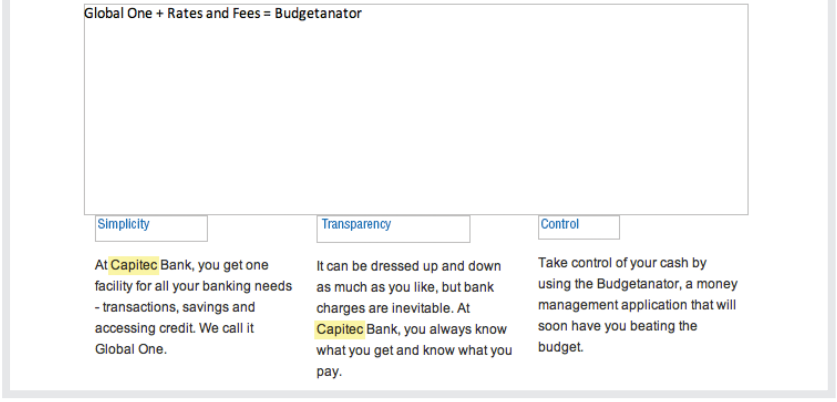

Figure 12. ***Good use of clear image alt tags in an email newsletter.***

The Call to Action

Email design should support the Calls to Action. In order for your campaign to be effective, your goals and KPIs should be supported by the email layout and design. Calls to Action can be hyperlinked text (also called text links), or can be images which look like buttons. Don't forget though, that if images are blocked, your buttons will be blocked too.

Generally, both text links and CTA buttons are effective for generating clickthroughs. While you should use buttons for links that support your CTA (for example, 'make a booking', 'check availability'), your email shouldn't be littered with them, and hyperlinks should be used for additional links. The best thing to do is test them to see what kinds of CTAs perform best for you.

The copy of the CTA is exceptionally important: a well-crafted and enticingly written CTA makes a big difference to the performance of your campaign. Again, test variations to determine what drives the highest clickthrough and conversion rates on your campaigns.

Testing

The design should be tested to ensure that it renders clearly in as many clients as possible. Make sure that images line up, that copy is clear and that all the links work.

16.4.3 Creating content

Email content that is relevant and valuable to readers is vital to ensuring the success of an email marketing campaign. Valuable content is informative and should address the problems and needs of readers. It is important to realise that the reader determines the value of the content, not the publisher. Newsletters can offer:

- Humour
- Research
- Information
- Promotions
- Exclusive content

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Content Marketing Strategy* chapter.

Determining the content of your email is an important element of your overall brand content strategy.

Any copy written for your brand should follow a pre-determined brand voice guide. Consistency is important and will dictate how your customers trust and build a relationship with your brand.

The principles of writing good online copy apply. You should start with the most important information first, and make sure that your language is scannable (meaning that it makes use of the appropriate formatting, such as bolding and bulleted lists).

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Writing for Digital* chapter.

It may be helpful to review the *Writing for Digital* chapter at this stage, but there are two elements that are important to highlight with respect to writing for email marketing.

1. The first is **in-email links**. It's important to consider that any links you include in your email copy will lead readers away from your email. You'll want to keep these to a minimum, and include a link only when it is a Call to Action, a legal requirement or a service feature.
2. The second element is the all-important **subject line**. Many users decide whether or not to open an email based on their first point of contact – the subject line.

For an email newsletter, it's useful to put together a recurring content structure. The example shown here depicts a consistent content structure with repeating elements.

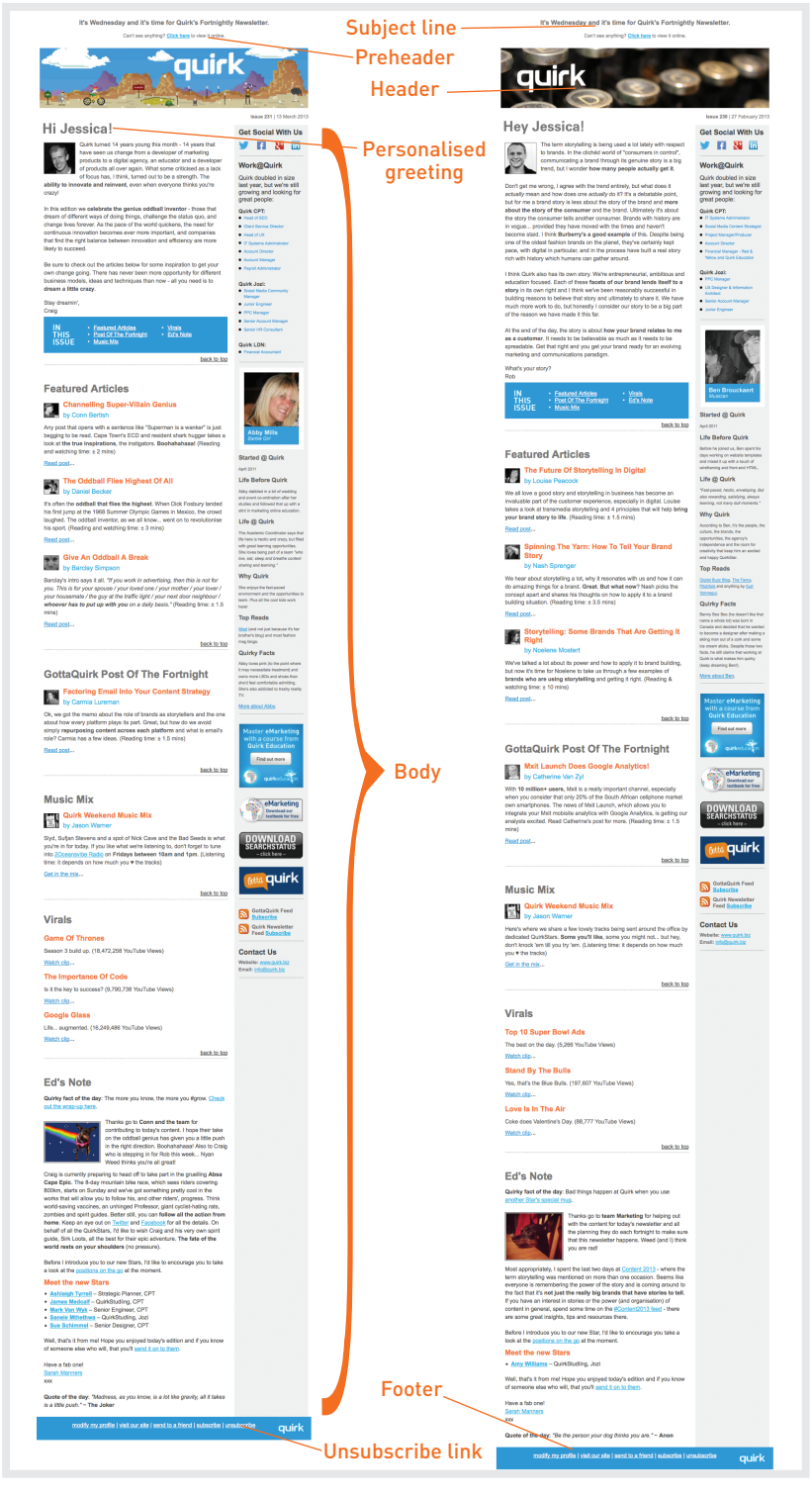

Figure 13. *Two editions of a newsletter, showing a similar structure.*

NOTE

Note how the same elements recur every month, creating consistency and delivering on reader expectations.

If your newsletter contains a lot of content, it is advisable to include enticing snippets with a link to the full article displayed elsewhere, such as in your company blog. Sending out too much long content in your newsletter can be daunting for time-starved readers, and they may not make it all the way through your newsletter. However, if your newsletter consists of only one article, it may help to publish it in full.

Figure 14. *An article snippet in an email newsletter.*

16.4.4 Segmenting your database

The technology of email marketing allows for mass customisation – it is one-to-one marketing on a macro scale. Even simple personalisation can see improved results.

Customisation covers everything from using the recipient's name, to sending the correct email version to their device, to sophisticated measurement of a recipient's preferences and tailoring content to suit them.

NOTE

Other options include segmenting by location, user behaviour on site or position in the sales funnel (for example, potential or existing customers).

Segmenting a database can allow for customisation across demographics or purchase history. For example, you may choose to divide your database according to gender or age. A political campaign may benefit from targeting messages to different demographics. A pet store may find it useful to segment their mailing list according to the different kinds of pets their customers own. In this way, it is possible to send mailers that are slightly different and tweaked to different target groups.

16.4.5 Deploying

By creating valuable content, establishing the correct frequency and testing the email for display and deliverability, an email marketer should be able to ensure an excellent delivery rate. Consistency in deploying newsletters also aids in fostering trust and fulfilling expectations.

When should you send emails? Common sense tells you not on Monday morning or Friday afternoon, but this varies by audience. Testing will guide you. Generally speaking, the best days of the week to send emails are between Tuesday and Thursday.

Email reputation

Email reputation is a score given to you depending on how well your emails are regarded by Internet Service Providers (ISPs) and your subscribers. If the sender's score falls within the ISP's thresholds, a sender's messages will be delivered. If not, the sender's emails may arrive in the bulk or spam folder, be quarantined, or be bounced back to the sender.

How it works: There are various authentication systems that can impact your reputation score. One of these is the Domain Keys Identified Mail (DKIM) and Domain Name System (DNS). DKIM associates domain names with individual email addresses, ensuring that each organisation has to take responsibility for emails sent that are associated with their domain. Basically, DKIM signs out any outbound emails. The DKIM signature is added to the email header and includes an encrypted code. The receiving mail server will then take that DKIM signature and verify it with the DNS system to find the matching DKIM public key. Once it has this key, it can use it to unlock the encrypted code – if the code hasn't been changed, the email hasn't been tampered with, which means it can be authenticated and passed into the receiving mail server.

Becoming an effective email marketer requires constant list cleansing and hygiene. In fact, most lists shrink by 30% each year as a result of subscribers changing email addresses. Build a preference centre and send out an email once a year asking subscribers to update their details. Make sure you are diligent about maintaining a current opt-in list to achieve maximum deliverability via reputation.

Tips to help your reputation score:

- ISPs offer various authentication standards such as Sender ID, Sender policy framework (SPF), and DomainKeys. Quirk highly recommends the use of these standards.
- Remember that a huge but inaccurate and outdated database is far less useful to an email marketer than a tightly maintained, smaller database. Strive to boost your database, but don't forget to clean as you go.
- Ensure that email broadcast rates are not too high.
- Respond to complaints and unsubscribe requests – if someone requests to be unsubscribed, do so. If you don't, there's a good chance you'll face stiff penalties.
- Educate users about white lists.

An email's reputation score can be checked at www.senderscore.org.

NOTE

The success of your email marketing relies on people explicitly indicating that they want to hear from you - don't break your customer's trust.

If the recipient has given permission to be sent marketing messages by email, then it is not spam. Users give permission when they tick a box that says: "Yes, please send me offers from your company by email". The email address can be provided to another company only if the user ticks a box that says: "Yes, please send me offers by email from third parties selected by you".

Permission must be explicitly given to the company. Trying to gain permission in a sneaky way is illegal and should never be done.

An email's spam score can be checked at spamassassin.apache.org.

16.4.6 Measuring

As with all things digital marketing, tracking, analysing and optimising are key to growth and success. Email tracking systems produce statistics in a user-friendly manner.

Key measurables for understanding the performance of email campaigns include:

- **Number of emails delivered**.
- **Number of bounces** (this should be separated into hard bounces and soft bounces).
- **Number of unique emails opened**: an email can be delivered, but not opened.
- **Unsubscribes**: significant or consistent loss in subscribers is a key indication you are not meeting the needs of your subscribers.
- **Pass-on rate**: a high pass-on rate (forwards) indicates that your customers value the content enough to share it constantly with others. Putting an easy 'forward to a friend' link in every email can increase this. You'll want to measure this link specifically. Adding a sign-up link to forwarded emails will organically grow the opt-in list.
- **Clickthrough rates and conversion**: These measure the effectiveness of an email via the links placed in the content. When a reader clicks through to a web page, these can be easily measured as a percentage against the number of delivered, opened or sent emails. It reveals which content or promotion was the most enticing for the reader.

Some metrics are more useful than others. A good example of this is the open rate. Emails are tracked using an image that gets downloaded, but many email desktop clients block the downloading of images. This means that people may be reading a text-only version of your email.

What you should be interested in is what activity takes place based on an email. So you'll need to track leads or actions. You can do this through link tagging (appending tracking parameters to a URL in your newsletter). These parameters are then identified by the Google Analytics of your website, registering that the user has come to the site through your email. Google Analytics will then take the information in the tag and store it in a cookie, from which it can track the user's interactions with the site after they arrived at the landing page.

Here is a link to the Quirk website as it may appear in a Quirk email campaign:
http://www.quirk.biz/?utm_source=dec01&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=digital marketing2013

The tracking parameters are:
?utm_source=dec01&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=digital marketing2013

These can then be used to report on traffic from that email using Google Analytics.

Generic email benchmarks can be used as a guide to see how well your campaigns are performing, but the best way to monitor performance is to benchmark your own campaign.

Smaller lists tend to have a higher open rate, but this is probably because they're more targeted. The overall average open rate is 11.2%, while the overall clickthrough rate is 1.6%. Overall rates are quite low because far too many ignorant or lazy email marketers bring down the average. It's best to look at the average open rate for your industry, rather than the overall rates. You can do this by checking the Email Stat Centre website (EmailStatCenter, n.d.).

Once the reports have been generated, it is time to work out what the numbers are revealing, and then use this information to improve the next email sent out.

16.4.7 Testing

In order to make sure that your email marketing efforts are continually improving, it's important to test your campaigns.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Conversion Optimisation* chapter.

The most common form of email testing is to conduct an A/B split test. This is a test that involves sending one version of your newsletter to a specified percentage

of your database, while sending a modified version to the remainder of your database. Some factors to test include:

- Open rates across different subject lines and delivery times.
- Optimal number of links in an email for clickthrough rates and conversions.
- Different copy styles and copy length.
- The effect of video on delivery rates, open rates and conversions.
- Balance of text and image ratio.

By monitoring the results of each send, you can determine which version yielded the desired results. You can, for instance, test variations of your subject line to determine which is more effective in persuading subscribers to open your email.

NOTE

Also test your personalisation efforts: for example, does including the recipient's name make a difference? Do you get higher clickthroughs if the content is adapted to the recipient's location?

Examples of what to test:

- Subject lines
- Send times
- Best day to send
- Layout
- Text vs. button links
- Database segmentation
- Call to Action

Testing and monitoring your send statistics go hand in hand. It's important to analyse your results after sending to ensure you're implementing the most effective strategies for your database.

16.5 Tools of the trade

There are many good ESPs available.

MailChimp (www.mailchimp.com) is one example of an email service provider that can manage the email send for you from start to finish. It provides tracking, support, subscriber list management and email templates.

More advanced ESPs that offer a range of message and campaign management facilities, as well as broader data management and delivery value, include ExactTarget (www.exacttarget.com), Silverpop (www.silverpop.com) and Responsys (www.responsys.com).

All emails need to be tested for email client compatibility as well as for any potential spam problems.

For email client compatibility, as well as mobile rendering, you can test your email at: www.pivotalveracity.com/email-marketing-solution/email-rendering.html

An email's spam score can be checked at: spamassassin.apache.org

An email's reputation score can be checked at: www.senderscore.org

Quirk's fortnightly digital marketing newsletter is a good example of best-practice email marketing (and you may learn about other digital marketing disciplines too!): http://www.quirk.biz/resources/newsletterarchive.q

Once an email has been sent, results need to be analysed to pinpoint areas for growth for the next campaign. Use your ESP's built-in analytics feature and correlate this with your Google Analytics data.

16.6 Advantages and challenges

Permission-based email marketing can give the highest return on investment of any marketing activities. Technology allows mass customisation, allowing personalisation across a large list of subscribers.

When used to foster relationships with a customer base, email marketing can go a long way to increasing the lifetime value of that customer.

Email marketing is highly measurable, and databases are able to be easily and thoroughly segmented.

However, with the increasing numbers of companies and individuals using email marketing, many consumers are email fatigued. It requires ingenuity, focus and dedication to maintain an email database and consistently deliver useful quality emails that will be read.

It does not take much for email to be marked as spam, and it can be difficult to recover from being branded as a spammer by the ISPs.

16.7 Case study – Zando

16.7.1 One-line summary

Zando achieves a 78% open rate by implementing email marketing best practices.

16.7.2 The problem

Zando is a South African online fashion store that sells a wide range of clothes, shoes and accessories around the country. In an effort to increase their database of customers, Zando considered running an email-based marketing campaign.

Zando approached Digital Fire, a digital marketing agency, to assist them with their email campaign. Zando wanted to create brand awareness, target new customers, grow their existing email database with quality leads, and increase traffic to their website in an effort to boost sales. Ideal new customers who fitted into their target market would need to be high-earning female South African urbanites (Digital Fire, 2012).

16.7.3 The solution

To meet these business objectives, Digital Fire created an email campaign with an enticing Call to Action at its core. Readers were offered the chance for them and a friend to "win a new pair of shoes every month for a year" (Digital Fire, 2012).

Figure 15. *The Zando email newsletter.*

The campaign profiled and tracked user actions, and allowed readers to pass the email on to their friends easily. The Call to Action 'click here to enter' prompted readers to fill in their own details, and those of a friend, for the Zando database (Digital Fire, 2012).

The email was sent to 70 000 people in Zando's target market from a well-maintained opt-in email database, with a second follow-up email sent later (Digital Fire, 2012).

16.7.4 The results

An impressive 29% of people who received the first email opened it, with 11 800 people entering the competition with their personal details and signing up to the Zando email newsletter (Digital Fire, 2012). This is a great result considering that traditionally direct mail has a response rate of around 0.1%.

The follow-up email was sent to competition entrants, thanking them for entering the competition and encouraging them to have a look at the Zando website. An astonishing 78% of these recipients clicked though, which resulted in more than 5 000 new visits to the Zando (Digital Fire, 2012).

Key elements that contributed to the campaign's success were:

- A well-managed and filtered email contact database
- Striking design
- Effective copy
- A strong Call to Action
- An enticing incentive
- The entering mechanism where the reader and a friend's details were requested

The viral sharing element particularly contributed to the campaign's success (Digital Fire, 2012).

16.8 The bigger picture

While email marketing can operate as a stand-alone marketing campaign, integrating it with other channels, both online and offline, will serve to reinforce the brand's message and increase responses.

There should never be a disparity between the content, tone or design of an email when compared to the rest of a company's offerings. In-store promotions can be reinforced and promoted to an email database, or website information can be summarised for email.

Custom landing pages, if required, should be created for any promotions being communicated by email. For the most part, marketing emails should aim to get the customer to the site; landing pages are therefore essential. They need to be optimised to close the Call to Action. So the email gets the subscriber onto the page and the landing page gets them to sign up, buy, or engage. The idea is to create a flow between the two that brings the 'selling' process full circle – whether it's actually buying something or just reading through the content to engage them with the brand.

Email marketing and social media work very well together for cross-channel promotion. Where email can create a one-on-one feel between a brand and an individual, social media can move that attention towards a sense of community and keep your reader involved in a dialogue.

16.9 Summary

Email marketing is a form of direct marketing that can deliver the best ROI of any digital marketing tactic. It is:

- Highly targeted and customisable
- Cost effective
- Easy to set up, test and track

Gaining explicit permission to send email marketing to a person is a prerequisite for successful email marketing. Once you have this permission, all emails sent by an organisation and the individuals in that organisation can be seen as marketing opportunities.

Successful email marketing requires careful planning and testing. HTML emails need to be tested across a range of email clients, and should be tested for a spam score, before being deployed.

All email sent to a list of subscribers needs to provide an easy and accessible unsubscribe link in the email. Make sure you adhere to your local regulations for email marketing.

16.10 Case study questions

1. Which elements of Zando's email marketing constitute best practice?
2. What role did the database play in this example? Why was it so important?
3. Explain how viral sharing played a role in the success of this campaign.

16.11 Chapter questions

1. What is meant by 'mass customisation', and why is this so beneficial?
2. What are the key differences between direct marketing by email and direct marketing by post?
3. Why is it important for permission to be gained before marketing by email to a prospect?
4. Emails that are expected and recognised are more likely to be read. How can a marketer use this knowledge to increase the readership of emails?

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17

Mobile Marketing

What's inside: The **key terms and concepts** required for understanding mobile marketing. We then include an introduction to marketing through **SMS**, **MMS**, **USSD** and **augmented reality**. We explore **mobile analytics** and mechanics for measuring your mobile marketing efforts.

17.1 Introduction

The mobile web is ubiquitous; six out of every seven people in the world use a mobile phone – that's six billion people (Wang, 2013). More people are active on Facebook through mobile devices than desktop (Tam, 2013); comScore research shows that Americans spent 225.4 billion minutes on the Facebook mobile app and mobi site during the second quarter of 2013, and 18.4 billion minutes on Twitter's mobile app and site (Vranica, 2013).

The Mobile Marketing Association (MMA) defines mobile marketing as "a set of practices that enables organisations to communicate and engage with their audience in an interactive and relevant manner through any mobile device or network" (Mobile Marketing Association, 2013).

Mobile devices are important to consider in any marketing strategy, and this chapter looks at the ways in which we can use mobile as part of an engagement strategy.

NOTE

Google's marketing philosophy involves "reaching people in the moments that matter". Mobile plays an essential part in this.

Mobile engagement extends far beyond just the mobile phone, or just SMS marketing. It's a mindset rather than a specific tactic. It's all about context – reaching people at exactly the right time, place and mood to facilitate their needs, provide a convenient touchpoint and encourage them to convert.

It's important to note that mobile marketing is very different in the developed world – where smartphones dominate, delivering rich web and application user experiences – and the developing world – where many phones are still text based, have crude WAP browsers, and radio, USSD and SMS are the most prolific services. Mobile users have a hierarchy of needs, which are fulfilled to various degrees by the capabilities of their devices:

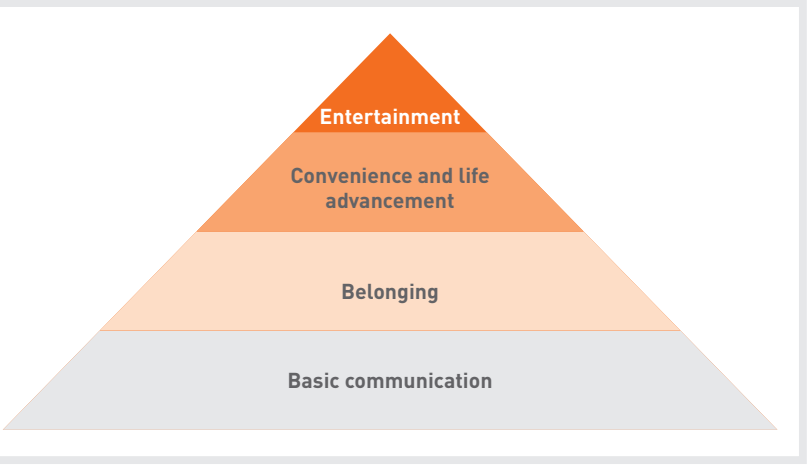

Figure 1. *The mobile hierarchy of needs, devised by the Quirk Think team.*

At the foundation, people use mobile devices to communicate – by voice, text or web access. Belonging addresses the need to be social and to form communities, using tools such as mobile social networks. Further up, mobile devices allow a great degree of on-the-go convenience, such as online shopping, research, mobile banking, career listings, coupons, and more – these more advanced capabilities are not available on very basic mobile devices. Education and information gathering also fit in here. Finally, mobile phones can entertain through games, apps and rich media.

Understanding where your target market falls on this scale will allow you to communicate more effectively with them, using the correct mobile channels and approaches.

In this chapter, you will learn:

- Why mobile is the most important communication channel available to marketers today
- A variety of mobile messaging channels and applications, from simple SMS messaging to advanced mobile commerce
- The role that mobile can play in a holistic marketing strategy, taking advantage of its unique features
- How to track and measure mobile activity

17.2 Key terms and concepts

Term	Definition
3G	Third Generation of mobile communications systems. A set of wireless protocols or standards used to transmit data to and from mobile devices. It is faster than previous generations, offering users a wider range of advanced services while achieving greater network capacity.
Application	Software that is developed specifically for smartphones and other mobile devices. Also known as an app. There are two types: mobile web apps and native apps.
Augmented reality (AR)	A variation of virtual reality that takes computer graphics and superimposes them onto the physical space around the person operating an AR device. These graphics can be 3D images or simply information tags about a location.
Bluetooth	A short-distance wireless transfer protocol for connecting devices.

Common Short Code (CSC)	A special number or code that can be used to address SMS and MMS messages from mobile phones or fixed phones, usually to get something in return.
Geo-targeting	Also known as location-based targeting. Delivering specific information or content to a user based on their geographic location. Mobile devices can enable this with high precision through features such as GPS and other location-based services.
Multimedia Message Service (MMS)	A media-rich extension of SMS, which allows picture, sound or low-quality videos to be sent on a wireless network.
QR code	Also known as a 2D barcode. These are scannable barcodes that can be read by certain mobile applications (by taking a photo of the barcode). They contain information such as a URL.
Short Message Service (SMS)	Text messages that can be sent to mobile phones from the Internet or from other mobile devices. Usually limited to 160 characters.
Unstructured Supplementary Service Data (USSD)	A messaging protocol used to connect mobile devices with a service provider's computers, often enabling a variety of applications and creating a real-time connection that allows two-way interaction.
Wireless Application Protocol (WAP)	A set of protocols used to connect mobile phones to the Internet over a mobile wireless network.
Wireless Fidelity (Wi-Fi)	The transfer of information from one device to another over a distance without the use of wires.

17.3 The role of mobile in personal communication

Mobile is an excellent marketing, advertising and distribution channel due to its always-on, always nearby nature. As mobile devices offer constant access and communication to users, they add a layer of interaction to existing real-world relationships.

17.3.1 Six unique features of mobile

Tomi Ahonen, an expert in mobile communications, has laid out six features that are unique to mobile and act as a framework for understanding mobile communications (Ahonen, 2008). These features affect the way we create and view mobile content.

1. Mobile devices are personal.

While most computers do present a personal connection to the Internet, they are not as personal as mobile devices. Mobile phones are part of people's personal presentation and their social affiliations.

The implication for marketers: Respect for privacy and permission is important in all aspects of marketing, particularly when it comes to mobile.

NOTE

Think about your own habits: when was the last time your mobile phone was out of reach, or turned off?

2. Mobile devices are always carried.

Consider your own behaviour: what do you take with you when you leave your house – wallet, keys and mobile phone?

The implication for marketers: Messages sent to mobile devices will most likely be accessed within minutes of being received. Messages sent to recipients can be read and acted on immediately.

3. Mobile devices are always on.

In order to fulfil its primary function – as a communication tool – the mobile device is always on.

The implication for marketers: Marketers need to be even more sensitive with their marketing communications. Not many people would appreciate an SMS at 4am informing them of a special offer.

4. Mobile devices have a built-in payment system.

All mobile phones (and many other mobile devices) have a built-in payment mechanism – the SIM card. Billing is easily handled through the user's mobile network. On top of that, paying for content and downloads has been built into the way that consumers use their devices.

The implication for marketers: Consumers are willing to pay for services and content on their mobile devices. Advertising is not the only way to generate revenue for content.

5. Mobile devices are available at the point of creative inspiration.

The mobile device features a number of tools that let users act on creative impulse, from taking photos and videos to becoming a scribbling pad on which to jot down ideas. Tools like Instagram, Evernote and Snapchat are purpose built for creating, sharing and consuming creative content.

The implication for marketers: This feature can be used to encourage interactivity within campaigns created for mobile. It presents the mobile device as a useful

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Customer Relationship Management* chapter.

tool in viral campaigns based on consumer-generated content. The flipside is that people can also post negative brand messages in the heat of the moment if they have a bad experience; online monitoring and CRM should be considered here for managing any potential backlash.

6. Mobile devices allow accurate audience measurement.

Every transaction made on a mobile device can be uniquely tracked, whether the transaction is a voice call, an SMS message or access to the Internet. They also allow for real-time tracking, where campaigns can be tweaked as they are run, and for location-based tracking, where customers receive marketing messages base on where they are physically located.

The implication for marketers: Aggregated data provides profiling and segmenting opportunities for targeting the right audience. Campaigns can also be accurately measured and tracked for their return on investment (ROI). As always, make sure you are respecting your customers' privacy and obtaining their consent.

17.3.2 Mobile devices: An overview

Mobile devices span beyond just mobile phones. While we focus on mobile phones in this chapter, since those are the most prevalent, it's important to acknowledge that mobile devices include portable game consoles, media players, global positioning systems and tablets.

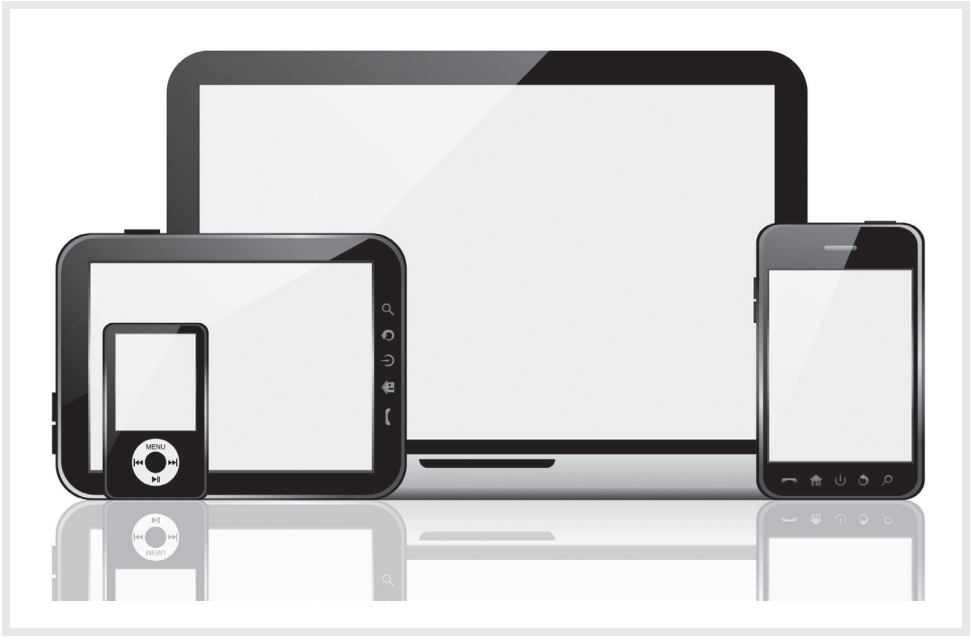

Figure 2. ***'Mobile' includes many different mobile devices.***

Of course, many people own more than one mobile device, or use it in connection with various other devices. This phenomenon of multiscreen usage is very important for marketers to understand. Here are some common scenarios:

- People often browse eCommerce websites using their mobile device, but then make the final purchasing decision at a desktop computer.
- Similarly, customers may use their mobile devices in physical retail outlets to scan, compare and research items, making their purchase later once they've had the chance to research in more detail.
- Commonly, people use a mobile device like a smartphone or a tablet while watching TV, simultaneously engaging with two screens and streams of content at once.

NOTE

Reality TV shows take advantage of this by providing a number that viewers can contact to vote, share comments or affect the outcome of the programme.

By understanding how your audience uses their devices in combination, or at different stages of the sales process, you can improve your CRM, marketing and analytics processes.

Mobile network standards

When it comes to mobile, there tend to be lots of confusing acronyms and technical terms to understand; as a marketer, however, it's not vital to understand all the nitty gritty details. To keep things simple, mobile network standards are the technologies used to connect a mobile device to the mobile network. There are three main ones you should know:

- GSM is the most widespread global network standard and is found across Europe, Africa, and most other parts of the world
- CDMA is predominantly found in the US, Canada and some Asian countries
- LTE is an upcoming, upgraded and faster version of GSM

17.4 Mobile messaging channels

There are many features built into the mobile phone that can form a part of your marketing campaigns.

17.4.1 SMS

Short Message Service (SMS) is the largest data application on the planet. By the end of 2013, mobile users will be sending 19.5 billion SMSs per day (Clark-Dickson, 2013). It is also one of the simplest and most effective mobile marketing channels available. Interestingly, SMS messages were initially designed as a way for network engineers to conduct tests on mobile networks, and not for commercial use at all.

SMS messages can be a maximum of 160 characters long, although it is possible to string several together in order to send longer messages (this is called concatenating). Messages can be sent from one phone to another or from a desktop computer to a phone and vice versa.

Almost all mobile phones support SMS. The restriction on the amount of data that can be communicated through SMS demands simplicity, and so consideration must be given to working creatively within the space of the small screen.

NOTE

Many smartphones allow users to block spam numbers directly from the device - make sure that your SMS communications don't compel your customers to do this!

SMS has useful marketing applications. It enables two-way communication, which allows subscribers to activate services and cheaply access important information. However, abusing this type of communication can also be problematic. The mobile phone is a highly personal device, and the potential to invade a mobile user's personal space is much greater.

SMS and marketing

With the massive volume of SMS messages being sent every day, SMS marketing must be considered by marketers. However, mobile phone users have proved reluctant to hand over their phone numbers for marketing messages, perhaps fearing a similar deluge of spam to the one they receive in their email inboxes.

This is changing to some extent, with the prevalence of Common Short Codes (CSC) in marketing. CSCs are short codes used in text messages, usually to get something in return, such as a competition entry. These can be sent to and from consumers, and often use keywords. There are two standard keywords that should always elicit a standard response:

- STOP. Unsubscribe the sender's number from the service.
- HELP. A support request from the sender's number.

Figure 3. *A Common Short Code on a competition entry from Spark ATM.*

As consumers are comfortable with using text messages for their communication, no extensive education process is required to have consumers access marketing campaigns based on CSCs.

There are several ways that SMS messages can be used to complement an existing marketing strategy.

Customer relationship management

SMS updates can be an exceptionally useful tool for customer relationship management (CRM). In the travel industry, hotel and airplane reservations can be sent by mobile phone, with updates being sent close to the time of travel. These short messages can include directions or details of a flight's status. When it comes to insurance claims or order processing, SMS updates on the progress of a claim or order can reduce call centre volumes and go a long way to ensuring that a client feels valued.

Promotions

SMS messages allow you to send timely sales promotions to a large database for a relatively low cost. These can be targeted to a particular time of day when prospects are most likely to be out shopping.

Receiving messages

CSCs are often used to receive messages from prospects or customers. They provide a fast, instant and trackable means for the public to enter competitions, voice opinions, or make requests. Even better for a company, the costs can often be passed on to the consumer, meaning that it can be a cost-effective way to receive marketing messages.

Please call me messages

Please call me messages – SMSs that are sent for free, asking the recipient to phone the sender back – are popular across Africa. These usually include an advert after the message, and this is an excellent position to reach lower-LSM users, who are more likely to be sending these messages.

17.4.2 MMS

Multimedia Messaging Service (MMS) is the media-rich version of SMS messages, and can contain graphics, audio, video, or images and text. These messages allow for richer information to be sent using WAP, but the costs are considerably higher.

MMS messages are particularly useful in viral campaigns, encouraging participants to use their phones to create content (photographic, audio or video) and pass on content. However, MMS usage doesn't appear to be a cost-effective method for marketers as it requires the recipient to bear considerable data costs to receive the messages.

17.4.3 Wi-Fi and Bluetooth

Apart from cellular network connectivity, most modern mobile devices have the ability to connect via Wi-Fi or Bluetooth.

Figure 4. *The Bluetooth logo.*

NOTE

How would you feel if you suddenly received a Bluetooth message while out and about? Would you consider this valuabe or invasive? Would this also depend on the brand sending the message?

If a user sets his or her Bluetooth-enabled mobile device to 'discoverable', Bluetooth devices within range of the phone can request to connect to it and exchange messages and data. This can be used to send location-specific marketing messages, such as discount codes in a shopping mall.

17.4.4 USSD

Unstructured supplementary service data (USSD) is an alternative messaging system to SMS and is available on most mobile data networks.

Unlike SMS, USSD is a protocol that allows a query-and-response action between the customer and a service centre. USSD services are initiated by the user, who enters a code on the device and then sends that as a request to the network. The code differs from the number to which an SMS is sent because it includes the symbols # and *. For example, a code like *100# can be used to check the balance of a prepaid airtime account.

These services are often used by networks to provide a service to a customer, such as requesting balance information, adding credit to a prepaid contract or passing on credit to another mobile phone user. Using USSD can also help you build up a profile of your customer, by tracking the kinds of interactions and services they engage in. On top of that, USSD can be used to gather data for CRM purposes, and to conduct surveys, in which you can gather specific data about respondents.

USSD also allows users to complete a double opt in, which is required in some jurisdictions before you can send marketing messages to a recipient.

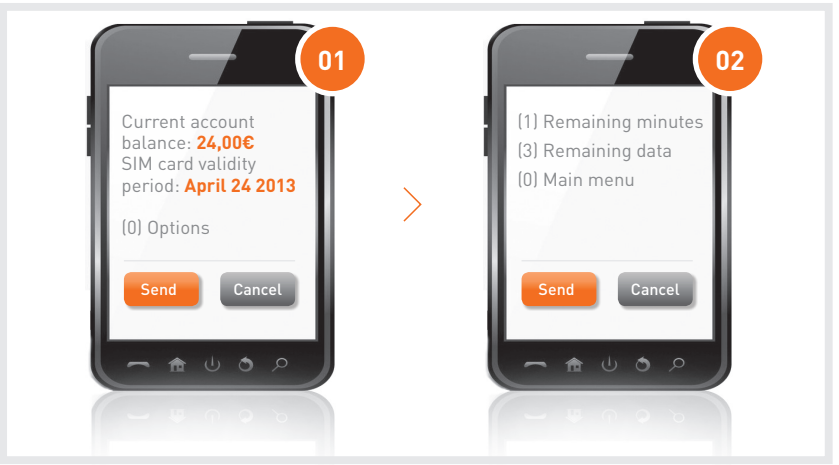

Figure 5. *How USSD appears on a phone.*

It is a rudimentary navigation process, but with far faster response times and lower costs when compared to SMS or to mobile browsing. In lower-income markets where web access is not prevalent, USSD can be a very powerful tool for engaging mobile users – it has a high success rate, low technological barrier to entry, and a low cost for the marketer.

M-Pesa is a mobile money-transfer service that was created in Kenya in 2007. It was devised to allow urban workers to send money home to their rural families, who had little or no access to banking or postal services, but who owned or could access a mobile phone. Since the money is transferred by SMS or USSD, no Internet access is required either.

M-Pesa has been so successful in Kenya that is has over 10.5 million active monthly subscribers, who have transferred over $5.9 billion (between October 2012 and March 2013) through 65,547 registered agents around the country (Safaricom, 2013).

M-Pesa has been rolled out to countries across sub-Saharan Africa and Asia.

17.4.5 Instant messaging

Instant messaging makes it possible for people to exchange messages in real time. To users, it offers many of the benefits of SMS, but it is instant and often cheaper. According to Juniper Research, mobile IM users will exceed 1.3 billion globally by 2016. The report also states that the market is fragmented across a wide range of apps and service providers (mobiThinking, 2012).

IM applications are available to users who own smartphones and also on some feature phones. Some of the better known are BlackBerry Messenger, WeChat and

WhatsApp, which can be installed on any smartphone and some feature phones. Other device-agnostic services include Google Talk and Skype.

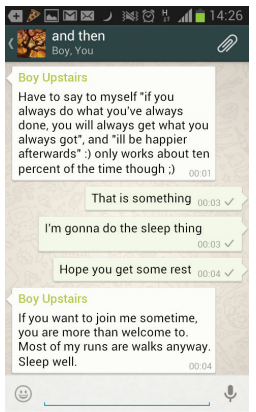

Figure 6. *A WhatsApp discussion on a mobile phone.*

From a marketer's point of view, IM can offer a channel for customer support, but presents even more of a risk in terms of alienating or angering consumers. This is a space reserved for personal contacts. That said, instant support gives you the chance to reach customers when they are focused on your service or product. This relies on the assumption that you are available to provide the information needed instantly. The alternative would just frustrate users.

17.4.6 QR codes

QR codes, also called 3D barcodes, offer a way to compress complex information into an image that can be decoded by your mobile phone.

QR codes can offer users with camera phones a convenient way to get information with just one click. Once you have installed a QR code reading app, these barcodes can be interpreted by the phone's camera to provide website URLs, contact information, discount vouchers, or even to activate downloads.

Figure 7. *The QR code for the GottaQuirk blog.*

The image on the left may look like a hybrid between a crossword and a Sudoku puzzle, but it's really the QR code for the URL of the mobile version of the marketing blog GottaQuirk, m.gottaquirk.com.

QR codes are a pull technology – they allow users to take the actions they want conveniently and quickly. They can be useful for sharing product or promotional information. One of the exciting benefits of QR codes is that they offer a way to activate offline advertising and make it interactive and measurable. A print campaign can, for example, include a barcode that can be used to send a user directly to your website.

QR codes are especially popular in East Asian countries, where the large prevalence of sophisticated smartphones makes accessing and using them easy.

However, QR codes do have their issues. They can be prone to bugs, and they also face a large barrier to entry for most smartphone users (since it is necessary to first install a specialised app before you can scan and use QR codes).

NOTE

Have you ever scanned a QR code with your phone? What was the experience like? If not, what is holding you back?

17.4.7 Automated voicemail messages

Automated voicemail messaging (AVM) involves creating a pre-recorded voice message that customers can hear if they dial a specific number. This is a popular option in emerging markets where literacy rates are low. It also provides an excellent way to capitalise on a celebrity endorsement, since the celebrity can record one message and have it be distributed to callers around the country.

17.4.8 Voice technologies

These days, mobile phones can also be controlled through voice commands. Sophisticated voice-activated applications like Siri on the iPhone allow users to perform complex tasks simply by asking a question or requesting an action out loud. For example, Siri responds to queries like "What is the weather like in Denver?" and "Can you move my 9am meeting to lunch time?" by analysing the key words used and returning the correct information, or completing the task. You can find out more about Siri here: www.apple.com/ios/siri.

There are also less-complex versions of voice-based control, for example in Google search, where the user can speak a query rather than typing it (which is beneficial on mobile, considering the typical hassle of typing on a small device).

Another mobile voice technology is interactive voice response (IVR). IVR is used in automated telephone systems to navigate through the menus. Rather than pressing a specific key to select an option, the user simply speaks their choice.

Voice technologies are exciting, convenient and easy to use. However, there is still a relatively high rate of inaccuracy in the technology, leading to misunderstood voice inputs and frustrations.

17.5 Location and mobile

Convenience and location are two cornerstones of the mobile marketing world. If services and useful information can be shared based on a user's location, the possibilities for conversion naturally increase. The more contextually relevant your marketing message is to the user, the more likely they are to engage.

A survey conducted by the Pew Internet and American Life Project found that 74% of smartphone users use their mobile phones to find locations. Google found that 68% of mobile users visited the business after searching for it on a smartphone (Google, 2012). And 67% of users surveyed shared that they would be more likely to buy if the website were designed for mobile devices (Google, 2012).

17.5.1 Geo-location

Combining mobile marketing techniques with geo-location can go a long way in providing customers with what they need.

There are a few different scenarios possible for implementing location in your mobile marketing campaigns. Location-targeted search offers some significant benefits. If searching for a local doctor, for example, it would be immensely useful to find the closest one and a map to his or her location in the first listed result. Localised news results could also offer a better user experience for someone conducting a mobile news search. Combining short codes or QR codes with print advertising in an area is another way to provide consumers with geo-relevant information. A QR code in a store or on a poster could offer a discount voucher to someone coming to the local retail outlet, for example.

NOTE

Google Free Zone is another example of a zero-rated service. It allows people in specific countries to access Gmail, Google+ and Google search on mobile without incurring any data costs.

To reach customers in areas of the world where data is scarcer and more expensive, some online services are turning towards a 'zero rating' system – which means that users don't pay for data when accessing that particular service.

For example, Facebook launched its Facebook Zero service in Africa to massive success. Accessing the simple, text-based website was free to all users. Just 18 months after launching, the number of Facebook users in Africa had increased by 114% (Mims, 2012).

When combined with location awareness, mobile search offers a targeted user experience.

If a website can detect what device someone is using and where they are, content customised to their location could be delivered, either automatically or after user input.

17.5.2 Mobile social networks

What are mobile social networks? Online social networks have extended their presence to mobile phones.

- m.facebook.com
- m.twitter.com

In addition, there are several social networks created specifically for mobile devices and centred on the potential of location-specific awareness. One example is Instagram (instagram.com).

One successful example of mobile social networking is Mxit. This South African company runs a messaging and social networking platform that is popular among the South African youth. With 7.5 million monthly active users (McConnachie, 2013), Mxit is a cheaper messaging alternative to standard SMS. In addition to the chat rooms in which users interact, Mxit offers brands the option to sell multimedia downloads and customised skins, and to create branded chat rooms for specific competitions or promotions. Mxit has its own currency – Moola – which enables purchases via Mxit's Tradepost commerce system. This ties in with Toni Ahonen's important observation about mobile devices having a built-in payment system – after all, Moola can be purchased using prepaid airtime and then spent on games, images, music tracks and more.

Many social media and social networking sites are also adopting and encouraging geo-tagging as a way for users to comment on posts. Services such as Foursquare (www.foursquare.com) and Facebook encourage users to 'check in' when they are at various locations. Foursquare also offers a social incentive to check in at locations – the people who visit the most become the 'Mayor' and can get cash discounts or vouchers at participating locations.

Figure 8. ***A super mayor badge from Foursquare.***

Coffee giant Starbucks and clothing brand Gap are two brands that make frequent use of Foursquare for deals, limited-time offers and loyalty rewards. Have a look at their listings here: foursquare.com/starbucks and foursquare.com/gap.

Some platforms allow people to tag locations with notes or information, and to let their friends or contacts know where they are. Some users prefer not to do this, but for others, the ability to comment on their daily lives is exciting and connects them with people who may not be physically near them through content.

Mobile social networks can also have operational value, especially from a sales and leads perspective. As getting work done becomes more important than where it is done, communication tools are more and more essential to CRM. And mobile devices lie at the centre of this.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Search Engine Optimisation* chapter.

As the different networks evolve, it is worth considering the potential of social search as well. Product or brand searches based around social networks and location can be a powerful tool: personal referrals are now combined with location-specific information.

Because of the prevalence of mobile, there is a strong strategic incentive to provide free, fast Wi-Fi networks to customers who visit physical retail outlets, restaurants or shopping centres. Not only does this provide a great selling point, it also gives the marketer a channel to communicate with and gain information from customers. For example, this lets you track their mobile behaviour and location (with permission, of course), send coupons and offers, engage in CRM-related questionnaires, provide helpful information and support, and more.

17.5.3 Considerations for location-based mobile marketing

Location-based mobile marketing naturally presents a number of concerns and challenges when it comes to user privacy. No one wants their location published without their permission, and notifications that suddenly pop up in certain areas could prove highly annoying if control doesn't remain in the hands of the user.

For this reason, marketers need to provide a method for people to unsubscribe. You could consider contacting users through alternative channels in order to check up on the service and allow them to customise the kinds of messages they receive.

It must be said, however, that implementation has not always lived up to potential. Possibilities such as geographic report-backs on the efficacy of campaigns in certain areas could be immensely valuable, but all of these services and ideas need input from mobile operators, advertising networks and marketing agencies. Network operators often closely guard all user information. Not all devices have the same capabilities of revealing their location. In other words, options seem endless, but beware of the hype.

17.6 Mobile commerce

Mobile commerce covers a wide range of ways in which users can buy things through their mobile devices – whether it's shopping from the mobile browser, paying with airtime for apps and games, or using the phone's built-in technology at the point of sale.

Setting up a successful mobile commerce experience requires that you consider who your mobile customers are. What sorts of devices do they typically own? Are they comfortable with shopping online in general, and have they bought items on their mobile phones? Use these answers to inform your strategy.

Since there are so many physical, electronic and mobile payment options available, ensure that you cater to your market by providing a wide range of popular payment options. Do some research to discover what consumers in your region are using.

NOTE

One interesting mobile payment tool is Square (squareup.com) - it consists of a small device that attaches to the merchant's mobile phone, allowing them to swipe and process credit card purchases on the spot.

17.6.1 Mobile shopping

Mobile shopping has become hugely popular because of the flexibility and immediacy of the mobile device – by 2014, a quarter of Chinese smartphone and tablet users will shop online. This is twice as many as the rest of the world – still a large number (Naidu-Ghelani, 2013).

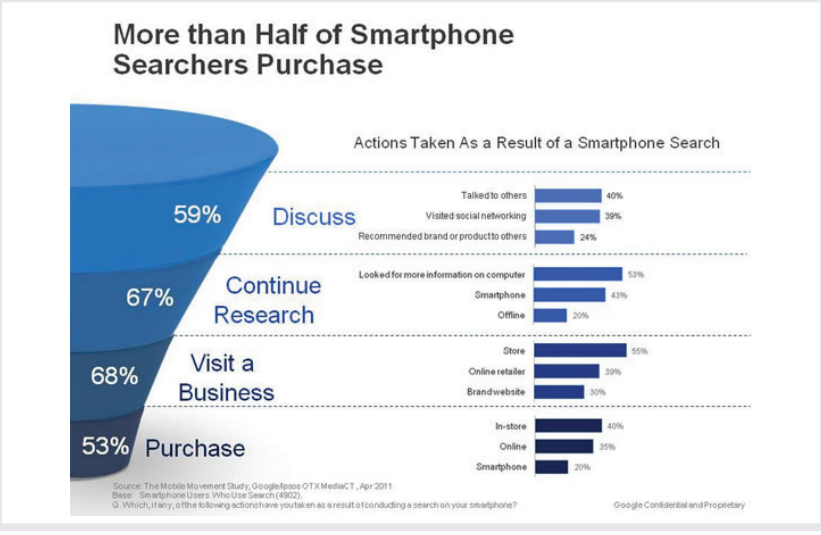

Figure 9. ***Over half of smartphone searchers make purchases. (Image source: Google/Ipsos).***

Users can purchase goods or services wherever they are via the mobile web. They are also able to search for and compare products and prices. A spokesperson for eBay finds that mobile users follow through with purchases more often than desktop users do. A quarter of their new customers are on mobile devices (Kucera, 2013).

What do people buy online?

People buy most things online. While the final purchase of a car may be uncommon, the research that goes into making this purchasing decision is often rooted in the online and mobile space.

Apps and music are currently the most popular items bought through mobile devices, most likely because they involve smaller payments and less risk (Lightspeed Research, 2010). This does not mean that other categories remain unexplored, however. The graphic below demonstrates that entertainment and content items dominate as the most popular currently.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Market Research* chapter.

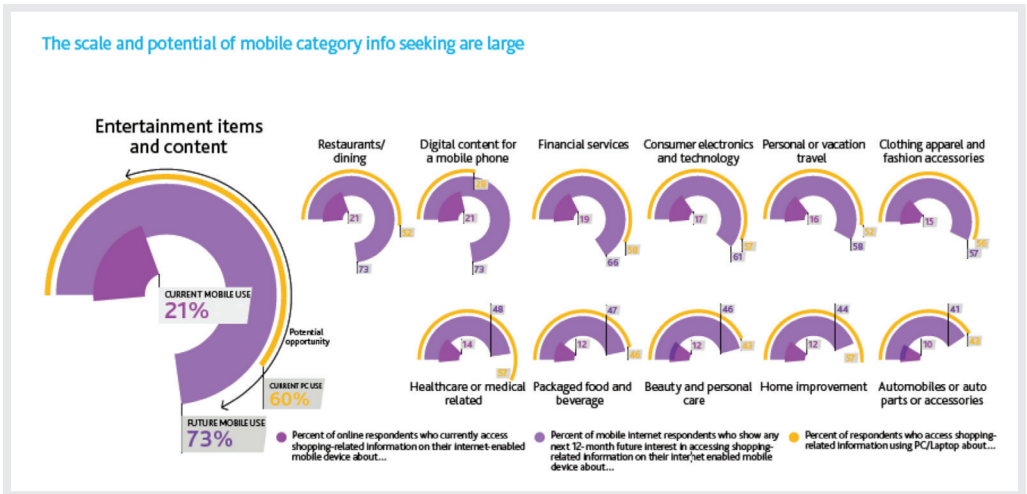

Figure 10. ***Types of goods purchased over mobile phones. (Nielsen/Yahoo, 2011)***

There are various factors that influence a mobile shopper's behaviour and interests. The device and its interface, as well the context within which shopping is explored, have a significant impact on a mobile user's actions. Nielsen and Yahoo conducted research into mobile shopping and established nine mobile principles that define a user's mobile shopping experience (Nielsen, 2011).

These are:

1. **Location** – Mobile ads should be relevant to a user's current location.
2. **Goal orientation** – Users actively shop and look up category information and know what they need to do and how to achieve it.

3. **Attentiveness** – Users often give their full attention to category information.
4. **Killing time** – Users access content because they are bored.
5. **Taking my time** – Consumers use as much time as they need to complete a task.
6. **Urgency** – Users experience a sense of urgency about completing a task.
7. **Routine** – Users embrace the same method or process used to access category information.
8. **Passion** – They display a sense of enthusiasm about category information.
9. **Trust and security** – Users want to access a trusted and secure source.

Mobile commerce best practices

When building any mobile experience, and especially a mobile store, prioritise the user experience above everything else. Mobile users are purpose driven, search orientated, and clear on exactly what they are trying to locate – so make it as easy as possible for them to achieve their goal – which is to find and purchase an item.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *User Experience Design* chapter.

- Include a prominent search bar and incorporate auto-suggest to make searching easier and quicker.
- Keep the menu short and clear, with only the most important items displayed. Focus on goals rather than simply long lists of items or categories.
- Make it easy to navigate by incorporating a prominent 'back' button at the top of every page.
- Lay out individual product pages simply, with the most important information at the top and a clear 'buy' button visible.
- Include an 'add to wishlist' or 'save this' button so that customers can find their favourite items later. This is especially handy if you also have a full eCommerce site, since customers can browse and research on mobile and then evaluate their purchases later at their desktop computers.
- Use images to draw attention and illustrate products.
- Allow users to sort search results so that they can quickly find exactly what they want.
- Ensure that users do not have to register to make a purchase – many will abandon the process if they are forced to fill out a complex form on the small screen.

NOTE

However, images can increase a site's loading time, so ensure you keep their file sizes low.

Build the payment system with good security, and reassure users that their details are secure – after all, most people are afraid of transacting on mobile because of security concerns. Include a privacy policy and information about the security measures you have taken for users who want to access this information.

If you want to venture into mobile commerce, it is recommended that you start by developing a mobi site before you spend time and money creating a dedicated store application. Not only are people more likely to find you through web search, but the barriers for entry are much lower, since a site does not require the user to download anything. Program your full eCommerce site to redirect mobile customers to the mobi site to improve their experience.

Finally, promote your mCommerce platform across your other media (your website, social media channels and offline promotions). Offering a special mobile-only coupon can drive traffic to this platform and will make customers feel more at ease, since they are being directed there from more trusted sources. You can also experiment with QR codes, depending on whether your market is aware of and comfortable with this technology.

17.6.2 Near-Field Communication and mobile wallets

Near-Field Communication (NFC) technology allows data to be transferred over short distances through the use of data chips. This allows consumers to make payments on the spot by simply swiping or scanning their mobile device. In order for NFC to work, the consumer must have a chip in their mobile device and the merchant must have the hardware to scan that chip. NFC has become more common on smartphones, with almost 100 million mobile devices shipped in 2012 including the technology; however, it is not included on Apple's iPhones yet (McNulty, 2013).

A mobile wallet is a way of storing currency (or other payment methods, such as credit cards or PayPal account details) on a mobile device and then using the device to make payments. NFC is the most common technology used for this. Mobile wallets are typically used to make small purchases, such as movie tickets, snacks from vending machines and public transport tickets, but can also be used for bigger purchases in place of a credit card.

Figure 11. *Using a mobile phone to make an NFC payment. (Jargon Media, 2011)*

NFC payment has the potential to provide a seamless experience for the user. And it can potentially be used for far more than just payments – such as personal identification, loyalty cards, membership cards, and perhaps even the keys to your home or car.

NOTE

Some public transport networks use NFC to make travelling quicker. For example, the Oyster system allows Londoners to swipe an NFC-enabled smartcard every time they want to take a bus, tube, tram or train.

17.6.3 Mobile ticketing and coupons

Mobile ticketing allows consumers to use their mobile devices to purchase and receive tickets for things such as their daily commute, secure parking, and concert seats.

Once a ticket has been purchased, a barcode, password or other identifiable piece of data is sent to the phone via SMS or MMS, and presented at the ticketing station. Mobile barcodes can be scanned quickly, making this paperless administration a lot easier, cheaper and more easily accessible.

Mobile coupons work in a similar way. Customers can receive a coupon from the brand – for example, by subscribing to an SMS marketing list, as a reward for completing a USSD survey, or simply by walking near a location-based mobile offer in a store window. Coupons are excellent for driving sales, offering free trials, retaining customers and more – especially among customers in the young, mobile-native demographics.

According to Juniper Research, mobile ticketing transactions will quadruple to 23 billion in 2016, from just 4 billion in 2011 (Juniper Research, 2012).

17.6.4 Mobile currency

This type of payment allows consumers to pay via a mobile phone using either e-currency or a mobile voucher. These are governed by the banking laws within a specific country. The major difference is the ability to draw money from the system. For merchants to make the most of these services, they must have online shopping enabled and register with the particular service.

There are various options available, such as M-Pesa, which is available in many African countries. For developing regions such as Africa – where 95% of adults do not have bank accounts (Heinrich, 2012), but almost all have access to a mobile phone – this is a significant benefit.

One of the key benefits of M-Pesa is that money can be sent by SMS or USSD, meaning that an Internet connection is not required. M-Pesa users can send e-money to other mobile users, regardless of their network provider. These mobile users can then convert the e-money back into cash via an M-Pesa outlet or a Nedbank ATM. Outlets are available at retail stores, Nedbank branches and elsewhere. This type of currency can work for even the most basic phone.

17.6.5 Carrier-based payments

Carrier-based payments make use of expensive premium messages. This means that mobile devices can be used to make or receive payments. All a user has to do is provide the merchant with his or her mobile number for the transaction. They are then sent a special code via an SMS and billed for the cost of this premium SMS from their airtime balance. The carrier will then receive payment and the merchant will get a portion of this payment. Premium messages are usually used to sell mobile content such as ringtones, games, images, wallpapers and music.

17.6.6 Airtime as currency

It is increasingly common for airtime to be used as a form of currency, especially in developing nations where traditional infrastructure is less freely available. As other payment options develop, this may change, but for the moment the significance of this method should not be ignored. Airtime has immense value for individuals who depend on their mobile devices for access to a number of services and who opt for prepaid rather than contract options for financial reasons.

17.6.7 Mobile banking

NOTE

Have you ever used mobile banking? Do you consider it more or less secure than banking on a desktop computer?

Mobile banking services are available through different mobile channels:

- **Mobile web**: Mobile web banking is when mobile users gain access to modified web versions of the bank's online site. This means that users have full access to their accounts in order to make payments, transfer funds and more. Mobile banking through this channel doesn't usually cost the user more than the online banking subscription.
- **Mobile app**: Mobile banking applications give users the ability to access a variety of account features through simple mobile-friendly processes. Through apps, users will have full access to their accounts.
- **Mobile text**: Mobile banking can also be conducted via SMS and USSD. This is useful for non-smartphone users. Mobile text banking involves banks sending alerts to customers via SMS, or allowing them to perform simple tasks, like transfers, via USSD. Alerts can be sent for account balances, payments, direct deposits, and other account activity. These services can be free or available at an additional cost, depending on the provider. The text messages themselves are for the consumer's cost with their mobile phone carriers.

17.7 Integrating mobile into online marketing

As you may have noticed, many of the chapters in this book discuss mobile applications or variations of standard online marketing strategies. We've done things this way because mobile is a mindset, not a specific and separate channel – so it should always be taken into account as a facet of any strategy you implement.

To recap, here are some of the key mobile implementations you can consider – have a look in the relevant chapters for more:

- User experience
- Email marketing
- Social media
- Mobile advertising
- Search advertising
- Search engine optimisation

17.8 Augmented reality

Augmented reality (AR) is a variation of virtual reality. Rather than immersing the user in a virtual world, however, AR takes computer graphics and superimposes them into 'reality' – the physical space around the person operating an AR device. These graphics can be 3D images or simply information tags about a location.

Google Glass is an exciting development in AR – this pair of glasses gives the viewer a digital data overlay over the real world.

While AR devices are relatively new, they do have a history outside their use in mobile. They can and have been used in medicine (superimposing surgical information onto a patient's body), architecture (superimposing virtual buildings into a space where they are yet to be built), or for long-distance collaboration where participants can't be in the same room.

Mobile-controlled concert in Japan

In 2013, Tokyo's Shiba Park played home to a one-of-a-kind concert – one controlled entirely by the audience's mobile phones. Concertgoers were asked to download the Odoroki app, which was specially built to enable interactions with one's environment. The area was turned into a mobile-operated theme park. Through interacting with the app, visitors could control vehicles, fountains, lighting, stage performances and even the illuminations on the city's iconic Tokyo Tower (Japan Trends, 2013).

17.8.1 Augmented reality in brand communications

The first use of AR in advertising was by HIT Lab NZ and Saatchi & Saatchi in 2005 for an application for the Wellington Zoo, which allowed users to view virtual animals by pointing their phone cameras at printed bar codes (Heinrich, 2012).

At present, applications have been interesting but often more gimmicky than useful. Some of the examples include an Ikea campaign that allowed people to view virtual versions of their furniture in their homes through their phone cameras (Butcher, 2010).

17.8.2 The future of augmented reality

NOTE

Do some research into the latest developments in AR technology - how much has changed since this textbook was published?

AR is relatively new and still has a long way to go. Barriers such as development costs and user education have held it back, but with smartphones and specialised AR devices becoming more common, the potential for AR applications is increasing as well.

Going forward, there are a number of challenges AR faces: investment in development and the potential for serious privacy concerns are the most notable. The image below illustrates what is possible when mobile, advertising, and geographical location are combined – exciting stuff.

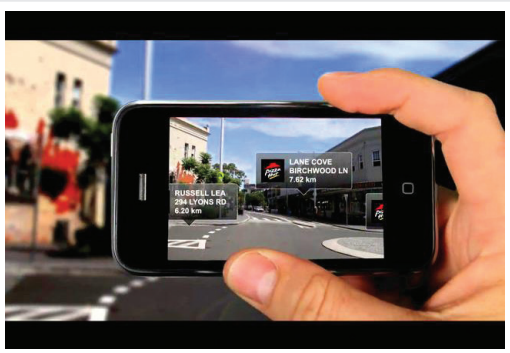

Figure 12. *Augmented reality on a mobile device.*

17.8.3 The quantified self

Another way in which mobile devices are adding a digital layer to the real world is through the trend of the 'quantified self', also referred to as personal analytics. In essence, this is the practice of using mobile devices to measure your physical behaviours in order to improve health, better understand your habits, get fitter and measure your daily life in more detail.

Some examples of this include:

- Step counters built in to mobile phones to measure how active you are
- Sleep-tracking apps that show how peacefully you sleep and what nightly rhythms and patterns you display
- Devices like the Nike+ FuelBand that measure exercise and calories burned
- Time-tracking apps to show how much time you spend reading emails, on social media, and more

17.9 Mobile analytics

Analytics for mobile sites and applications is a relatively young field, but given that anyone investing in a new technology is interested in return on investment, being able to track the effectiveness of your campaign is an essential part of mobile marketing.

Traditional analytics, focusing on the web rather than the mobile web, has come a long way in providing us with information about what keywords brought users to our sites, which referrers were used, and how long people spent on a page, as well as a number of other metrics. Through various tools, you can gain insight into your users' actions and from there deduce information about their intent, using this to refine your web presence and campaigns.

NOTE

Read more about this in the *Data Analytics* chapter.

While some would argue that both spheres face data collection challenges, there is an understanding that mobile analytics presents more challenges in terms of sourcing reliable data.

The first thing to acknowledge is that users of mobile analytics may be looking for different kinds of information. Given design challenges, primary information would include what device is being used, what network is being used, what browser is used, and then information about screen size.

Judah Phillips of Metrics Insider lists the following challenges for mobile analytics:

- **Not all mobile browsers support JavaScript**, meaning that the most common method for collecting data is not available on a lot of mobile devices. Mobile analytics packages have had to come up with alternative implementation methods such as packet-sniffers and accessing log files.
- **Handset capability detection** can be a challenge for some packages, and is not offered as a rule. If this information is important for your site, you may need to investigate carefully the analytics package you use.

Beyond this, however, there are a number of tools that have developed to provide mobile analytics data. Some of the ones most often discussed include the offerings from AdMob and Google Analytics, which are both available for free. Google Analytics for mobile offers options for tracking iPhone and Android applications, and for tracking mobile websites. Its server-side tracking options can be used to track sites on phones that don't support JavaScript.

17.10 Advantages and challenges

The mobile phone has many benefits but also comes with its own challenges. Many mobile marketing mediums need little audience education, but marketers need to be careful when creating more complicated campaigns and applications. If there is an extensive education process required in order for a campaign to succeed, it probably needs to be rethought.

Because the mobile phone is so personal, permission and privacy need to be at the core of any mobile campaign. Unlike the situation with email or web pages, where there is space available on screen to explain privacy and permission, there is very little real estate on a mobile device to do so. Ensure that you have very clear permission to market to the phone numbers on your database and that it is easy for users to opt out of receiving your messages.

NOTE

How can responsive web design help meet the challenge of non-standard mobile devices?

Mobile devices are even less standard than PCs. Not only do device models present myriad screen sizes; there are also several operating systems and browsers that are used. This can make standardising websites and campaign materials a challenge.

Mobile devices usually have a small screen and keypad or touch interface. When it comes to the mobile web, consider that devices do not have a mouse and full keyboard. These limited navigation options mean that inputting information and browsing can be harder.

17.11 Case study – Carling Black Label's "Be the Coach"

17.11.1 One-line summary

Carling Black Label engaged soccer fans with an innovative and successful mobile campaign tailored for feature phones.

17.11.2 The problem

Carling Black Label, a well-known South African beer brand, wanted to engage its market in an unprecedented way. The target market they wanted to reach had a low Internet penetration rate, but had a high rate of mobile access. They knew that many Black Label drinkers are also passionate soccer fans – who, like all fans around the world, thought that perhaps they could do a good job at coaching their favourite team, Kaiser Chiefs.

17.11.3 The solution

The brand identified that their target audience was active on mobile, but typically owned lower-end feature phones, so any mobile marketing campaign had to take this into account.

To create a feeling of involvement in the sport, Black Label created the "Be the Coach" campaign. Using mobile devices, fans could choose players for the team and even substitute a player right in the middle of a match. The campaign was advertised on Black Label bottles, TV and radio, as well as other media.

Fans used the code on the inside of the beer bottle cap to participate. Communicating through USSD, they voted on which players to include, and then participated during the live match by choosing which players should be substituted.

A mobile site was also purpose-built for the campaign, where team, player and voting information could be viewed, and fans could access the "Be the Coach" Facebook and Twitter profiles. Participants used their mobile numbers to sign in to the site; this low barrier to entry made the campaign easily accessible. Web-enabled mobile devices could access the campaign information through the site in real time.

Facebook ads, display ads and digital PR were also used to promote the campaign. Another important mobile aspect was the use of Mxit. The campaign was advertised for two weeks on this portal. Fans could create a "Be the Coach" profile on Mxit and visit the mobile site from there.

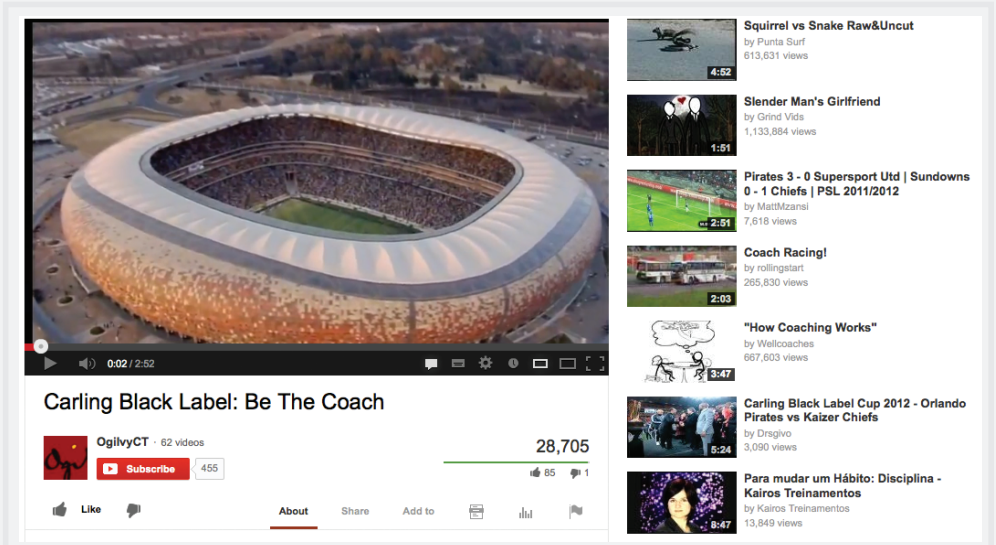

Figure 13. *A video for the "Be the Coach" campaign.*

17.11.4 The results

Over seven weeks of voting, the campaign created intense discussion among fans, players, coaches and journalists. It also garnered some incredibly impressive results:

- Fans voted more than 10.5 million times over the seven-week voting period.
- A record 85 000 tickets to the game were sold, and millions more watched from home.
- The Facebook and Twitter accounts grew by 450% and 600% respectively.
- The equivalent PR value of all this attention came in at over R83 million.
- The mobi site had 31 088 visitors (18 405 of these were unique), and users visited 6.97 pages on average, with an average time on site of 5 minutes 30 seconds.

On the day of the game, rival team Orlando Pirates won, but the fans did get to "Be the Coach" for Kaiser Chiefs (Ogilvy & Mather South Africa, n.d.).

17.12 The bigger picture

Mobile communications should always be considered in context within your other marketing communications. The mobile channel is not a separate one, but rather one that can be accessed and integrated with many other forms of communication.

One of mobile's powerful characteristics is its ability to stitch media together – especially online and offline marketing channels, since the mobile device can be physically located in the real-world space, and access the digital world at the same time.

We've listed earlier in this chapter some of the many marketing tactics of which mobile can form part. Mobile should also be a central consideration in your marketing and content strategy – consider the context of the user and how mobile content is consumed differently.

Mobile is also excellent in CRM and customer support, where it provides an always-on, always accessible channel to answer queries, resolve issues and reward customers.

17.13 Summary

The mobile device cannot be ignored as an important tool in any marketing campaign. There are messaging capabilities unique to mobile that can be very effective – from SMS to USSD and Bluetooth.

Exciting technological developments also open up the opportunities for interactive campaigns and mobile experiences. Although not widely adopted yet, QR codes can be the point of interaction that connects other media to the mobile device. Augmented reality campaigns can also create a rich interactive experience for a user by adding a layer of information to the real world.

As with any digital marketing approach, planning is vital. While mobile can offer a dazzling array of marketing and communication opportunities, knowing your audience will help you to best plan those most suited to your market and your campaign.

17.14 Case study questions

1. Why was USSD the best choice for this campaign?
2. Describe how the device combined real world experiences with digital options.
3. Are there any other mobile marketing options that you would have incorporated into this campaign?

17.15 Chapter questions

1. What makes SMS such a powerful marketing medium?
2. When is it a good idea to invest in an augmented reality application for your brand?
3. What are the main benefits and concerns of mobile advertising?
4. How would you go about deciding which engagement method is the best one for your target market?

17.16 Further reading

mobithinking.com – mobiThinking offers the latest stats and research into the rapidly changing mobile world.

www.comscore.com – comScore is one of the leading digital marketing websites, regularly releasing white papers and statistics.

www.mobilemarketer.com – Mobile Marketer, as the name implies, is geared heavily towards different forms of mobile marketing. Keep an eye on this site for news and developments in this industry.

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